



No end to suffering

India must enlist more support against Pakistan's bombing of Afghanistan

As the U.S.-Israel war against Iran rages, India's western frontiers have flared up, intensified by recent clashes between Pakistan and Afghanistan forces on the Durand Line. On Tuesday, Pakistani airstrikes tragically killed at least 400 Afghans at a drug treatment and rehabilitation centre. Pakistan, which has accused the Taliban administration of harbouring the Tehreek e Taliban Pakistan (TTP) and supporting its terror attacks on Pakistan, denied Afghanistan's accusations, claiming that its strikes had only targeted "military installations". Despite the denial, it is clear from visuals that the Omid Rehabilitation Facility in Kabul was destroyed. In an extremely strong statement, India condemned what it called Pakistan's "cowardly" targeting of a hospital, rejecting its denial as a cover-up for a "massacre", and called for an international inquiry. The Pakistan-Afghanistan conflict, which has been simmering for over a year, escalated in February when the Pakistan Air Force struck Taliban bases in Kabul, Kandahar, and Paktia in what it called Operation Ghazab Lil Haq (Righteous Fury). Tensions have also risen after TTP attacks killed 11 soldiers and a child in Bajaur and 32 people in an Islamabad mosque following a suicide bombing. Pakistan has also been angered by closer India-Afghanistan ties and New Delhi's hosting of Taliban ministers, accusing the Taliban of turning Afghanistan into an "Indian colony" – a turnaround from its support in 2021, for the Taliban's rise to power in Kabul. Apart from its continued tensions and hatred of India, and now Afghanistan, Pakistan possibly benefits from the global focus on the U.S.-Israel war with Iran. The U.S.'s actions here and its statement expressing support for Pakistan's "right to defend itself against Taliban attacks", has also imbued Pakistan's generals with a sense of impunity to strike targets in Afghanistan at will.

New Delhi could be permitted some sense of 'payback' as Islamabad's fight against cross-border terrorism from Afghanistan mirrors India's problems with Pakistan. The constraints on Pakistan's military in a two-front situation with India and Afghanistan, compounded by a transnational war on the third front, may also be the source of some relief for India. With no dialogue with Pakistan, and the limited dialogue with a Taliban regime it deals with but does not formally recognise, India's diplomatic role in the conflict is limited. However, it must enlist other SCO members that have been concerned over the outbreak of an "open war" between Pakistan and Afghanistan, to intervene. The region is already suffering from trade, energy and travel restrictions as a result of the West Asia war, to risk more volatility and loss of lives, particularly in Afghanistan, where the vulnerable, especially women, have suffered the most.

Fire and more fire

India must treat hospital fire safety as an issue of criminal accountability

Cuttack is not an anomaly. It is the latest entry in a ledger of preventable deaths in Indian hospital ICUs. In 2016, 22 people died in a fire at a private hospital ICU in Bhubaneswar, which did not have the mandatory fire safety clearance. Following this tragedy, fire safety audits were made compulsory for such facilities. Last year, the Odisha government allocated about ₹320 crore for fire safety improvement across hospitals in the State. But this did not prevent the fire at the government SCB Medical College and Hospital, Cuttack, apparently caused by a short circuit in the ICU of the trauma care unit. Some reports suggest the fire may have started in a ventilator, which was later found heavily charred. The accident, which occurred in the early hours of Monday, claimed 12 of the 23 ICU patients. Although the hospital had a firefighting unit, its personnel arrived after more than 30 minutes, reportedly because staff did not alert them early. Additionally, the fire hydrants could not be operated by staff. Nevertheless, water is not the right medium to fight electric fires, which are best extinguished using carbon dioxide, a method that requires trained personnel. Last October, six patients were killed in an ICU fire in Rajasthan. In 2024, newborns died in an ICU fire in Jhansi, Uttar Pradesh. Two similar accidents were reported in Maharashtra in 2021. An audit in Jhansi revealed hazards including exposed wiring, inadequate earthing and electrical circuits not matching power load requirements – the last being a leading cause of electrical fires in India.

ICUs have intrinsic safety risks, as their oxygen-rich environment can turn even a spark into an inferno. ICUs are also packed with electrical equipment, and the personnel are not always well trained in their safe handling. State-of-the-art medical equipment comes with advanced electronics and variable frequency drives that generate what are called "harmonic currents". These currents flow within circuits and typically have no safety devices such as circuit breakers. Harmonics create silent, persistent overheating and insulation degradation and are a severe fire hazard. Today's electrical practice lays down that every time a new ventilator is wheeled into an ICU, the wiring, protection and load capacity must be re-evaluated. Older facilities need an electrical upgrade before cutting edge equipment can be installed. As patients in ICUs are often sedated, intubated, and connected to machines, staff must be trained to ensure their safe evacuation. Until India treats hospital fire safety as a matter of criminal accountability rather than bureaucratic paperwork, the fires will keep burning and the bodies will keep mounting.

NCERT book ban, a chapter on judicial transparency

Max Boot, former Features Editor of *The Wall Street Journal*, authored the seminal study on the United States judiciary, 'Out of Order: Arrogance, Corruption, and Incompetence on the Bench' (1998). Robert H. Bork, former Solicitor General of the United States, wrote the foreword to it with a striking conclusion – "Our Courts are behaving badly and the public, to the degree it can be brought to understand that, will exert force for reform, a reform that must be structural as well as intellectual and moral."

He observed that the book's subtitle sums up a system in distress. The book underscores the critical role that the media and citizens must play while dealing with the judicial institution in a democracy.

In February this year, the Supreme Court of India, faulting what it felt as selective reference to corruption within the judiciary, directed "a complete blanket ban" on a Class eight social science textbook published by the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT). The three-judge Bench, presided over by the Chief Justice of India, further alluded to "an underlying agenda to undermine the institutional authority and demean the dignity of the judiciary".

The Court subsequently ordered that the persons responsible for preparing the passages should be 'disassociated' from future projects by governments and public universities. The Court thus instantly punished them, without due process or hearing. The prohibition by the Court is problematic as it sends critical signals about the shape of India's democracy today.

What appears to have annoyed the Bench were the passages in the book on judicial delay and corruption in judiciary. As per the news report cited by the Court, the textbook has data on the approximate number of pending cases in Indian courts. It refers to the Bangalore Principles of Judicial Conduct, which prescribe values for judicial life. It also discusses the in-house procedures evolved by the Supreme Court and the constitutional mechanism for the removal of errant judges.

An undermining of freedom

By itself, a book ban is the most egregious form of censorship. Such a move directly impacts the right to freedom of speech under Article 19, a solemn promise in the Constitution. This right could be restricted only by a law made by the



Kaleeswaram Raj

is a lawyer in the Supreme Court of India



Thulasi K. Raj

is a lawyer in the Supreme Court of India

The top court's ban on an NCERT textbook exposes gaps in judicial accountability and public trust

state on grounds expressly provided under Article 19(2), such as "the sovereignty and integrity of India, the security of the state, friendly relations with foreign states, public order, decency or morality, or in relation to contempt of court, defamation, or incitement to an offence". There is no law made by the state to justify the ban on the book in question. Judicial orders or judgments do not come under the realm of 'law' made by the state, as understood in the context of Article 19 (*Nareesh Shridhar Mirajkar vs State of Maharashtra*, 1966).

For an act to amount to contempt of court, there must be material that scandalises the authority of the court or prejudices or interferes with judicial proceedings or the administration of justice, as defined under Section 2(c) of the Contempt of Courts Act, 1971. Whether mere references to corruption in the judiciary and case backlogs meet this high threshold for criminal contempt was a question that, unfortunately, did not form part of the Court's deliberations. What was also not examined was whether the statements were too general in nature to suggest any malicious intent to scandalise the Court.

Further, and importantly, going by the scheme of judicial review, courts must put to constitutional scrutiny the law passed by Parliament often violating fundamental rights. When the courts take on the task of book banning, citizens are left without remedy, as constitutional courts are the last resort to safeguard fundamental rights.

Global efforts

In advanced democracies, the credibility of the court is a matter of concern, primarily for the court itself. Transparency International has conducted a number of surveys that show that there is a prevailing notion about judicial corruption. Judiciaries across the world have made efforts to address this problem. In Kenya, the reforms led by Chief Justice Willy Mutunga, between 2011 and 2013, are an illustrative example. During this period, institutions such as judicial ombudspersons, court users' committees, and performance management committees were established.

By 2013, public trust in Kenya in the judiciary had risen to 61%, compared to 27% in 2009. The reforms continued even thereafter. This happened only by acknowledging the issues and trying to address them, rather than suppressing critical voices.

The opportunity in Cameroon to rebalance the WTO

Today, trade is no longer just about economics. It is increasingly used as a geopolitical tool. Tariffs are imposed as pressure tactics, and economic dependence is sometimes used strategically. In this context, the World Trade Organization (WTO)'s Ministerial Conference (MC14), to be held in Yaoundé, Cameroon, Africa (March 26-29, 2026), comes at an important moment. The real issue is not whether the WTO needs reform, but whether it can adapt fast enough to stay relevant in a world moving toward more transactional and power-based trade relations.

WTO in turmoil

The WTO is facing its biggest crisis since its founding in 1995. Its dispute settlement system is still effectively paralysed because the Appellate Body appointments have been stalled for years. This weakens trust in the system, since rules matter only when they can be enforced. At the same time, WTO negotiations have struggled to keep pace with major shifts in global trade. Digital commerce is growing rapidly and now forms a large part of cross-border economic activity. Yet, WTO rules have not evolved at the same pace.

Decision-making has also become slow and difficult. With 166 members at very different levels of development, consensus is hard to reach and cumbersome. As a result, many negotiations produce limited outcomes and long-pending issues remain unresolved.

Meanwhile, geopolitical tensions and the growing use of tariffs as political tools have distorted markets. However, these problems should not be mistaken for irrelevance. Most global trade still operates under WTO rules. If enforceable multilateral rules weaken, global trade would become unpredictable and unstable. Smaller and poorer countries would suffer the most, because they rely on common rules to protect themselves from pressure by stronger economies.

The WTO's challenges are also part of a wider shift in the global order. The Munich Security



Rajeev Ranjan Chaturvedy

is an Associate Professor, heading the School of International Relations and Peace Studies, and founding coordinator of the Centre for Bay of Bengal Studies, Nalanda University, Rajgir, Bihar



Anushka Padmanabh Antrolikar

is a postgraduate scholar at Nalanda University, Rajgir, Bihar

The World Trade Organization's Ministerial Conference must ensure that trade is governed by rules rather than coercion

Report 2026 describes this as a move toward "wrecking-ball politics", where countries prefer disruption and short-term deals instead of gradual institutional reform. In trade, this is visible in the rise of unilateral tariffs, economic coercion and bilateral deals that bypass multilateral commitments. If this continues, rule-based trade could be replaced by ad hoc arrangements shaped mainly by power rather than shared principles.

Global production has changed

Against this backdrop, the MC14 offers a chance not just to fix technical problems but to also restore balance between predictability and fairness. The original balance of rights and obligations in the WTO no longer reflects today's reality. Emerging economies now export advanced and technology-intensive products, climate-related trade measures are expanding, and digital networks are reshaping how global production works.

Rules designed for a late 20th century trading system cannot fully govern a 21st century one.

Reform must start with restoring credibility to enforcement. Without a functioning dispute settlement system, commitments lose their value. Members need to rebuild a binding, trusted mechanism rather than relying mainly on temporary alternatives that lack universal acceptance. A robust dispute-resolution system helps remove politics from conflicts and keeps confidence in multilateral rules.

At the same time, predictability must go hand in hand with fairness. Long-standing disputes over agricultural subsidies, market distortions and unequal openness need transparent solutions. Many developing countries argue that while WTO rules ensure the rule of law, they do not always deliver the rule of justice. In other words, rules may be legally correct but still produce outcomes that feel unequal or developmentally unfair.

Reform should, therefore, improve transparency on subsidies, create credible

In India, the courts including the top court have acknowledged the menace of delay and corruption. Judges have repeatedly warned about the 'bad apples' within the system. The very existence of the in-house Procedure indicates the possibility that a minuscule number of judges may breach their oath.

In *K. Veeraswami vs Union Of India And Others* (1991), the Court categorically held that judges of the High Courts and the Supreme Court fall within the definition of "public servant" for the purposes of prosecution under the Prevention of Corruption Act, while also cautioning against the potential for misuse of this provision by the executive. The Court also said: "We consider that the society's demand for honesty in a judge is exacting and absolute. The standards of judicial behaviour, both on and off the Bench, are normally extremely high. For a Judge to deviate from such standards of honesty and impartiality is to betray the trust reposed on him. No excuse or no legal relativity can condone such betrayal. From the standpoint of justice, the size of the bribe or scope of corruption cannot be the scale for measuring a judge's dishonour. A single dishonest judge not only dishonours himself and disgraces his office but jeopardises the integrity of the entire judicial system."

The need for introspection

Therefore, the need to eradicate corruption and delay is also in the best interest of the judiciary. In the interim order directing the book ban, the Court also pointed out that the "book also chooses not to delve into any of the transformative initiatives and measures pioneered by this Court towards overhauling legal aid mechanisms and streamlining the ease of access to justice". Not addressing all counterarguments might render an opinion potentially incomplete. Yet, that is no reason for banning the view expressed. If the exercise of free speech is required to follow a particular form, the right itself becomes illusory. During judicial deliberations, nobody pointed out that the judiciary, like other organs of the state, must be open to dissent and reform.

The first step in fighting systemic problems such as corruption – whether in the executive or the judiciary – is acknowledging it. After all, it is imperative to curb all kinds of corruption and that civil society is educated about the institutional challenges. A court that continuously reforms itself is the bedrock of any democracy.

responses to distortive practices, and revisit special and differential treatment so that it remains meaningful in today's economic conditions.

Institutional adaptability is also important. The WTO's structures were designed for a smaller and less complex membership, which contributes to today's deadlock. Some countries are moving ahead in smaller groups on issues such as e-commerce, investment facilitation, and services. These efforts can help progress, but they must remain transparent, inclusive and connected to the wider WTO framework. Flexibility should help the system move forward, not divide it. If such initiatives remain open to all members and eventually become part of common WTO rules, they can support reform instead of fragmentation.

Ultimately, WTO reform is not only technical but also normative. The Munich Security Report warns that a world shaped mainly by transactional deals would favour the powerful and leave weaker countries vulnerable.

The choice is clear

The WTO's value lies in preventing exactly this outcome by ensuring that trade is governed by rules rather than coercion. In an era of strategic competition, rules do not weaken sovereignty; they protect countries from economic domination.

The choice before the MC14 is crystal clear. Members can undertake serious reform, preserving the WTO's stabilising core while updating its rules, procedures and developmental balance, or allow the system to drift further into fragmentation. Achieving reform will require political will and shared responsibility.

Rebalancing the WTO is ultimately about securing a workable framework for cooperation in a world where economic interdependence is still unavoidable. If the MC14 seizes this opportunity, it can show that meaningful reform remains the most credible path to sustaining global trade governance.

India’s future demographic challenges

A new report by the International Institute of Migration and Development and the Population Foundation of India titled ‘Unravelling India’s Demographic Future: Population Projections for States and Union Territories, 2021-2051’, underscores the demographic risks that are beginning to surface nationwide. India’s population is projected to increase from 1,355.8 million in 2021 to 1,590.1 million in 2051, with an average annual increase of 0.5%, suggesting a prolonged period of slower population expansion. These figures fall below earlier estimates, strengthening the case that India is unlikely to face the threat of population explosion that once dominated political and academic debates. These projections point to a turning point, where India is poised to move beyond a youth-led, fast-expanding population into an era of a more urban, steadily ageing, and balanced demographic structure.

A problem for schools
The projections point out that the pre-primary school-going population (0-4 years) is expected to dwindle from 113.5 million in 2021 to 8.6 million by the middle of this century. Since most regions in the country are now close to universal primary school enrolments, the demand for new schooling facilities could ease out, especially in the government sector. A sustained drop in fertility could leave the country with an escalating number of ‘uneconomic schools’ (schools with lesser enrolment rates that cannot justify their economic costs), raising the threat of teachers losing their jobs, a trend that the State of Kerala has seen play out for more than three decades.

Evidence from different parts of the country suggests that declining fertility rates have already started influencing schooling requirements, with classrooms adjusting to smaller cohorts. Data from the Unified District



S. Irudaya Rajan
Chair, International Institute of Migration and Development, Kerala



J. Retnakumar
Senior Research Fellow, International Institute of Migration and Development, Kerala

The growing elderly population is set to exert increasing pressure on healthcare and social security, thereby putting a strain on the state’s finances

Information System for Education and the Ministry of Education highlights a significant reduction in the number of government schools over the last decade, with schools dropping from 11.07 lakh in 2014-15 to 10.18 lakh in 2023-24, amounting to a reduction of close to 90,000 schools across the country. This decline has been accompanied by a sharp increase in private schools; their numbers grew from 2.88 lakh to 3.31 lakh over the same period, an increase of 43,000 schools.

While falling birth rates have led to a reduction in enrolments and closure of government schools, smaller families and improved capacity to afford education have propelled the demand for private schools. Many parents choose private schools in the hope of giving their wards the education they never had in life, nudged by social pressure and a common perception that government schools generally fall short on quality compared to private schools.

Greying population
As the demographic dividend largely depends on the working age population (15-59), a relatively higher proportion of this specific group can lead to faster economic growth, a dynamic evident in the development phases of several countries, including China, Japan, and South Korea. India has one of the world’s largest workforces, rising from 833.8 million (65.2%) in 2021 to a projected peak level of 1,009.0 million (65.5%) in 2041, before declining to 998.1 million (62.8%) by 2051. There is an impending concern that the demographic dividend window will close after 2041, highlighting the urgency of leveraging it before its contribution to economic growth starts to diminish. Nevertheless, close to six out of every 10 persons in the country are expected to be part of the workforce by 2051, which is an encouraging sign.

However, India’s population is ageing. In 2021, India’s elderly

population (60+) stood at 130.5 million or 9.62% of the population. By 2051, this number is projected to touch 325.3 million (20.5%), highlighting that there will be a profound increment in the ageing population. The median age, a measure that splits the population evenly by age, is projected to climb from 28 years in 2021 to 40 by 2051, signalling India’s shift towards a more advanced stage of demographic transition. The growing elderly population is set to exert increasing pressure on healthcare and social security, thereby putting a strain on the state’s finances.

Policy signals
The declining child population is expected to offer a better teacher-pupil ratio and expand infrastructural facilities in schools. Further, declining birth rates reduce demand for maternity care, allowing the healthcare system to rationalise the use of resources and offer better quality care. Though fertility levels have been falling, continued investments are required for family planning and to prevent unintended pregnancies, as well as reduce infertility and ensure the reproductive rights of women.

India needs to overhaul its education and skill development system to cope with modern-day challenges. It should also equip the younger generation to seize new opportunities before our demographic leverage disappears in the coming decades. The decline in the working-age population can be offset by bringing in more women to formal work (gender dividend) and by expanding access to better-quality employment. With the rapid growth of the elderly population, India’s financial and healthcare systems, especially geriatric care, must be redesigned to support the growing needs of elderly citizens. At the same time, this creates a strong potential for a thriving silver economy, and could help in unlocking a second demographic dividend in the future.

A plausible three-cornered fight

The third player in Tamil Nadu electoral politics has always been a disruptor

STATE OF PLAY

T. Ramakrishnan
ramakrishnan.t@thehindu.co.in



For the past one week or so, the political arena in Tamil Nadu has been dominated by reports of frenzied attempts to bring the fledgling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), headed by popular film star Vijay, under the fold of the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK)-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA). Talks of the TVK negotiating its entry into the NDA was laid to rest by party functionaries earlier this week. Leaders of the AIADMK and its ally, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which was said to be keen on roping in the TVK, also denied that talks were held in this regard. Political circles were abuzz with the speculation that the BJP was trying to bring the TVK into the NDA fold, as soon as the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and the Congress signed an electoral pact on March 4, after days of uncertainty and hard bargaining.

When the talks between the Dravidian major and the national party were on, there was a lot of noise about the possibility of the Congress ditching its long-standing ally in favour of the TVK. Once this issue became irrelevant, media attention turned to the theory of TVK joining hands with the AIADMK and the BJP. In October 2024, Mr. Vijay said that he was open to not only an alliance, but also to the idea of sharing power.

Luring in the TVK
What fuelled speculation was the perception that given the arithmetic strength of the DMK-led Secular Progressive

Alliance (SPA), the NDA would not be able to defeat the SPA. This was based on the fact that in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, the SPA secured 47% of votes polled while the AIADMK and its ally, the Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK) netted 23% and the BJP-led NDA, 18.24% (now, the DMDK is a constituent of the SPA). As per an estimate, even after giving allowance for the political developments for and against the SPA in the last two years, the NDA still requires a minimum of five percentage points to put up a tough fight. Only the TVK can bridge this gap in vote share.

Of course, another reason cited for the alliance is that all the three major parties – the AIADMK, the BJP and the TVK – have the same goal of defeating the DMK. After all, at one stage, the first two had openly courted the TVK. About 10 days after the tragic stampede at the TVK leader’s rally in Karur in September 2025, which claimed 41 lives, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami, during his visit to Namakkal, remarked that “a beginning” had been made for the alliance. He made this observation in reference to a few people holding up the TVK flag at the meeting.

Even as Mr. Vijay began holding interviews, on March 10, with aspirants for the Assembly election at the party headquarters in Panaiyur on the outskirts of Chennai, me-

dia circles were abuzz about alliance talks. Mr. Vijay’s scheduled visit to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) office in New Delhi on March 15 was linked to the much-speculated deal. Even though the party’s high-level administrative committee chief coordinator K.A. Sengottaiyan on March 12 clarified that his organisation would go to the polls alone, political circles were agog with speculation that a majority of the TVK district secretaries supported joining the NDA. This was reportedly conveyed during a virtual interaction with the party general secretary ‘Bussy’ N. Anand. As of today, TVK’s office-bearers have not denied that any such interaction took place, even though they rebut reports of holding negotiations for the alliance.

‘Fancy offers’
Addressing a public meeting on March 17, TVK general secretary Aadhav Arjuna, regarded as one of the key functionaries of the party, claimed that “fancy offers” – 90 assembly seats and the post of Chief Minister for one half of the Assembly term of five years – had been made to his party but Mr. Vijay was “very firm” in rejecting them, and that the party would stand by religious minorities. But, he did not state who made the offer. On Wednesday evening, the TVK chief reiterated at an iftar event that his party would not compromise on secularism and social justice.

Even though there is still time for more alliance drama, a three-cornered fight looks imminent. As in the past, the third force is bound to be a disruptor. It is to be seen which formation – the SPA or the NDA – benefits from the solo performance of Mr. Vijay and his colleagues.

Children have borne the brunt of Israel-U.S. aggression

Israel accounted for about 41% of all external attacks that ended with a child fatality, while the U.S. accounted for 21% of such attacks

DATA POINT

Sambavi Parthasarathy
Nivedha M.

On the morning of February 28, as hundreds of young girls were attending their classes in Minab’s Shajareh Tayyebah school, the building was struck by a missile.

Residents and rescuers, who rushed to help seeing black smoke rising from the school, found blood stained backpacks, severed arms, and dead children buried under piles of rubble.

The school was likely struck by one of the U.S.’s Tomahawk cruise missiles, claimed to be one of the most precise guided weapons in the world. The school was one of the casualties in the targeted attacks by the U.S. on Iran, in conjunction with Israel.

Later reports confirmed that around 168 children, mostly aged between seven and 12, were killed in the attack. The school was located adjacent to a naval compound operated by the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC).

Though U.S. President Donald Trump initially suggested that Iran itself – despite not having Tomahawk missiles – may have been responsible for these attacks, media reports and the U.S.’s preliminary military investigations suggest the attack was a result of the U.S.’s use of outdated targeting data.

The Pentagon elevated its probe into the matter last week. A UN inquiry is also underway to investigate the fatal strike. Amnesty International, this week, said that the strike points to a failure by the U.S. forces to take feasible precautions to avoid civilian harm.

A war on children

However, the girls in Minab weren’t the only ones who paid the price of the ongoing war. More children are estimated to have been killed in the daily strikes launched by the U.S. and Israel on

Iran in separate instances.

Less than two thousand kilometres away, in Lebanon, more than a hundred children have been killed by Israel’s campaign since March 2. Reports indicate that Israeli airstrikes have completely wiped out generations of families in the country in less than two weeks. The death toll due to the ongoing conflict in Lebanon is reported to be rising faster than any other war that the country had previously endured.

What happened in Minab and what is unfolding in Lebanon aren’t isolated instances. Data points to a more troubling pattern – the U.S. and Israel together accounted for about 62% of “external attacks” that ended with a child casualty since 1996. External attacks refer to acts of aggression or military involvement by an actor on foreign soil.

The *Hindu* analysed events of external attacks that were recorded by the Armed Conflict Location and Event Data Project. While over 66,000 events of external attacks have been lethal (ending with any fatalities), around 4% of such reported attacks have ended up with at least one child fatality.

Incidences of attacks were used as a proxy, as data for child fatalities under external attacks were not separately maintained. These events offer a reliable snapshot of the extent of attacks against children during conflict. However, fatalities in individual events may be significantly higher. The data only pertains to confirmed events of deaths, and therefore cases of missing children or unreported events of deaths are not included in the analysis.

A further look at the 4% reveals that close to 2,500 reported cases of external attacks have ended with a child fatality between 1996 and 2026.

A country-wise analysis of these events show that Israel accounted for about 41% of all external attacks that ended with a child fatality (**Chart 1**). That is, about one in

every nine lethal attacks (11%) launched by Israel since 1996 has killed at least one child.

No other country has recorded such events as high as Israel. The figures reflect the violent escalations in Gaza and West Bank since October 7, 2023 including instances when children were killed while receiving aid; via airstrikes; and in refugee camps. Close to 20,000 children have been killed in Gaza between October 7, 2023 and August, 2025. Infants alone accounted for 10% of these figures. This is despite the fact that Israel, globally, only accounted for 14% of lethal external attacks. (**Chart 2**)

Meanwhile, Russia alone accounted for 55% of lethal external attacks since 1996. Less than 2% of them have been reported to kill a child.

As for the U.S. which ranked second, in terms of external attacks carried out by countries that resulted in a child fatality, data shows that roughly around 7% of its lethal external attacks had resulted in a child casualty.

Grave violation

The United Nations Security Council identifies killing and maiming of children as one of the six grave violations against children in times of war. Children in these conflict zones might also be exposed to other atrocities such as recruitment by armed groups, sexual violence, abduction and denial of humanitarian access.

Days after the Minab school strike, the UN Committee on the Rights of the Child said in a statement that the strikes on civilian infrastructure, including schools and hospitals, serve as a stark reminder that children are among the most vulnerable in armed conflicts. It added that children must never be treated as collateral damage. However, with intensifying attacks and more buildings falling to rubble, children are at an increasing risk of becoming exactly that.

Nivedha M. is interning with the Hindu Data Team



A heavy toll: Graves are being prepared for the victims following a strike on a school in Minab, Iran, on March 2. REUTERS

Caught in the crossfire

The data for the charts were sourced from the Armed Conflict Location and Event Data Project. Data for 2026 pertains only till March 6

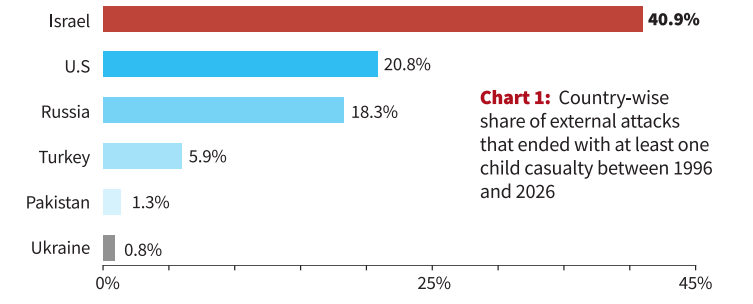
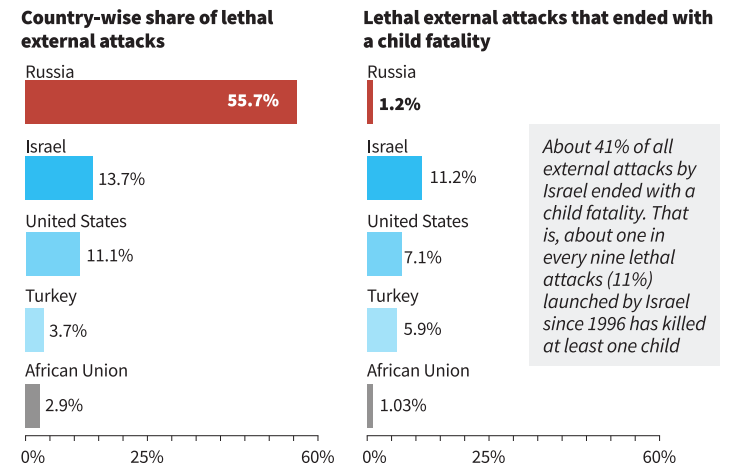


Chart 1: Country-wise share of external attacks that ended with at least one child casualty between 1996 and 2026



Note: Figures in the charts above may not add up to 100 as they only include the top countries in terms of share

■ Attacks attributed to the African Union refer to the African Union Mission in Somalia and the African Union Transition Mission in Somalia

■ Attacks attributed to the U.S. include those under the ‘Global Coalition Against Daesh,’ as it was a U.S.-led coalition

The data only pertains to confirmed events of deaths, therefore cases of missing children or unreported events of deaths are not included in the analysis

About 41% of all external attacks by Israel ended with a child fatality. That is, about one in every nine lethal attacks (11%) launched by Israel since 1996 has killed at least one child

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The *Hindu*

FIFTY YEARS AGO MARCH 19, 1976

French author’s reply to critics

Madras, March 18: Mr. Dominique Lapierre, co-author of “Freedom at Midnight”, claimed to-day that the controversial book was objective history and “a hymn of love for India” and did not distort the facts in any way.

“Four years of hard work and research have gone into the book and to dismiss it as fiction is most unjust”, he said at a press conference.

Turning to the controversial part which maintains that Nehru and Patel, unable to handle the partition riots, secretly requested Mountbatten to take charge of the situation, Mr. Lapierre said this account though never published before was accurate. A memorandum at the U.K. Government archives, which had been dictated contemporaneously by Mountbatten, recorded the conversation among the three. This version was also corroborated by the private papers of Mr. V.P. Menon.

He said that far from denigrating Nehru, the book only brought out his greatness and political courage in having an Englishman as head of State after independence. “One cannot conceive of Ben Bella, for instance, asking De Gaulle to become head of State in independent Algeria though it might have solved many of their difficulties”, he remarked.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MARCH 19, 1926

“Doodle” annual

We extend our congratulations to our humorous contemporary ‘Doodle’ on entering its sixth year of publication, which it does with its current number. For these five years this weekly journal has been providing mirth and relaxation for the public through its amusing cartoons, humorous stories, pungent – but never offensive – skits and burlesques mainly dealing with Indian social life, farces, sharp pieces of witticism etc. The first number of its sixth volume which is now before us is decidedly an improvement on its predecessors in more than one direction. It is slightly bulkier than hitherto and its cartoons on local politics are as delightful as they are to the point. Its “curry and chutney” are indeed well-dressed and the “pickings” too are a choice selection. We have no doubt this pioneer venture in a branch of journalism which is yet to come into its own in India will receive the support and encouragement it deserves.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Record number of inbound tourists who visited Japan in Feb.

3.46 in million. Visitors to Japan in February rose 6.4% from a year earlier to set a new record for the month, despite a drop-off in Chinese tourists amid ongoing diplomatic tensions between the two countries. REUTERS

Number of deaths of children under five in 2024

4.9 in million. About 4.9 million children under five died in 2024, according to new United Nations estimates. Most of the deaths were preventable with better access to healthcare and low-cost interventions for challenges. AP

Displacements of Palestinians in the West Bank

36,000 A report by the UN warned that Israel's accelerating expansion and annexation of large parts of the West Bank was driving "unprecedented" displacement. AFP

Telegram channels disabled for hosting pirated content

3,142 More than 3,100 Telegram channels and about 800 websites hosting pirated content have been disabled at the government's order, the Lok Sabha was informed on Wednesday. PTI

Number of backlogs of consumer cases between 2020-24

5.15 in lakh. The Consumer Justice Report prepared by the India Justice Report (IJR) said that between 2020 and 2024, the pendency of cases increased by 21%, from 87,545 to 5.15 lakh. PTI
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What is new in transgender rights Bill?

How is the government proposing to alter the definition of ‘transgender person’? What is the right to self-perceived gender identity? What does the new Bill propose on gender certification and SRS? Why are transgender communities opposing the amendments?

EXPLAINER

Abhinav Lakshman

The story so far:

Twelve years after the Supreme Court recognised the transgender identity and held that “self-determination of gender is an integral part of personal autonomy and self-expression”, falling within the realm of personal liberty guaranteed by the Constitution of India, the Union government on March 13 introduced a Bill in the Lok Sabha to take away transgender people’s “right to self-perceived gender identity” and redefine a “transgender person” by proposing amendments to the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019. Transgender community leaders, activists, and people across the country reacted with shock, arguing that the amendments go against the fundamental principles underlying their long struggle for recognition.

What are the changes being brought about?

The key changes being proposed have to do with the definition of a “transgender person” and the expansion of the section on offences against transgender people and punishments for them.

In the amendment Bill, the Centre has called for the omission of sub-section (2) of Section 4 of the Act, which says: “A person recognised as transgender under sub-section (1) shall have a right to self-perceived gender identity.”

In addition to this, a new definition of ‘transgender person’ is proposed. It describes them as people “having such socio-cultural identities as kinner, hijra, aravani, and jogta, or eunuch”, people with intersex variations, and people who have “congenital variations” in “male or female development” in their “primary sexual characteristics, external genitalia, chromosomal patterns, gonadal development, endogenous hormone production or response or such other medical conditions”.

The definition also includes any person or child who has been “compelled to assume, adopt, or outwardly present a transgender identity, by mutilation, emasculation, castration, amputation, or any surgical, chemical, or hormonal procedure or otherwise”. However, it adds that this definition shall not include “persons with different sexual orientations and self-perceived sexual identities”.

Compared to this definition, the Act currently defines transgender person as someone “whose gender does not match with the gender assigned at birth and includes trans men and trans women (whether or not such person has undergone Sex Reassignment Surgery (SRS) or hormone therapy or laser therapy or such other therapy), person with intersex variations, genderqueer and person having such socio-cultural identities as kinner, hijra, aravani and jogta.”

Further, a specific definition for “people with intersex variations” has also been proposed to be omitted.

Apart from these, the Bill suggests introducing the terminology for “authority”, defining it as “a medical board, headed by a Chief Medical Officer or a Deputy Chief Medical Officer, as may be appointed by the Central government, State government or Union territory Administration”.

Another key amendment is on the issuance of transgender certificates. While the law currently mandates the District Magistrate to issue a certificate based on a self-declared affidavit and without



Activists and members of the community during a demonstration against the Bill on Wednesday. AFP

physical or medical examination, the proposed amendment requires the District Magistrate to “examine the recommendation of the authority”, and decide, if deemed necessary or desirable, and after consulting other medical experts, before issuing the certificate.

A new section has also been proposed, which confers the right of transgender people to have their first names changed in birth certificates and other identification documents, with the caveat that the person should be a “transgender person” under the revised definition.

The Bill also mandates that individuals apply for a revised gender certificate after undergoing SRS, as opposed to the current law, which leaves this to the individual.

Additionally, medical institutions performing SRS would be required to furnish details of such procedures to the District Magistrate.

The Bill also significantly expands provisions relating to offences and penalties, introducing graded punishments, including rigorous imprisonment up to life and fines of up to ₹5 lakh, for crimes against transgender persons and children.

However, it remains to be seen what further changes could come through in the form of Rules, if this amendment Bill is passed by Parliament.

How did the amendment Bill come about?

Union Social Justice Minister Virendra Kumar introduced the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026, in Lok Sabha on March 13. Days earlier, media reports cited that the Union Cabinet had approved amendments to the 2019 Act, though details were not disclosed. It remains unclear how long the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment and the Centre had been preparing these changes.

Transgender activists, including Tamil Nadu-based Grace Banu, who had been central to the drafting of the 2019 Act, told *The Hindu* that the amendments seem to have been brought in without consultation with the community. Several leaders and members have described their initial reaction as one of “shock”, calling the changes “sudden”.

Interestingly, just hours before the Bill was introduced, the Ministry had posted on X, promoting the 2019 version of the Act and advertising the fact that this Act allowed the right to self-perceived gender identity as a key feature.

A few days back, on March 4, the Ministry had posted, “The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019, safeguards the rights and dignity of transgender persons.”

In February, the National Council for Educational Research and Training (NCERT) informed the Supreme Court that it had developed teacher training modules to build sensitivity towards transgender issues.

It substantiated this by saying that the 2024 module specifically spoke of the difference between gender and sexuality and discussed the idea that sex identity ascribed at birth may be at odds with a person’s perceived sex identity at a later stage. The NCERT added that it had been conducting capacity building and training programmes based on similar modules till as late as November 2025, with more planned this year.

Why is there a concern?

A primary concern raised by the transgender community is the omission of the right to self-perceived gender identity, followed by the new definition, which appears to contradict the principles laid down in the landmark 2014 NALSA judgment recognising the right to self-determination of gender.

Ms. Banu said, “there is an issue that the government seems to be including only those in the definition of transgender who may have been accommodated in Hindutva’s history and is using terms that indicate Hindutva’s accommodation of transgender identity like ‘hijra, kinner, aravani,’ etc.” And there seems to be some sort of refusal to use respectful terms that have evolved for transgender people in other parts of the country, like in Tamil Nadu, where there is now a vocabulary of *thirunagai* and *thirunambi*.”

Dr. Aqsa Shaikh has raised the issue of transgender people across the country having to now deal with the existential question of whether they continue to remain transgender as per the proposed new definition, while another Delhi-based transwoman spoke of concerns that this might create divides within the community about who has legitimacy to use the transgender identity.

What does the NALSA judgment say?

The landmark 2014 judgment in *National Legal Services Authority vs Union of India*, delivered by Justices K.S. Radhakrishnan and A.K. Sikri, remains central to India’s understanding of gender identity.

When the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Bill, 2019, was introduced, the Statement of Objects and Reasons in it noted that it flowed from this very judgment of the Supreme Court, adding that one of the principal goals of bringing this Bill was to “confer right upon transgender persons to be recognised as such, and a right to self-perceived gender identity”. In the judgment that notably

recognised a third gender beyond male and female, and the fundamental right of persons to self-determination of gender identity, the court accepted the principle that the concepts of gender and sexuality are different and that gender identity is on a spectrum.

The court said, “Gender identity is one of the most fundamental aspects of life which refers to a person’s intrinsic sense of being male, female or transgender or transsexual persons.”

The judgment explained that “a person’s sex is usually assigned at birth, but a relatively small group of persons may be born with bodies which incorporate both or certain aspects of both male and female physiology. At times, genital anatomy problems may arise in certain persons and their innate perception of themselves is not in conformity with the sex assigned to them at birth and may include pre and post-operative transsexual persons and also persons who do not choose to undergo or do not have access to operation and also includes persons who cannot undergo successful operations.”

On sexual orientation, the court defined it as an individual’s enduring emotional, romantic, or physical attraction to others.

Importantly, the court held that no person should be forced to undergo medical procedures – such as SRS, sterilisation, or hormone therapy – as a condition for legal recognition of their gender identity.

It concluded that self-determination of gender is integral to personal autonomy, dignity, and freedom under Article 21 of the Constitution.

Justice Sikri, in his judgment concurring with Justice Radhakrishnan, expanded on this, saying, “If democracy is based on the recognition of the individuality and dignity of man, as a fortiori we have to recognise the right of a human being to choose his sex/gender identity which is integral to his/her personality and is one of the most basic aspects of self-determination, dignity and freedom.”

What is the government’s reasoning?

In the Statement of Objects and Reasons, the government said that since the 2019 Act was enacted, “certain doubts and difficulties” have arisen in implementing it with regard to the “definition of transgender persons and how the identification of such persons is to be done”.

It noted that the existing definition of “transgender person” was “vague”, arguing that this made it “impossible to identify the genuine oppressed persons to whom the benefits of the Act are intended to reach”. It added that this existing definition renders several provisions “unworkable”, further saying that this definition was “not compatible” with several statutory provisions enacted by both Parliament and State legislatures.

The government has argued that the intent of the legislative policy was always to “protect only those who face severe social exclusion due to biological reasons” for no fault or choice of their own. It went on to say that the purpose of the legislation was never to “protect each and every class of persons with various gender identities, self-perceived sex/gender identities or gender fluidities”.

Noting these aspects, the government argued for a “precise” definition of transgender people, saying, “The protection and benefits that are provided under the Act are vast in nature, and therefore, care has to be taken that such identification cannot be extended on the basis of any acquirable characteristics or personal choice or claimed self-perceived identity of an individual.”

THE GIST

The Amendment Bill proposes removing the ‘right to self-perceived gender identity’ and introducing a new definition of a ‘transgender person’, focusing on socio-cultural identities, intersex variations, and congenital conditions.

It introduces a medical board-led certification process, requires scrutiny by the District Magistrate, mandates a revised certificate after SRS, and expands provisions on offences and punishments.

Transgender activists argue the changes contradict the NALSA judgment on self-determination of gender, could exclude sections of the community, and have been brought without consultation.

Course correction

The overvalued Indian market is facing a reality check

Indian markets have fallen sharply since the start of the US-Israel-Iran war; they have reacted to the disruption in supply of critical energy sources, and to crude breaching \$100 per barrel. The benchmark Nifty50 index has lost around 7 per cent since the war began three weeks ago, akin to other global emerging market benchmarks. However, this fall may actually be beneficial to the long-term health of our markets.



Stocks from many sectors were unhinged from fundamentals. Retail investors who entered stock markets in large numbers post Covid, propelled a surge in demand for direct and indirect equity (through the mutual fund route). As a result, Indian stocks have been quite pricey, compared to other emerging markets. The Nifty50 traded at price-earnings multiple of 21.7 times towards the end of 2025. This was at a premium to benchmark indices of other EMs including China, South Korea, Brazil and South Africa which traded at PE multiples between 11 and 18. Stocks in consumption-oriented sectors such as FMCG, healthcare and retail trade traded at higher PE multiples of over 50 times. The absence of a deep correction since the Covid-low in March 2020, with declines not exceeding 20 per cent from the peak, had led to complacency with investors buying at every dip. Stocks remained elevated for too long. Owing to these higher valuations, foreign portfolio investors turned net sellers of India equity since September 2024, pulling out close to ₹3.5 lakh crore. The ongoing correction will help valuations to revert to their mean levels. The valuation of Nifty50 has cooled a bit, with the PE multiple declining to 19.51 times. But prices need to decline further.

And they well may. Given the multiple headwinds currently facing markets and the economy, investors should be prepared for further price corrections. If the war in West Asia prolongs, corporate margins are going to shrink, as fuel, logistics and input costs increase. Shortage of LPG and other fuel will likely further dent corporate bottomlines. The domestic economy, which was trotting along nicely before the onset of this war, is up against multiple first and second-order effects. Besides shocks in the form of prices, supplies and asset valuations, the sentiment factor, too, could hurt business. It does not help that there are just a few stocks in nascent, sought-after sectors such as AI and semiconductors.

The bottomline is that market corrections should happen when the underlying fundamentals change. After all, equities are not meant to be risk-free, and excesses created in bull and bear markets need to be ironed out. The Securities and Exchange Board of India should let markets follow their course, while watching out for any undue volatility caused by manipulation. The regulator, Association of Mutual Funds in India and other investor bodies should run awareness campaigns, advising investors to pursue long-term goals with realistic expectations.

OTHER VOICES.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

EUROPE

Why the SAVE America Act . . . Won't

For partisan hype, it's hard to beat the Senate debate this week on the SAVE America Act. President Trump says the legislation is a salvation from mass voter fraud. Sen. Chuck Schumer says it's an effort at mass voter suppression, "Jim Crow 2.0." Neither is reality. Also, Republicans don't have the votes to clear the Senate's filibuster. And if they bully the bill through anyway, Democrats eyeing the end of the 60-vote rule will quietly celebrate. The House version of the SAVE America Act has two main planks. First, people registering to vote would be asked to show proof of US citizenship, such as a passport, birth certificate or naturalization document. Many driver's licenses wouldn't qualify. While the bill says it would accept a REAL ID "that indicates the applicant is a citizen," standard license designs often don't say. (NEW YORK, MARCH 17)

GULF NEWS

The challenges facing World Cup 2026

When the expanded 48-team FIFA World Cup kicks off in North America on June 11, 2026, it will be the largest sporting event ever staged. Matches will take place across the United States, Canada, and Mexico, involving millions of spectators and a global television audience expected to exceed five billion. The tournament is now unfolding against a geopolitical backdrop that few planners anticipated: a major war in the Middle East involving the United States and Israel against Iran, and an increasingly assertive foreign policy under the current US administration. Many quietly hope that the conflict will de-escalate or conclude well before the tournament begins, as a prolonged war would risk casting a shadow over the world's largest sporting event. (DUBAI, MARCH 17)



P. ELANGO

My favourite management lesson used to be this: when cow gets into the ditch (which often happens when you run an oil and gas company), one has to first get the cow out of the ditch, figure out how it got there and then ensure it does not get there. These three common sense steps need to be taken sequentially and not simultaneously. Let's follow the same principle while analysing the "worrisome" scenario, as the government put it, in LPG supply. The government is taking a series of measures including allocating priority for LPG usage, tightening the booking cycle, invoking the Essential Commodities Act to increase domestic production of LPG, securing safe passage for Indian flagged vessels to pass through the Strait of Hormuz and diversifying the LPG supply by sourcing from the US.

To know how we got into the current LPG situation requires understanding of some basics. A balanced mix of propane and butane is commonly known as liquefied petroleum gas (LPG). And it is produced in the process of converting crude oil into petroleum products such as petrol and diesel in the refineries. India has surplus refining capacity and was able to export about 65 million tonnes (mt) of petroleum products last year.

LARGE-SCALE IMPORTS

However, India imports 60 per cent of its LPG requirement and 90 per cent of that is from the Middle East, which means the vessels carrying the consignments have to necessarily pass through the Hormuz bottleneck. The first question is: when we have surplus refining capacity, why do we have to import LPG?

LPG production is highest (3-5 per cent) from light and sweet crude oil, but the Indian basket of crude (all the different types of crude that the country imports) has only 20 per cent light crude, as it is more expensive in international markets. Eighty per cent of crude that India imports consist of medium to heavy sour crude which are traded at a discount. However, modern Indian refineries with high complexity index are able to crack the heavy oil into export grade petroleum products. This process has some built in flexibility and that is how Indian refineries are able to increase the LPG production under the current emergency protocol.

Still this will not be sufficient as India consumes about 60 lakh LPG cylinders

Dileep Mavalankar
Abhay Bang

As India steps up its global trade talks (bilateral free trade pacts or broader arrangements), there is a temptation to treat all commodities as equal bargaining chips. The discourse revolves around market access, tariff reductions and investor confidence. Yet there is one line that India must not cross: allowing foreign alcohol and tobacco products to enter the country at low customs duties. This is not merely a question of economics or protectionism. It is a constitutional, moral, and public health imperative.

The Constitution is unambiguous on the role of the State in relation to intoxicating and harmful substances. Article 47, one of the Directive Principles of State Policy, explicitly directs the State to "endeavour to bring about prohibition of the consumption except for medicinal purposes of intoxicating drinks and of drugs which are injurious to health." While Directive Principles are not justiciable, they are fundamental to the governance of the country and serve as guiding principles for any state policy. Trade negotiations, conducted in the name of national interest, cannot be exempt from this

Luxury cars in demand

Apropos 'FTAs set to drive luxury car market: Audi India' (March 18). Many Indians aspire to own luxury cars despite crowded streets and pothole-ridden roads. High-speed driving is rarely possible, yet comfort, smooth suspension, and stylish interiors make the ride enjoyable. For most buyers, the appeal lies less in utility and more in prestige and display of wealth. Free Trade Agreements (FTAs) could lower prices, encouraging wider adoption. Still, the pride of ownership often outweighs practical challenges. However, Indian roads remain unsuitable for such vehicles. The first priority should be building infrastructure fit for luxury cars before expanding imports or

manufacturing them locally.

O Prasada Rao
Hyderabad

Uplift of rural areas

This is with reference to 'Rapidly developing Naidupeta emerges as a key industrial node in southern AP' (March 18). If India has to achieve all-round growth and development the contribution of the rural economy is vital. Due to lack of employment opportunities in rural areas people migrate to urban areas resulting in over-congestion of urban areas and all the problems relating to migration. To arrest this, it is important to start industries in rural areas. In this background it is refreshing to read about industrial development in Naidupeta, a small

town in Tirupati district. Investments in infrastructure projects in rural and semi-urban areas will go a long way in creating employment opportunities for the youth in villages. Veena Shenoy
Thane

Pulling up insurers

This refers to 'Wrongdoing by insurance cos will not go unnoticed' (March 18). That the list of those subjected to penalties for various misdeeds, reads like a veritable who is who of Indian insurance industry, is not a matter of solace. It is proof of the extent of malfeasance unbecoming of institutions entrusted with fiduciary responsibility and trust. Collecting

hefty sums as fines does not equate with good governance. Proactive monitoring, timely enforcement, are the abysmally lacking in Indian insurance, evidenced by reactionary fines. High time, the authorities thrash out the pain points in designing plans with adequate insurance cover for all, at affordable rates and on practical conditions. Jose Abraham
Vaikom, Kerala

Stabilisation fund

Apropos 'Scenario planning' (March 18), government's decision to institute an Economic Stabilisation Fund constitutes a judicious and forward-looking policy intervention amid escalating geopolitical tensions in West Asia. With crude price

fluctuations exerting inflationary pressures and straining fiscal balances, such a mechanism assumes critical importance. By creating a financial buffer to absorb external shocks, the fund can facilitate price moderation, macroeconomic stability, and policy flexibility during periods of uncertainty. It also reflects a calibrated approach to economic governance in an increasingly unpredictable global landscape. If operationalised efficiently, this initiative could significantly bolster India's resilience, ensuring sustained growth while mitigating the spillovers of energy-driven disruptions. N Sathasiva Reddy
Bengaluru

India slips up on the LPG front

IN CRISIS MODE. India banked on the Middle East for almost all of its LPG imports, and failed to build strategic storage



everyday, the largest in the world for household cooking. LPG coverage, post the successful PM Ujala Yojana, is more than 10 crore households. Other countries do not depend solely on LPG as cooking fuel; electric or piped gas cooking is more common. So in the current geopolitical conflict India has a unique problem to deal with.

In a way the current situation is similar to the oxygen shortage that hospitals across the country faced during the coronavirus pandemic.

India has no facilities for strategic storage of LPG reserves to meet a crisis, and the commercial storage the oil companies together hold can meet only less than 15 days of normal consumption. The cost of storing LPG isn't much when compared to the economic cost of shortage, perceived or real. The investment needed to create storage to meet one day's requirement is about ₹2,000 crore. Surface storage

As part of a robust energy security plan, we should have built a buffer of 45 days of surface and sub-surface storage (strategic and commercial) capacity

capacity can be custom built for large customer segments, and large sub-surface strategic storage capacity can be created in suitable caverns to meet crisis situations such as the current one.

SKEWED SOURCING

In the energy security planning agenda, LPG seems to have missed its rightful place. And we ended up sourcing nearly all our LPG imports from the Middle East. The major alternative source is the US, which is the largest producer and exporter of LPG in the world and it hardly uses LPG as a cooking fuel. However the transit time will be about 45 days, as the vessels have to take a longer route to avoid the strait of Hormuz.

As part of a robust energy security plan, we should have thought through this scenario and built a buffer of 45 days of surface and sub-surface storage (strategic and commercial) capacity. It's better late than never, and planning should start at least now if we are to avoid a "cylinder in a ditch" situation.

Piped natural gas (PNG), compressed natural gas (CNG) and LNG are different modes of storing and transporting natural gas, which is produced directly from gas fields in Mumbai High, Krishna-Godavari offshore and in onshore fields of

Gujarat, Rajasthan and Assam either along with oil as associated gas or independently as natural gas. The gas being predominantly methane, its storage will require expensive liquefaction and re-gasification process or reinjection in reservoirs.

Though LPG and natural gas can meet the same purpose, they are produced through different methods and by different entities. LPG is produced by downstream oil companies such as IOC, BPCL and HOCL in the public sector, and Reliance and Nayara Energy in the private sector.

Natural gas is produced by upstream players such as ONGC, OIL and a few independent oil companies in the private sector. Incidentally, India meets about 50 per cent of its natural gas requirements by importing LNG. Disruption in LNG imports has implications for the industrial sector, too.

Policy planners must give serious thought to electric cooking as an alternative option. Though it would be expensive, at least we will not be dependent on any other country. Ten crore households depending on imported fuel to cook their daily meal is no way to build national energy security.

The writer is former CEO, Cairn India, and former MD, HOEC

Keep alcohol, tobacco out of low-duty trade deals

Trade policy cannot trump the Constitution. The gains from tariff cuts are washed away by costs to health, family and society



LIQUOR. No safe consumption limit

constitutional responsibility.

Alcohol and tobacco are not ordinary consumer goods. Rather, they are among the important causes of preventable death and disease in India. Their harmfulness ranges from cancers, cardiovascular diseases, liver disorders, road traffic injuries, domestic violence, and loss of productivity. The WHO estimates, 40 million Indians are alcohol addicts. US Surgeon General has proposed a mandatory label on alcoholic beverages that alcohol causes seven types of cancers.

HEALTH HAZARDS

The Lancet and the WHO now unequivocally state that only safe limit of drinking alcohol is zero drinking. Gujarat, Bihar, Nagaland and Mizoram have prohibition in place. Meanwhile, tobacco alone kills more than a million Indians each year, while alcohol use imposes enormous social and economic costs on families, particularly among the poor and women and children. Any policy that makes these products cheaper, more accessible, or more socially acceptable contradicts the State's constitutional duty to protect public health and life and liberty of citizens.

When customs duties on imported liquor and tobacco are slashed as part of

trade deals, foreign brands become more affordable, more aggressively marketed — especially to youth. Global experience shows that transnational alcohol and tobacco corporations are very skilled at exploiting new markets with weak regulation. When India agrees to lower tariffs on whisky, wine, cigarettes, or novel tobacco products, it sends a clear signal that revenue and trade relations matter more than health, social welfare, and even the Constitution. This goes against government's campaigns to reduce use of tobacco and alcohol. Trade negotiators often count tariff reductions as "wins" without accounting for the downstream fiscal and social costs borne by health systems, families, and society. True economic rationality demands a

full accounting — not just of trade flows.

Public health exceptions under World Trade Organization rules and many bilateral agreements allow countries to restrict trade in products harmful to health. India, with its explicit constitutional directive, has an even stronger moral and legal basis to exclude alcohol and tobacco from low tariff treatment.

What India needs, therefore, is a clear red line in trade policy: alcohol and tobacco products must be removed from tariff-reduction commitments. Just as India has taken principled positions on access to medicines, generic drugs, and public health safeguards, it must now do the same for alcohol and tobacco. India has taken a tough stand on agri and dairy products as well.

At a time when non-communicable diseases are rising, healthcare systems are under strain, and families are grappling with the social fallout of addiction, trade policy cannot afford to be blind to its consequences. The long-term national interest requires the courage to say no to alcohol and tobacco in trade negotiations.

Dileep is public health expert and former director of Indian Institute of Public Health, Gandhinagar, and Bang is Director of SEARCH Gadchiroli and a public health expert and activist for tribal health

Pragmatic position

India must drive reforms at the WTO meeting

The 14th ministerial conference of the World Trade Organization (WTO) — the session to be held in Yaoundé, Cameroon, from March 26 to 29 — comes at a crucial juncture. Trade ministers from across the world are expected to discuss the challenges and opportunities facing the multilateral trading system and decide the agenda. The global trade order has been upended by the world's largest economy over the past one year, with little regard for well-settled trade principles. Given the state of current policy thinking in the United States (US) and its actions regarding the WTO over the past decade, it remains to be seen to what extent the multilateral forum can advance the trade agenda. Geopolitics has also become a bigger risk for trade.

As reported by this newspaper this week, India's position going into the conference is that the foundational aspects of the WTO should not change. These include issues such as consensus-driven decision-making at the forum and non-discriminatory tariff treatment by trading partners. Further, pending issues must be addressed before new items are added. The position is understandable. However, it must also be noted that the WTO has seen little progress over the years. The nature of world trade has changed in recent decades with the emergence of global value chains (GVCs). However, the consensus-driven decision-making process has not kept pace with the changes. As a result, countries have turned to free-trade agreements (FTAs), which are allowed under the rules, as an alternative to attain deeper integration and facilitate GVC-led trade.

While the terms of an FTA remain limited to only the countries doing the deal, outcomes of plurilateral negotiations can be included in the WTO rulebook with consensus. One such issue is the integration of the Investment Facilitation for Development Agreement. The idea is to facilitate investment by focusing on issues such as transparency, simplifying administrative processes and rules, and improving regulatory capacity. The agreement is supported by 128 of the 166 WTO members, including developed and least developed countries. India has opposed it, but it is hard to see why. India anyway needs to do all this to attract investment, which is absolutely necessary to grow at higher rates. Aside from the standpoint of macroeconomic management, where India needs foreign capital to supplement domestic savings to achieve higher growth, foreign capital also brings technology and can enable the country's integration into GVCs.

Equally important for the Cameroon conference is that several such issues, including the moratorium on e-commerce Customs, are likely to be discussed there. India must take a pragmatic position at multilateral forums and, more generally, in its trade and investment policies. Over the past year, India has shown considerable openness to trade and signed agreements such as those with the United Kingdom and the European Union. Although the fate of the agreement with the US remains uncertain, the initial framework reflected a pragmatic approach. India needs to carry forward the momentum and open itself to global trade. It is reported that India is considering joining the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership. It must pursue this possibility. Exports can be a major source of growth, as demonstrated by a number of countries over the past few decades. The nature of global trade has changed, and India must adapt quickly. It can also be a major driver of reforms at the WTO.

Apple@50

Staying ahead through many technology cycles

Fifty years ago, two young geeks, both named Steve, along with Ronald Wayne, who quickly left, started with an idea: Building and marketing a personal computer. Steve Jobs sold his car and Steve Wozniak his scientific calculator to raise funds for their venture, which was incorporated as Apple Computer Company. The Apple 1 was designed and hand-assembled by Mr Wozniak in a proverbial garage in Cupertino, California, while Jobs marketed the pioneering devices. The timing was perfect. Millions of consumers were waiting for just such a device, even if they didn't know it. Apple saw a dream run, in which its revenue doubled every four months for an incredible period of five years. When the company went public in 1980, it hit a market value of \$1.8 billion on the first day. It is worth over \$3.7 trillion now.

Apple has since seen its share of triumphs and disasters, far more of the former than the latter. Mr Wozniak decided to take the back seat fairly early in the game, going off to complete his college degree, while Jobs was removed by the board and then reinstated for complicated reasons. Through all the cycles that have driven global markets for consumer electronics and information technology since 1976, Apple has remained a leading innovator. It has conceptualised and created the smartphone — the iPhone is now into its 17th iteration. But long before that, it created the designer's dream computers and laptops, focusing on graphics and smooth operating systems. It drove and continues to drive trends in digital movie-making and editing.

Apple also reimagined personalised digital music mixes with the iPod. It launched the iPad, combining the convenience of the smartphone with some of the power of a laptop. And it has managed to remain the "premium brand" through all its product iterations even as every innovation was commoditised by other electronic brands. Apple has retained certain design principles. It offers integrated solutions. It designs and sources every hardware component on a bespoke basis to slot it perfectly into its specifications. It knits all the hardware tightly together with its proprietary iOS operating system. Every component of every Apple device speaks the same language, and every Apple device integrates seamlessly with every other Apple device, with the user's data backed up on the iCloud.

There is one advantage of this approach. Users like the fact that Apple devices work seamlessly with every other Apple device. For Apple, the advantage is that it considerably improves margins. Also, any problem considered by Apple engineers is perfectly solved, making the Apple ecosystem nearly "idiot-proof" and as close to being secure as any digital system can be. However, the disadvantage is that Apple's closed ecosystem lacks the flexibility to easily solve problems that Apple engineers may not have considered. This is why far more applications, programmes, and utilities are designed for the more open Linux, Windows, and Android ecosystems. But it is difficult to argue against a strategy that has kept the company in pole position across 50 years and umpteen technological cycles. Apple has over 2.5 billion active devices out there in the wild and its user-base will likely keep growing as it moves past the half-century mark.



ILLUSTRATION: BIINAY SINHA

Can companies buy their way into S&P 500?

Firms' behaviour suggests that they see a link between rating purchases and index inclusion

Few benchmarks matter more to financial investors than the S&P 500. Trillions of dollars track it directly, and many more are evaluated against it. Inclusion often boosts a firm's stock price, lowers its cost of capital, and confers prestige. Many corporate boards even tie executive compensation to performance relative to the index.

Given the S&P 500's influence, index membership should be determined objectively and transparently. Yet as a recently published research paper by Kun Li, Kelly Liu, and me shows, the process for adding companies allows for considerable discretion, potentially creating incentives for firms to purchase S&P's credit ratings in hopes of improving their chances of getting into the index. This is suggested by a key finding: Firms that recently obtained an S&P rating were more likely to be added to the S&P 500 than those that purchased ratings from Moody's.

When the working-paper version of our study first circulated in 2021, S&P strongly objected to our interpretation, emphasising that its index committee operates independently of its ratings business, with the two separated by a "Chinese wall." According to the company, the index team does not communicate with ratings analysts about firm-level decisions, and therefore, index

inclusion cannot be influenced by ratings-related revenue. While we take this claim seriously, the data reveals patterns that are difficult to reconcile with full separation between S&P's index and ratings divisions.

S&P publishes detailed criteria for index inclusion, including minimum market capitalisation, liquidity, financial viability, and sector representation. Thus, we began with a simple question: How closely did decisions to include firms follow these stated rules? Using data from 1980 to 2018, we found that the published criteria explained no more than 15 per cent of additions to the S&P 500. Many firms that met all the criteria were passed over, while others were admitted despite seeming to fall short.

To be sure, there is nothing inherently wrong with discretion in stock-index construction, and S&P does not claim its methodology is purely mechanical. The index committee is expected to exercise judgement. But whenever discretion is involved, incentives matter.

With this in mind, we examined whether firms that recently purchased an S&P credit rating were more likely to be added to the index. S&P does not publicly disclose its rating fees, but estimates from other rating agencies suggest that they range from a few thousand



SHANG-JIN WEI

India's invisible urban fault line

Indian cities are learning to do very modern things in very old ways. You can order groceries in 10 minutes, pay a street vendor with UPI, track your bus on an app, and work from a glass tower plugged into the global economy. Then the rain comes, a junction locks up, garbage spills onto the service lane, a footpath disappears under parked cars, and the city reverts to negotiation. That is the invisible fault line this year's Economic Survey also identifies: A weak civic compact between citizens and the state that leaves Indian cities struggling to convert investment into order and growth into livability.

This is a more interesting diagnosis than the usual perspective that Indian cities simply need more money, more roads, and more flyovers. While they do need investment, they also need something harder to build and easier to ignore. Cities need a widely shared understanding that public rules are real, public space is shared, and compliance is not for the naïve.

What may appear abstract is, in fact, deeply practical. It determines whether traffic signals coordinate movement or simply function as suggestions, whether housing plans guide urban growth or are gradually hollowed out by exceptions and encroachments, and whether waste segregation campaigns reshape everyday habits or remain confined to PowerPoint slides.

India's cities are now too economically important for this to remain a side issue. Urban India already produces the bulk of national output and will absorb much of the country's future demographic and economic change. The World Bank has estimated that by 2036, India's towns and cities could account for around 70 per cent of gross domestic product (GDP). The standard urban conversation in India still tends to focus on physical infrastructure. Yet the harder truth is that cities are not merely engineering projects. They are large systems of cooperation among strangers. Their success depends on whether millions of people believe rules will be applied predictably and whether the state

itself behaves as though enforcement is routine rather than theatrical.

In India, urban systems falter less because of a shortage of rules than because of weak expectations that those rules will hold. Studies of urban governance show that compliance depends heavily on perceived legitimacy and credible enforcement, not simply regulation density. In many Indian cities, the gap between rules and practice is visible in everyday coordination failures. Bengaluru commuters now lose roughly 168 hours a year to congestion, while average peak speed falls below 14 km/h, illustrating how behavioural and institutional frictions compound infrastructure limits. Such patterns are well-documented in urban economics: When enforcement appears uneven and procedures opaque, citizens rationally adapt. Signals become negotiable, regulations elastic, and informal workarounds gradually emerge as the practical operating system of the city.

India's urban history helps explain why this equilibrium has proven stubborn. Colonial municipalities were designed more to administer than to empower. Post-independence, urbanisation expanded at a speed that governance systems never fully matched. Cities grew outward, institutions remained fragmented, and informal arrangements filled the gap between official rules and lived reality. Over time, cities became a place where legality and practicality diverged.

This is visible in everything from land markets to traffic. India does not merely have congestion. It has a culture of negotiated movement. It does not merely have unaffordable housing. It has a planning system whose formal rigidity often pushes people towards informal solutions. It does not merely have waste problems. It has an urban commons problem, where the public realm is everyone's concern in theory and too often no one's responsibility in practice.

Even so, the picture is not bleak. Indian cities also contain evidence that civic norms can shift. Indore's

CONURBATION
AMIT KAPOOR

VAPPALA BALACHANDRAN

This book, authored by senior business leader R Gopalakrishnan (Gopal) and human resources professional Nirmala Isaac, has encapsulated the two-millennium history of China-India relations in just 174 pages.

What distinguishes this volume from other books on China is the writing style, which is transactional rather than academic. The authors say the "book comes from the practical mindset of an enterprise manager rather than the academic rigour of a historian, philosopher or geographer". Yet the book is deeply researched

and useful to academics too. The authors have suggested workable solutions for India and China to engage with each other to establish a stable global order against the backdrop of the decline of Western powers.

They say the long history of China-India relations was marked with three Ts: Thoughts, Travels and Trade. For over 2000 years, both countries were able to maintain a "peaceable intercourse" through these Ts. "Thoughts were carried through travellers. Travel resulted in trade. Trade intensified the pursuit of ideas and thoughts," they write. Also common were the thoughts of Sun Tzu in China's ancient Zhou period and of Chanakya in the Mauryan Empire.

A significant aspect of their narrative is based on practical experience of one of the authors (Gopal) who first visited China as a Tata director in the early 2000s. He was then chairman of Tata Auto Comp Ltd, which had set up a 100 per cent Tata-owned company in

Nanjing (NTACO) to make plastic injection-moulded automotive components. In 2015, NTACO set up a second unit near Changshu, followed by NTACO Trading Company to trade in automotive components.

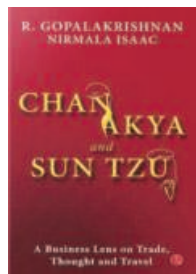
Gopal was also a member of the Indian delegation to the World Trade Organization (WTO) meeting at Seattle in 2000 that admitted China into the world order of doing business. He had then shared the hope that the "rules-based global system would take deeper root as China would become more akin to other trading nations."

That was also the hope of the Bill Clinton administration that allowed China to enter WTO. This reviewer had published a column in July 2019 on this process and how it resulted in the United States (US) agreeing to China's WTO entry after their National Intelligence Council (NIC) had convened a crucial meeting with prominent academics and nine US intelligence specialists. This was on September 24,

1999. The NIC then concluded that China was "unlikely to break with the United States or engage in disruptive military buildups or aggressive foreign behaviour" unless "Beijing was challenged by unexpected circumstances". Global China watchers always hold this date as the crucial milestone in the history of China's economic rise.

This, together with US International Trade Commission's report in August 1999, which felt that WTO Standardisation would benefit US companies in China and compel Beijing to adhere to WTO rules, was the reason the Clinton Administration recommended China's WTO entry. As a result, China became the largest exporter in the world, accounting for 20 per cent of US imports, as the *US Journal of International Economics* concluded in a September 2020 assessment.

Sure, there are voices in the Trump administration that want the US to

CHANAKYA AND SUN Tzu: A Business Lens on Trade, Thought and Travel
by R Gopalakrishnan & Nirmala Isaac
Published by Rupa
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abrogate this on the ground that China is not adhering to WTO's rule-based global order. However, on October 20, 2025, President Donald Trump brushed aside these calls and described the relationship with China as "G-2", a peer. The authors want this global trend to be modulated by quoting history: "Whenever India has been connected to the rest of the world, supported by its strong coastal tradition, it has brought the country great prosperity." They strongly believe that the policy of "self-reliance," which was the core goal of India's Third Five Year Plan (1961) and repackaged in 2020 as "Atmanirbhar Bharat," is

neither practical nor possible. Instead, "we should consider how India can leverage its position with potential partners as the world's largest (or a major) importer of, for example, fertilisers, lentils, edible oils and hydrocarbons". To this end, the authors suggest

dollars to several million. After accounting for the published selection criteria, we found a clear pattern: Firms that had recently obtained an S&P rating were significantly more likely to gain admission to the S&P 500. For non-member firms, the unconditional likelihood of being added to the index was 15.5 per cent; for firms that had recently purchased an S&P rating, it was 21.4 per cent. One possible explanation is that S&P ratings to favour fast-growing firms, and that such companies are naturally more likely to issue debt and seek credit ratings. But if that were the whole story, we would expect to see the same pattern among firms that purchased ratings from Moody's, and we did not. If rating purchases simply reflect firm quality or growth prospects, the effect should not be specific to S&P.

Firms' behaviour further suggests that they see a link between rating purchases and index inclusion. When mergers among S&P 500 firms create openings for new additions, large non-member firms disproportionately increase their purchases of S&P ratings. Conversely, after a 2002 rule change that made foreign firms ineligible for inclusion, non-US firms listed on US exchanges sharply reduced their purchases of S&P ratings relative to Moody's. The implication is clear: When the prize disappears, so does demand. Taken together, these patterns suggest that firms believe purchasing S&P ratings increases their chances of joining the index.

What about another, more innocent explanation? S&P learns useful information during the ratings process, which helps it decide whether firms belong in the index. In that case, the correlation we observed between rating purchases and subsequent inclusion reflects improved information from the rating process rather than business incentives.

But this explanation is difficult to sustain. For starters, if index-addition decisions rely on non-public information obtained through the ratings process, that would mark a departure from S&P's published methodology, which does not indicate that private ratings information is used in index decisions.

Moreover, such information-sharing would seem at odds with S&P's public statements that the index committee and ratings department operate independently and do not exchange firm-specific data. In addition, the information uncovered during the rating process could just as easily lower a firm's chances of inclusion as raise them.

Lastly, when we looked at how companies performed after joining the S&P 500, we found no evidence that discretionary additions — including those associated with recent rating purchases — systematically outperformed rule-based additions or even firms that met the criteria but were passed over. In other words, discretion does not appear to lead to better outcomes.

Whether or not S&P 500 membership is literally for sale, the evidence suggests that firms behave as if it might be. And when companies believe that paying for ratings can improve their odds of inclusion in the index, the credibility of the admission process is at risk.

The author, a former chief economist at the Asian Development Bank, is professor of finance and economics at Columbia Business School and Columbia University's School of International and Public Affairs. ©Project Syndicate, 2026

seven steps under "Thoughts", five under "Travel" and six under "Trade" with this conclusion: "It is time for Chanakya and Sun Tzu to walk the same path, where the wisdom of India and the strategy of China meet, not in conflict, but in convergence, forging a new dawn for Asia".

This idea might appear to be a mirage in the present context, but not impossible if we study current Sino-Vietnam relations. Hanoi, which resisted a brutal invasion by China in 1979, could settle their differences with Beijing in 2000. Hanoi even accepted the building of the 850-Km Kunming-Hanoi highway to allow land locked south-west China to use Vietnamese ports. Politically, however, it pursues a nuanced policy of "Co-operation and Struggle" — economic cooperation and resisting China's encroachments in the South China Sea. (R Gopalakrishnan is a *Business Standard* columnist)

The reviewer is a former special secretary, Cabinet Secretariat. His latest book, *India and China at odds in the Asian Century*, was published by Hurst, London, and Pentagon Books, New Delhi

OUR VIEW



IDBI Bank's sell-off: Its delay should mystify us

The government's decision to mark time on this bank's privatization is a puzzle. Its rationale is clear and the stage for it was set long ago. Low bids shouldn't get in the way of a stake sale

It is unfortunate that India's government has decided to call off the privatization of IDBI Bank for now, as reports indicate. The disappointment is that this decision was reportedly taken in response to poor investor interest—as seen in low bids for the 61% stake on offer to corporate bidders. There are many reasons behind the process of what we in India like to call 'disinvestment,' a euphemism coined as a political shield against critics. The money it raises is just one reason. It pales in front of another motive, one that has long been regarded as a free-market principle. Namely, that governments should not be in any business that the private sector can do as well, if not better. It was this aspect of India's market reform agenda that led successive administrations to disinvest in a host of state-run undertakings across sectors over the past three decades. It was an exercise that culminated in the most difficult and perhaps controversial sell-off of all, that of Air India in January 2022.

For a government that has been keen to demonstrate its ability to bite the bullet on contentious reforms such as those related to labour, its call on IDBI Bank is puzzling. It risks sending mixed signals on the Centre's commitment to structural reforms. This puzzle is deepened by the government's rejection of revenue maximization as its main motive for selling stakes in publicly held enterprises. To be sure, banking is a strategic sector—especially in an emerging economy like ours where public ownership of banks helps serve policy ends like financial inclusion. But we already have 12 public sector banks (PSBs) with a strong presence in this field; they account for 53.5% of all loans, against private lenders'

share of 41.5% (at the end of 2025), and about 60% of all bank deposits, according to a 2024 State Bank of India report. In such a scenario, turning IDBI Bank over to private control would not have upset the appercart of PSB dominance of Indian banking. Moreover, the process has long been in the works. After state-owned LIC bought a 51% stake in January 2019 when IDBI Bank was under stress, the cabinet committee on economic affairs gave an in-principle nod for its privatization way back in 2021. By then, an equity issuance had taken LIC's share below half. The plan was for the government to sell 30.48% of the bank's equity pie, with LIC offloading another 30.24%. Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman's budget speech on 1 February five years ago had set a target for the sale's completion within fiscal 2021-22—only to have the deadline breached time and again.

Ironically, foreign investors have lately shown considerable interest in our banking sector. The Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) approval of Warburg Pincus's 10% investment in IDFC First Bank in July 2025 was followed by a significant stake taken by Japan SMBC in Yes Bank last September. That's not all. Last October, RBL Bank received funds from Emirates NBD, which was reportedly also one of the bidders for IDBI Bank in the aborted auction. Earlier this year, a Blackstone affiliate obtained regulatory approval for investing in Federal Bank. While some of these investments could be attributed to RBI's recently relaxed stance on foreign ownership, it also reflects greater global interest in the country's banking space. All of this gives the Centre's decision to mark time on IDBI Bank's sell-off an air of mystery.

MY VIEW | OTHER SPHERE

Pride in AI: It's a force that needs constraints of collective wisdom

Some forms of pride must be nurtured but not the kind that raises the risk of civilizational collapse



ANURAG BEHAR
is CEO of Azim Premji Foundation.

There is something remarkable about the best salespeople, something quiet. Not the loudest, not the most decorated, not the ones with the fanciest titles or biggest incentive payouts. The truly effective ones, if you spend enough time around them—in liquor distribution, IT services, pharmaceuticals, agricultural inputs, across every sector—you begin to notice a common thread that has nothing to do with technique or personality type.

They have pride in their work. This is not the pride that comes from a sales award at an annual jamboree or being featured in the company newsletter, a cash reward for nudging quarterly numbers up or other such motivators. But from something deeper. This pride emanates from a felt sense that they have made a real difference to someone or to someone's business.

In the liquor business, this might look like a salesperson who has spent years helping a distributor grow, building his territory, thinking about his margins, relationships and capital cycles with as much care as if it were her own business. In IT services, it might be the account manager who feels genuine ownership over whether her client's operations became more efficient. The sale is the outcome. The pride is in the effect. This distinction matters.

What is true of salespeople is equally or perhaps more true of those who work

in professions whose very purpose is human well-being. The most effective teachers carry a particular light in their eyes when they speak of a student who struggled and then found her way. The best doctors speak of a difficult diagnosis resolved or a patient restored to full life with a satisfaction that no performance bonus can replicate. Care workers who persist through the severe physical and emotional demands of this work are also often driven by this force.

Organizations that achieve sustained excellence understand this even if they don't always articulate it this way. They build structures, processes and cultures that constantly reinforce the connection between what their people do every day and the difference it makes. They tell stories. They create visibility. They bring the salesperson face-to-face with the effect of her work. This scaffolding matters. Pride doesn't always emerge spontaneously; sometimes it needs to be cultivated, made legible and given form.

In this, the world of business has it harder than the social sector in one specific respect. A business is ultimately about making money. The immediate goal of the salesperson—close the deal, hit the number—is structurally at some distance from the deeper effect that generates pride. Organizations must aim to bridge that gap. The social sector, at least in principle, has no such problem. The work itself—the learning of children, the curing of patients, the well-being of communities—generates pride. It should come more naturally. Yet, with tragic regularity, it does not.

In too many parts of our public and social systems, anganwadi workers, teachers, nurses, doctors and care workers are treated as replaceable cogs in a large indifferent machine. They are blamed for systemic failures that are not of their making. Their professional judgement is second-guessed and their dignity quietly eroded. Rather than building pride in their work, these systems demolish it. This is one of the most

consequential and least-discussed failures of institution-building.

But now I turn to a very different kind of pride, because pride is not always benign. It can, under certain conditions, become something dangerous. Something that licenses recklessness.

We are living through a moment when the most powerful technology companies in the world and many individuals who lead them are in the grip of a particular variety of pride. The people driving the artificial intelligence (AI) revolution are motivated by the usual things—money, market dominance and the fear of being left behind. But there is something else that makes this moment distinct. There is a messianic quality to much of today's discourse. A felt sense that these individuals are not merely building products but transforming the world, reshaping human civilization and bending the arc of history.

This pride is driving a breakneck pace of development that an increasing number of the very pioneers of AI—people who understand these systems better than almost anyone alive—are warning against. The risks being accumulated are together sufficient for civilizational collapse. AI could undermine economic stability as well as public safety, diminish basic human capacities for independent thought and genuine relationships, and deplete the natural world through its extraordinary consumption of energy and related carbon emissions.

There is a phrase so old that it has become a cliché. Yet, it captures something precise about this moment: pride comes before the fall.

The pride of the best salesperson, best teacher and best doctor is among the most constructive forces in the world. It should be nurtured. But the pride of those who believe their roles are too important and their mission too consequential to be constrained by ordinary caution or collective wisdom has been among the most destructive forces in human history. We would do well to tell the difference.



JUST A THOUGHT

Each era has the fatal hubris to believe that it has once and for all climbed to the top of the mountain and can see everything as it is, from the highest and most objective vantage point possible.

ERIC METAXAS

MY VIEW | TIGHTROPE WALK

America has missed the great irony of its war on Iran

RAGHU RAMAN



is former CEO of the National Intelligence Grid, distinguished fellow at Observer Research Foundation and author of 'Everyman's War'.

Beneath the stated justifications of any war in history—righteous causes, nuclear threats, regime changes—the bedrock truth is the same. Conflict is and has always been a quest for resources. The Iran war is merely the latest chapter. What distinguishes it is not the violence itself, but what has been abandoned to prosecute this war.

The blitzkrieg delusion: Heady after the one-sided bombardments of Gaza and Tehran and kidnapping of a sitting head of state, US President Donald Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu may have convinced themselves that similar tactics would crush Iran within hours. Three weeks into an ever-enlarging conflict, that figment has been brutally dispelled.

Consider what Iran represents as a theatre. At over 90 million people, its population exceeds the combined populations of Vietnam, Iraq and Afghanistan at the time of their respective US wars. Over 4 million of its citizens live across the West—a politically engaged diaspora now watching their

homeland burn. Iran's landmass is larger than all three of those killing grounds combined. A nation of that size, with thousands of years of civilizational memory, cannot be pummeled into submission.

The American war machine has been weakening through a decade of West Asian entanglements and a grinding proxy war in Ukraine. Structurally, it has an Achilles heel that weapons cannot compensate for: a decaying democracy's intolerance for body bags and economic pain. Every increase in war casualties or inflation erodes Trump's domestic support even within his base.

Pandora's Box: Killing Ali Khamenei has not decapitated the Iranian state. It has decentralized it, creating something more dangerous than a unified enemy. A headless movement cannot be negotiated with, deterred or made to submit. What replaces centralized authority is not chaos, but something more implacable: a 'nothing left to lose' resolve. A person who loses his entire family in a single day does not calculate the odds of success as he plots vengeance.

The US and Israel are creating entire nations of such men and women. Their targeted killing of a nation's leader, its nuclear scientists and its commanders without any due process has opened a door that cannot

be shut. If the world's most powerful military can eliminate a sovereign nation's entire leadership and slaughter civilians, on what moral or legal basis can it object when a weaker adversary reaches for the only instruments available to it?

Terrorism: If US and Israeli forces can kill schoolgirls in Iran and scientists in Zurich, by what principle would CEOs of US firms be off-limits to Iranian forces? This is not an argument to target civilians, but a warning that the choice of legitimate targets is not unilateral.

Rules are not a constraint on war but the architecture of peace: The UN Charter's prohibition on external regime change action, the Geneva Conventions' protections for civilians and the norm against assassinating heads of state were not designed to constrain military power, but to make peace possible. Without those rules, there is only escalation until one side is annihilated or both are exhausted.

The US has indicated that those rules are for adversaries, not for it. It launched a war

for regime change, killed a sitting head of state and normalized civilian infrastructure as targets. So if these rules don't apply to the US, why would China feel constrained in Taiwan or Russia in the Baltics? Why would a middle power grant the international order its allegiance or not pursue nuclear weapons as an insurance policy?

The US spent eight decades as architect and enforcer of the post-war international order. What is being dismantled in Iran is not merely a hostile regime. It is that framework itself.

Iran is in it for the long haul: Tehran understands something that advocates of this campaign don't seem to. A nation that survived eight years of war with Iraq, fought against chemical weapons and endured harsh sanctions does not break easily. A civilization spanning three millennia does not measure time in news cycles or US election schedules. A dispersal of power that appears to have followed Khamenei's killing will not weaken Iran's resistance; it will fragment it into cells and individuals whose

motivations might plausibly be personal more than political. An insurgency with no command structure to negotiate with, disrupt or destroy could prove more perilous.

History offers a consistent verdict on superpowers trying to bludgeon proud nations into submission. Think of Vietnam, Afghanistan and Iraq. Mistaking firepower for 'the will to fight' imposes very high costs.

The price of arbitrary action: Every war has been premised on the assumption that it will end. That premise requires rules—not as a concession to the enemy, but as a precondition for settlement. Total arbitrariness produces not victory but a permanent state of violence, radicalizing populations and foreclosing every exit. The great irony is that the nation that will suffer the most from the death of a rules-based order is the one that has killed it. America's power rested on the voluntary deference of allies that believed the rules applied to everyone, including Washington. That credibility is now spent.

Resources have always been fought for. But the most precious resource any great power possesses is not oil, territory or nuclear capability. It is the trust of the world that it seeks to lead. That resource cannot be seized by force. And once lost, it cannot be recovered by bombing anyone.

We've seen the world's most powerful nation tear up its own rulebook and erode its most vital resource

THEIR VIEW

Geo-economic warriors should think twice: They endanger us all

National strategies that weaponize trade equations, essential supplies and financial systems are prone to dangerous errors



BARRY EICHENGREEN

is professor of economics and political science at the University of California, Berkeley, and the author, most recently, of 'Money Beyond Borders: Global Currencies From Croesus to Crypto'

In 1945, at World War II's close, the economist Albert O. Hirschman published *National Power and the Structure of Foreign Trade*, in which he analyzed how nation-states shape trade patterns to their strategic advantage. The book sank like a stone. It garnered just a brief summary in the *American Political Science Review* and was rarely if ever cited by other economists and authors.

Today, Hirschman and the field he invented, known as 'geo-economics,' have re-emerged with a vengeance, building on his seminal ideas. These start with his 'influence effect,' which showed how a dominant state could structure its trade so that disruptions hurt its partners more than itself. By threatening to withhold exports or market access, this dominant state could then coerce and extract concessions from its partners.

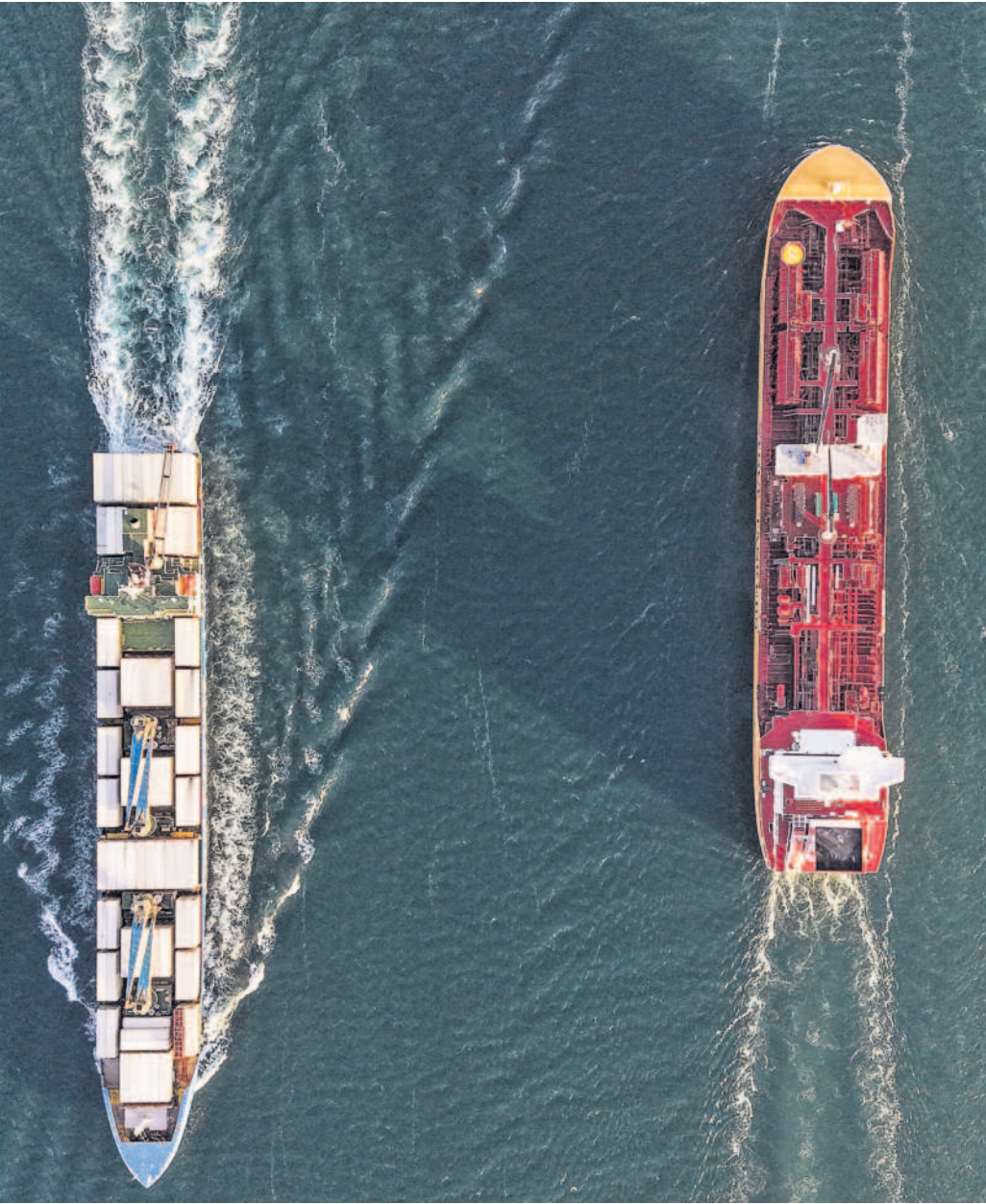
In the last year, we have seen multiple instances of US President Donald Trump using tariffs and export controls to coerce countries to invest in the United States or grant US firms favoured market access. Unlike Hitler's Germany, Hirschman's original example, the Trump administration can't be credited with having consciously shaped US trade to amplify this effect. Trump inherited a large US market and America's high-tech leadership, which granted him leverage. However, the resulting strategy is the same.

Hirschman also pointed to a second mechanism, the 'supply effect,' where trade is used to stockpile resources and channel transactions toward reliable partners, strengthening economic resilience and limiting vulnerability to foreign influence. Today, we see countries friendsourcing their trade and investment, enhancing their self-sufficiency in semiconductors, and stockpiling rare earths. The more things change...

But some things have not remained the same. International financial markets, having fallen into disarray in the 1930s, were inactive when Hirschman was writing. Now, by contrast, they are a major arena for geo-economics. The US notably capitalized on Russia's financial dependence following the full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022 by freezing the Kremlin's overseas dollar deposits and denying it access to the US correspondent banking system.

China uses its Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) not only to build secure supply chains, but also to cultivate other countries' dependence on its financial resources. Those other countries are not unaware: in 2023, Italy terminated its participation in the BRI precisely because of uneasiness about its financial dependence on China.

Critics of financial sanctions worry that such measures will erode the leverage of governments applying them. Russia and other countries worried that they too will find themselves on the sharp end



of US sanctions have an incentive to seek other ways to hold foreign assets and make foreign payments.

Russia is pushing its System for Transfer of Financial Messages (SPFS) into the domain of cross-border transactions. A more serious competitor for the dollar and US correspondent banking system is China's Cross-Border Interbank Payment System (CIPS), now with some 1,700 banks participating directly and indirectly. Analysts warn that willy-nilly use of sanctions will lend more impetus to such initiatives and thus end up undermining the global role of the American dollar, eliminating America's ability to leverage finance to its advantage.

Similarly, countries like China that are on the receiving end of US export controls have reason to accelerate their own investments in dual-use (civilian and military) technologies. If so, the US may end up facing an even more powerful and technologically sophisticated rival as a result of its geopolitical measures.

Such responses should not come as a surprise. They are exactly what Hirschman's framework would lead one to expect: countries targeted by America's 'influence effect' would resort to their own 'supply effects' to limit their vulnerability.

Targeted countries will also retaliate in an effort to deter aggressive action by the initiator.

Hirschman devoted little attention to this, given the power imbalance between Nazi Germany and the Central and Eastern European countries it targeted. By contrast, today's China possesses leverage. It responded to Trump's tariffs and export controls with tariffs on US products, export controls on critical minerals and investment restrictions for US companies.

Late last year, the two countries drew back from the brink, negotiating a 'tactical truce' to de-escalate their trade war. But their tit-for-tat retaliation could easily have spiralled out of control. This danger remains. Now that the American Supreme Court has forced Trump to reconfigure his 'reciprocal' tariffs, the entire situation will have to be revisited.

This is our dangerous new world. It is one of alarming parallels between nuclear deterrence theory and Hirschman's geo-economic theory. As with nuclear weapons, the consequences of miscalculation by those wielding geo-economic weapons would be devastating.

The globalization to which we have grown accustomed has survived recessions, financial crises and a worldwide pandemic. It is not clear that it will survive escalating geo-economic conflicts. Geo-economic warriors should think twice. They proceed at their—or, more precisely, our—peril.

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THEIR VIEW

How climate stress impacts corporate real-estate assets

SOUMYA SARKAR



is an independent expert based in New Delhi, Kolkata and Odisha. Twitter: @scurve Instagram: @soumya.scurve.

India's corporate skyline has expanded rapidly over the past three decades. Tech campuses in Bengaluru and Hyderabad, logistics parks along the Delhi-Mumbai industrial corridor and multiple warehouse clusters on city outskirts reflect a country building the infrastructure of a modern economy. Yet, much of this expansion has been planned around connectivity, labour access and land prices. Climate risk has rarely figured in the blueprint.

That omission is becoming harder to ignore. Floods, extreme heat and infrastructure breakdowns are increasingly shaping the reliability and value of corporate real estate. The 2015 Chennai floods offered a stark illustration, causing industrial property losses estimated at around ₹14,600 crore, according to a report on building climate resilience for Indian industry. Events like these are not isolated shocks. They are signals of a deeper structural risk embedded in the built-up environment.

Corporate property is especially exposed

because it is designed to last. Office parks, warehouses and campuses are typically built with a life-span of 30-50 years. Once a facility is constructed in a vulnerable location, the investment is effectively locked in. Flood-prone land, rising temperatures or fragile infrastructure can gradually erode the reliability of assets that companies depend on for operations.

Extreme heat has emerged as one of the most pervasive pressures in recent times. India's cities can be as much as 6° Celsius warmer than surrounding rural areas because of the urban heat island effect, as research by World Resources Institute shows. For large corporate campuses and data-heavy office buildings, this translates directly into higher electricity consumption for cooling. Power systems designed for milder conditions can come under severe strain during prolonged heatwaves.

Logistical infrastructure faces a different kind of exposure. Warehouses and distribution hubs are often located on the edges of cities where land is cheaper and access to highways is easier. These areas are often former wetlands or low-lying floodplains. Heavy rainfall can overwhelm drainage systems, cut road access and damage inventory. As supply chains become more time-sensi-

tive, even short disruptions can ripple through corporate operations.

Risks extend beyond physical damage. Climate stress increasingly affects the economics of property assets. Cooling costs rise as temperatures climb. Insurance premiums may increase in areas with repeated disasters. Worker productivity falls when heat becomes extreme. The Institute of Risk Management estimates that heat-related productivity losses already cost India tens of billions of dollars annually and could threaten several percentage points of GDP by the end of this decade.

Investors are beginning to treat these pressures as financial variables rather than environmental concerns. Property portfolios are increasingly assessed for exposure to physical climate hazards such as floods and heatwaves, according to the OECD, a club of rich nations. For companies with large real estate footprints, resilience may soon matter as much as location.

That shift is beginning to influence how

corporate infrastructure is planned. One response is better information. Companies are starting to incorporate climate hazard maps and heat projections into location decisions, avoiding sites prone to floods or extreme heat exposure. The practice is already visible in sectors such as data centres, where developers increasingly factor climate risks into site decisions.

Building design is also evolving. India's policy framework for construction emphasizes structures that can withstand rising temperatures and other climate stresses. Architects are turning to techniques that reduce heat absorption and cooling demand, including reflective materials, improved ventilation and building orientation that minimizes solar exposure. Flood-prone sites are increasingly incorporating raised foundations and improved drainage.

Green infrastructure is another emerging tool. Expanding tree cover and permeable landscapes can lower local temperatures and absorb excess rainwater during storms,

urban adaptation research supported by the International Finance Corporation shows. Corporate campuses that integrate parks, shaded walkways and natural water retention areas not only improve work conditions for staff but also reduce flood risk.

Even logistics infrastructure is beginning to adapt. Developers are building warehouses that meet green certification standards, which often include better insulation, water management systems and more efficient energy use. India's stock of green-certified warehousing space could quadruple by the end of the 2020s as institutional investors push for more resilient assets, according to JLL, a property consultancy.

India's corporate real estate boom is far from over. New industrial corridors, tech clusters and logistic networks will continue to reshape its landscape. However, the next generation of corporate infrastructure will be judged not only by how efficiently it supports growth, but by how well it withstands the pressures of a changing climate.

Companies that treat resilience as a design principle rather than an afterthought may find that their safest assets are also the most valuable. In the coming years, corporate India's geographical map may be shaped as much by climate science as by economics.

MINT CURATOR

Paramount priorities: Hiring #MeToo men comes at a cost

The Hollywood studio's signing up of 'distressed assets' is myopic



BETH KOWITT

is a Bloomberg Opinion columnist covering corporate America.



Hiring decisions have an impact on the kind of films that get made. BLOOMBERG

Hollywood is known for its short memory, but David Ellison has been testing the aphorism's limits. Ellison, who merged his Skydance studio with Paramount seven months ago and is in the process of acquiring Warner Bros Discovery, has a payroll that includes several names lodged in the collective memory of observers for the wrong reasons.

First, there's Jeff Shell, president of Paramount Skydance, who was fired as CEO of NBC Universal in 2023 following an allegation of sexual harassment. Then there's John Lasseter, Paramount's head of animation, who left Walt Disney in 2018 after allegations of inappropriate behaviour. Paramount brought on Max Landis, who faced accusations of sexual misconduct in 2019, to write a treatment of *G.I. Joe*—one the company has passed on. Filmmaker Brett Ratner, who was accused of sexual misconduct by several women (allegations he has denied), is making *Rush Hour 4* with Paramount as its distributor. (Amazon also hired Ratner, tapping him to direct *Melania*, a documentary.)

As *The Wrap* aptly pointed out, Ellison is essentially telling "Hollywood's canceled #MeToo men: We're hiring."

The industry publication amplified a theory about why Paramount Skydance has hired controversial figures: The company isn't trying to make a big point about redemption, the #MeToo movement or cancel culture. Instead, it's just trying to get talent on the cheap. One top dealmaker it didn't identify said, "Studios like Paramount Pictures are ultimately in the asset business. Hiring someone like Max Landis or Brett Ratner is more likely about acquiring distressed creative assets at a price below their historical market value."

Ellison has a strong incentive to keep a tight leash on expenses. Paramount will have \$79 billion in net debt after its acquisition of Warner Bros Discovery, which Ellison has promised to quickly pay down.

There are two ways to think about all this. The first is that Hollywood has always played a prominent role in shaping the country's broader culture.

So what does it say that one of the world's soon-to-be largest and most influential movie studios has hired these men? It was not long ago that almost no company would be motivated to bring on anyone accused of allegations during the #MeToo movement. The climate around accountability was so swift and public that association alone could end a career. Clearly, moral clarity has softened. What was once considered a clear disqualification is now

framed by some as undervalued assets.

The second is that Hollywood in many cases seems more willing to grant second chances to men than first opportunities to women. Women held only nine, or 8.1%, of the 111 director roles attached to the top 100 US box office films last year, down from 13.4% in 2024, according to a study by the Annenberg Inclusion Initiative at the University of Southern California. The report also found that films by women received the same ratings from critics as those made by men; films by women of colour were the highest rated overall.

The study notes that Paramount, which Skydance merged with only in August, was one of three major distributors that didn't hire a female director across the top 100 of 2025 that it evaluated. Since then, the company has greenlit several women-led films, including Billie Eilish's concert film that the singer co-directed, *Children of Blood and Bone* directed by Gina Prince-Bythewood and Teyana Taylor's directorial debut. The company declined to comment.

In Hollywood, hiring decisions have an impact on the types of stories that get told. A separate report from San Diego State University's Center for the Study of Women in Television and Film found that last year women who worked on the top 250 films continued to be wildly under-represented as producers (28%), executive producers (23%), writers (20%), editors (20%) and cinematographers (7%). Meanwhile, the percentage of top-grossing films with female protagonists dropped from 42% in 2024 to 29% in 2025. As the report put it, "Hollywood has never needed permission to exclude and diminish women, but it now has it."

The one area in Hollywood where women aren't under-represented? Viewership. Men and women were equally likely to report going to the movies in the last year, but an ability to capture a female audience can make a film. Last month, *Wuthering Heights* had the year's biggest opening so far, with women buying some 75% of those tickets.

In such a fragile box-office environment, which has yet to fully recapture its pre-covid audience, failing to represent and tell the stories of this audience on the big screen will come at a cost—one no distressed asset can offset. ©BLOOMBERG

‘CAN’T AFFORD TO REFILL LPG CYLINDER’

Workers’ exodus sets alarm bells ringing in Surat’s textile industry

Kamal Saiyed
Surat, March 18

FOR SEVERAL days, Subhash Thakur, a dyeing and printing mill worker here, has been struggling to feed his family of four. His struggle is not caused by unemployment, but the inflation that is a result of an LPG or liquefied petroleum gas crisis that has impacted people far and wide.

Thakur, until recently, lived at a rented accommodation in Pandesara with his wife and two kids. Among his belongings is a five-kilogram gas cylinder that he “cannot afford to refill” now. Waiting to board a train back to his home in Lucknow (Uttar Pradesh), Thakur said, “As I don’t have a gas registration book, we used to get our small LPG cylinder filled at a refilling centre in Pandesara for Rs 500. The store has raised the charges to Rs. 2,500, a price we cannot pay. My children are small. To survive, I have booked tickets back to my native place.”

For some days now, Udhna Junction (Railway station) has been bearing witness to hordes of migrant workers desperate to return home in the wake of the crisis. Mostly from UP, Bihar, Jharkhand, Uttarakhand and Odisha, the exodus of several workers has left the expansive textile sector in Surat reeling. Several factories have even begun shutting down for a day or two in a week to cope with



Many of those employed in the textile industry wait to board a train at Udhna railway station in Gujarat’s Surat. EXPRESS

the manpower shortage. Like Thakur, several of his neighbours and others were seen waiting at the railway junction to catch a train back home on Tuesday. A mess where textile workers had their lunch has been shut down.

While one of their associations has started a community meal service, several mills too, have begun offering food to their workers. The district administration has deployed officials to 75 gas agencies to prevent black marketing of LPG cylinders.

Commenting on the quandary looming over the industry, South Gujarat Textile Processing Association president Jitubhai Vakharia said: “At present, it is a tough situation for the workers due to the LPG crisis.

Many don’t have an LPG cylinder registration book. They live in rented houses. Some mills are shutting down for one or two days every week. As Navratri and the wedding season are around the corner, we are somehow ensuring that the factories keep working... To overcome the food crisis, we have started a community kitchen at Pandesara, where workers are given good food at cheaper rates. One plate costs Rs 40-Rs 45. Mill owners buy food from the kitchen and give it to their workers when they head home around 8.00 pm, so that they come back to work the next day.”

Vakharia said the kitchen had been “making food for over 5,000 people every day”. A mill owner in Surat, Rahul Agrawal said the kitchen at his facility had been providing food for Rs

Morbi ceramics industry shut until April 15

Ahmedabad: A majority of the ceramics units in Gujarat’s Morbi, which account for 90% of the Rs 75,000-crore industry in India has declared a month-long shutdown over fuel shortages that went from bad to worse within a week of the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz by Iran. A decision on the shutdown, taken at a meeting of the Morbi Ceramics Manufacturers Association, came on the heels of shortages in both of their major fuels — propane and natural gas. The industry will be closed until April 15, industry leaders confirmed. ENS

20 per meal. “We want to retain our workers. We don’t have any manpower shortage in our mill, where production is optimal.”

Labour contractor Kamran Usmani said, “To overcome the present situation, we buy wooden logs from Mandvi (Surat) and give them to workers so that they can cook. Daily, we order five public carrier vehicles loaded with wooden logs.”

Sources in the district collectorate said there are 55 LPG gas agencies in Surat city and 20 more in rural areas. Officials deployed there maintain a record of the current stock and ensure that gas cylinders are supplied to consumers, they added.



Express News Service
New Delhi, March 18

THE WAR in West Asia has dominated global headlines since US and Israel launched strikes on Iran, and Tehran counter-attacked Israel and about a dozen countries in the region that hosted US military bases and personnel.

In its 20th day, the war has impacted the global economy and has led to rise in oil and gas prices as the battle for control of Strait of Hormuz has impacted many nations, including India. US President Donald Trump has given mixed signals about ending the war and the Gulf countries are facing the heat as Iran continues to strike at their



residential areas, airports apart from some oil facilities as well.

There are many questions that are top of the mind: What is the endgame? Are the US and Israel justified in attacking Iran? What is happening inside Iran? What will be new Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei’s strategy? How does West Asia view the war? How is India’s position on the war perceived by different nations? How far is it going to hit India’s economy and its diaspora in the region?

To answer these questions and explain the situation, Nav-

deep Suri, who speaks Arabic and has extensive experience in the region, having served as India’s Ambassador to Egypt and the UAE, will be the guest at the Express Explained.Live session on “War in the Middle East: Where is it headed, and what happens now” at 5.30 pm on March 19. Suri is a regular commentator on developments related to West Asia and had earlier been a guest at the Express Explained.Live in December 2023.

He will be in conversation with Shubhajit Roy, Diplomatic Editor at *The Indian Express*. Express Explained.Live is a unique series of explanatory conversations that *The Indian Express* hosts from time to time.

Expert Guests at Explained.Live sessions have included former Indian Ambassador to China Gautam Bambawale, former Foreign Secretary

Shyam Saran, former Indian Ambassador to US Arun K Singh, former Indian High Commissioner to Bangladesh Pinak Ranjan Chakravarty, former Indian Ambassador to Russia D B

Venkatesh Varma, former Foreign Secretary and Indian Ambassador to China Vijay Gokhale, former Deputy NSA Pan-kaj Saran, former Indian Ambassador to Nepal Ranjit Rae, former Indian High Commissioner to Pakistan T C A Raghavan, former G20 Sous Sherpa J S Mukul, former Indian Ambassador to the US, Taranjit Singh Sandhu, former Indian Ambassador to US, UK and Israel Navtej Sarna, among others.



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TOPIC: WAR IN THE MIDDLE EAST, WHERE IS IT HEADED, AND WHAT HAPPENS NOW

DATE: MARCH 19, 2026
TIME: 5:30 PM

US offers illegal immigrants \$2,600 bonus for self-exit; posts images from India, China

Press Trust of India

Washington, March 18

THE US Department of Homeland Security (DHS) has released posters offering to fly illegal immigrants, including from India, to their home countries for free with an exit bonus of \$2,600.

The DHS used an image of the Taj Mahal and prominent landmarks of Colombia and China to promote its self-deportation initiative targeted at illegal immigrants living in the US. “Receive a FREE flight home and a \$2,600 exit bonus when you use CBP Home to self-de-

port,” DHS said in a post on X.

The initiative, Project Homecoming, was launched in May 2025, after the inauguration of US President Donald Trump’s second term in office. The DHS has advised migrants to use the Customs and Border Protection (CBP) app to begin the process, allowing them to register their intent to leave the country voluntarily, submit their details, and access information about travel assistance and financial incentive offered under the programme. The DHS said that over 2.2 million illegal immigrants have availed of the scheme since

its launch in January 2025.

The current cost of a single enforced deportation is \$18,245. With the new offer of a \$2,600 stipend, the cost of a single self-deportation via the CBP Home App will be just \$5,100 saving the American taxpayer over USD 13,000 per illegal alien, the DHS said in a note in January. The programme provides migrants the chance to “return home as regular travellers without arrest, detention or restraints. It’s a safe, orderly alternative that provides assistance and flexibility, not fear”, according to the website.

Using the CBP Home app,

according to DHS, “allows illegal aliens to plan their return, including having an opportunity to depart in a timely manner allowing illegal aliens to wrap up work, school, and personal matters and organise their return in an orderly and lawful way”. When the programme was launched in May last year, the DHS was offering an exit bonus of \$1,000, which was tripled to \$3,000 during the holidays in December if the illegal aliens opted to leave before the new year.

The exit bonus was fixed at \$2,600 in January this year.

कार्यालय विशेष भूमि अध्याप्ति अधिकारी, मुरादाबाद शुद्धि-पत्र

18 अक्टूबर, 2025 ई०

सं० 627 / आउ-वि० भू० अ० अ० / मुरादाबाद / 2025-उत्तर प्रदेश राजकीय गजट दिनांक 18 अक्टूबर 2025 ई० (आश्विन 26, 1947 शक संवत्) के संस्करण में भाग 1-क हिन्दी खण्ड में प्रकाशित प्रारूप 19 नियम-27 का उपनियम (1) समुचित सरकार / कलेक्टर द्वारा घोषणा (अधिनियम की धारा-19 की उपधारा (1) के अन्तर्गत अधिसूचना की पृष्ठ सं० 1044 पर अनुसूची-क में क्रम सं०-2 में तहसील-बिलारी व क्रम सं०-3 में परगना-कुन्दरकी एवं पृष्ठ संख्या 1046 पर अंग्रेजी में क्रम सं०-2 में तहसील-बिलारी व क्रम सं०-3 में परगना-कुन्दर की उचित श्रृंखला है।

अतः भाग 1-क हिन्दी खण्ड में प्रकाशित अनुसूची की पृष्ठ संख्या-1044 पर अनुसूची की क्रम संख्या-2 पर तहसील-मुरादाबाद व अनुसूची की क्रम संख्या-3 पर परगना-मुरादाबाद पढ़ा जाए एवं पृष्ठ संख्या 1046 पर अंग्रेजी में क्रम सं०-2 में तहसील-मुरादाबाद व क्रम सं०-3 में परगना-मुरादाबाद पढ़ा जाए।

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विशेष भूमि अध्याप्ति अधिकारी,
मुरादाबाद।

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कार्यालय, नगर पालिक निगम, रतलाम (म.प्र.)

क्रमांक/69/PMAY/2026 ई-निविदा आमंत्रण रतलाम, दिनांक 17.03.2026

नगर पालिक निगम रतलाम द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु ऑन लाईन निविदा आमंत्रण की जाती है जिसकी विस्तृत जानकारी ऑन लाईन वेबसाइट <https://mptenders.gov.in> पर देखी जा सकती है:-

क्र.	ऑन लाईन निविदा क्र.	कार्य का विवरण	कार्य की समाप्ति	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य एवं EMD	निविदा की अंतिम तिथि
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नोट :- निविदा से संबंधित किसी प्रकार के संशोधन का प्रकाशन ऑनलाईन <https://mptenders.gov.in> की वेब साईट पर ही किया जावेगा, पृथक से समाचार पत्र में प्रकाशित नहीं किया जावेगा।

कार्यालाल यंत्री
नगर पालिक निगम, रतलाम

पुणे महानगरपालिका, पुणे

निविदा प्रक्रिया कक्ष- पाणीपुरवठा विभाग

निविदा जाहिरात - नविन कामे

विज्री कालावधी दिनांक :- १९/०३/२०२६, ०९.०० सकाळी ते १२/०४/२०२६, १४.३० दुपारी पर्यंत

स्वीकृती दिनांक :- १९/०३/२०२६, ०९.०० सकाळी ते १२/०४/२०२६, १४.३० दुपारी पर्यंत, तांत्रिक निविदा उघडणे प्रक्रिया दिनांक :- १३/०४/२०२६, १५.०० दुपारी

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अ) सदर कामाबाबत निविदा अटी/ शर्ती इ. बाबतचा सर्व तपशील निविदा संचामध्ये नमूद केला असून सदर कामाचे निविदा संच www.mahatenders.gov.in या वेबसाईटवर पाहण्यासाठी उपलब्ध आहे. निविदा संचाची विक्री व स्वीकृत सदर वेबसाईटवरून फक्त ऑनलाईन पद्धतीने करण्यात येत असून सर्व निविदा देण पकोट पद्धतीने मागविण्यात येत आहेत.

ब) निविदा विक्रीच्या शेवटच्या दिवशी संच प्राप्त न झाल्यास व स्वीकृतीच्या शेवटच्या दिवशी ऑनलाईन सादरीकरण न झाल्यास याची सर्वस्व जबाबदारी टेडडाराची गद्दील.

क) ऑनलाईन निविदा प्रक्रिया बाबतची संपूर्ण माहिती टेंडर सेल विभाग पुणे म.न.पा. येथे मिळेल.

ड) कार्यालयीन आदेश क्र.अतिमआ(वि.)/३२ दिनांक २२/०४/२०१६ नुसार बराणा रकम ई.सी.एस/ आर.टी.जी.एस/ एन.एफ.टी सुविधाफार्मच स्विकारण्यात येणार आहे.

स्वाक्षरी/-

टेंडर लिपिक

पाणीपुरवठा

पुणे महानगरपालिका

जाहिरात क्र. ३/२९१५

दि. १८/०३/२०२६

स्वाक्षरी/-

Satish Jadhav (Prabhari)

कार्यकारी अभियंता, पाणीपुरवठा विभाग

पुणे महानगरपालिका

NORTHERN RAILWAY
CORRIGENDUM
Ref:- i) Tender Notice No. 91/2025-2026 Dated 03.03.2026. S.N.-03
ii) Tender No. 07265006 due on 26.03.2026.
In reference to above tender, relevant drawings have been uploaded.
All other terms and condition remain unchanged.
The corrigendum has been published on website www.ireps.gov.in
932/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

CSB Bank
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PUBLIC NOTICE ON AUCTION OF PLEDGED GOLD ORNAMENTS

The borrower/s in specific and interested bidders in general, are hereby informed that on account of non-repayment of the Banks due by the borrowers as under despite the payment notice and recall/auCTION notice issued by the Bank, the gold ornaments pledged with the bank security by the respective borrowers for the loan availed by them will be sold in public auction on "as is where is" and "non-reserve" basis through e-auction portal <https://csbgold.auctiontiger.net> on **30 March, 2026 at 10.30 AM**. The auction may be adjourned to any other later date at the discretion of the bank upon publication of the same in the Bank's notice board. The borrowers are hereby further inform that the gold ornaments will be disposed of by private sale if the public auction is not successful and if there is a further balance to be recovered thereafter, legal action will be initiated against the borrowers for recovery of the balance amounts due to the Bank. In case of deceased borrower, all conditions will be applicable to legal heirs.

S. No.	Account Name	Client ID	No. of Acc.	Bal. Outstanding as on 17/03/2026	Weight (grams)
ASHOK VIHAR - DELHI					
1	Indu Jain	4819123	002	3,21,416.28	46.04
SHALIMARBAGH					
2	Indu Jain	4819123	002	5,29,374.99	82.52
DILSHAD GARDEN					
3	Mohd Tahir	4829058	001	2,55,804.94	35.90
BHAJANPURA - NEW DELHI					
4	Gautam Zubair	10025222	001	1,37,201.48	25.90
5		50685271	002	6,16,092.90	111.25
PASCHIM VIHAR					
6	Sonu	4874098	001	3,29,201.93	57.67
KALKAJI					
7	Gulshan Kumar	10028620	001	1,09,036.07	16.70

For more details/account wise information borrowers/interested bidders may contact respective branches and for participating in the auction, please visit/login to the e-auction portal <https://csbgold.auctiontiger.net>.

NCT of Delhi | 19.03.2026 Sd/- Authorized Officer, CSB Bank

GUJARAT MEDICAL SERVICES CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of Gujarat Undertaking)
Regd. Office: Block No. 14/1,
Dr. Jivraj Mehta Bhavan, Sector-10, Gandhinagar
☎ 079-23250767, 23250766, 23257698

TENDER NOTICE NO:GMSCL/ D-23/2025-26
Tenders are invited online from reputed Manufacturers/formulators/ Direct importers for X Ray Film on Rate contract basis and details of specification, quantity is available on, <https://gmscl.gujarat.gov.in> All tender documents can be downloaded free on the website: <https://tender.nprocure.com> Interested bidders are requested to submit the tender through e-tender process.
Duration of downloading of tender document (online):- 18/03/2026 to 02/04/2026 up to 18.00 Hrs
Last date for Submission (online): 02/04/2026 up to 18-00 HRS
Last date for submission of EMD/Tender Fee (Physical) : 04/04/2026 upto 18:00 HRS
Opening of Technical Bid Date (online): 07/04/2026 At 15-00 HRS.
Pre-Consultation meeting (Pre-Bid)
Interested Manufactures/formulators/Direct Importers are requested to remain present for Pre- Consultation meeting to be held on 25/03/2026 at 11.30 am at Committee room at above mentioned address. Only one representative from each Manufacturer carrying authority letter would be allowed to participate in the pre-bid.
INF-2854-2025-26
MANAGING DIRECTOR

मुख्य कार्यालय, विरार
सहायक नगर, विरार (प.) ता. वसई,
जि. पालघर-४०९ ३०२

दुखली : ०२५०-२५२९१०१/०२/०३/०४/०५/०६
फॅक्स : ०२५०-२५२९१०९
ई-मेल : vasavirarcorporation@yahoo.com
जा.क्र. : व.वि.श.म./राश/बांध/११०/२०२६
दिनांक : १८.०३.२०२६

जाहीर ई-निविदा सूचना करिता प्रथम मुदतवाढ
वसई-विरार महानगरपालिका कार्यक्षेत्रातील आचोटे सर्वे नं.६ येथे ४०० खाटांचे बहुविशेषज्ञ (Multispeciality) रुग्णालय उभारणे या कामासाठी कंत्राटदार नियुक्त करणेकामी जा.क्र.वविरारम/बांध/शअ/८५५/२०२६ दि. २५.०२.२०२६ अन्वयेची ई-निविदा सूचना <https://mahatenders.gov.in> या अधिकृत संकेतस्थळावर निविदा आयडी क्र.२०२६_VVCMC.१२८१६७९_१ दि. २७.०२.२०२६ रोजी प्रसिद्ध करून दि. २७.०२.२०२६ ते दि. २०.०३.२०२६ रोजी स. ११.०० वाजेपर्यंत ऑनलाईन मागविण्यात आली होती. सदर निविदेमधील स्विकृतीची अंतिम ताखी प्रशासकीय कारणास्तव पुढील प्रमाणे सुधारीत करण्यात येत आहे. मुदतवाढीचा तपशील खालील प्रमाणे.
१. ऑनलाईन ई-निविदा स्विकृतीचा अंतिम दिनांक :- दि. १०.०४.२०२६ सकाळी ११.०० वाजेपर्यंत
२. ऑनलाईन ई-निविदा उघडण्याचा दिनांक :- दि. १५.०४.२०२६ सकाळी ११.०० वाजता.

सही/-
(प्रदीप पाचगे)
प्र. शहर अभियंता
वसई-विरार शहर महानगरपालिका

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE
HEAD
CONSTABLE
GHANSHYAM
SINGH
15.07.1950 –
19.03.1998

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head constable Ghanshyam Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries fighting militants in Sopore (J&K) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

**CONSTABLE
JADEJA JAYRAJ
SINGH**
30.06.1975 –
19.03.2006

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan constable Jadeja Jayraj Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal injuries in Grenade blast, triggered by militants in Sopore, Baramulla (J&K) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

**CONSTABLE
KUMAR
PANDEY**
CT 30.09.1989 –
19.03.2022

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan constable Jitender Kumar Pandey on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he made ultimate sacrifice while on operational duty in Dhubri area, Assam.

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE
DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Pritam Chand of 128 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely countering an ambush by militants in Beerwah, Budgam, Jammu & Kashmir on 19 March 2004. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

INDO-TIBETAN BORDER POLICE (ITBP)
Dy. Commandant
Ajit Kishore
Narain

ITBP salutes its braveheart Dy. Commandant Ajit Kishore Narain of 2nd Battalion, who made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty on this day in Ladakh in 2001.

Andhra Pradesh State FiberNet Limited

Proposals are invited from interested agencies for the following Request for Proposal (RFP)s
1. Selection of Agency for Supply and Installation of Batteries (under Buyback) to APSFL
2. Selection of an AMC Service Provider for UPS Systems in APSFL Network - Set 1
3. Selection of an AMC Service Provider for UPS Systems in APSFL Network - Set 2
4. Selection of an Agency for Providing Pickup Vehicles for the Fiber Restoration Team of APSFL.
Details of the RFPs and corrigenda may be downloaded from e-procurement platform tender.apeprocurement.gov.in
Sd/- Manager (Procurement), APSFL
DIPR No.4925PP/CL/ADVT/1/1/2021-22, Dt.18/03/2026

KONKAN RAILWAY CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of India Undertaking)
USBRIL Project office, Reasi, Jyotipuram Road, Timtha, Post Gran Morh Reasi (Dist. Reasi) J&K, 182311, Tele/Fax: 01981-245316.

NOTICE INVITING OPEN-E-TENDER (Two-Packet System)
Konkan Railway Corporation Ltd. Invites tender for "COMPREHENSIVE MAINTENANCE (BREAKDOWN/ PREVENTIVE) WORKS OF RAILWAY ELECTRIFICATION WORKS INCLUDING ROCS & FOCs SYSTEM FOR 05 YEARS IN THE KATRA (Excl.) to BANIHAL (Excl.) SECTION OF UDHAMPUR-SRINAGAR- BARAMULLA RAIL LINK PROJECT, JAMMU & KASHMIR." Tender Notice No. KR-PD-JK-EL-CMC-RE-KB-3-2026, dated 09.03.2026. Approx. Cost of the work: Rs. 73.22 Cr. Completion period of contract: 60 months. Submission of Tender: 04/04/2026 upto 12:00 hrs. Opening of Tender: 04.04.2026 @ 12:30 hrs. Cost of Tender Form: Nil. Earnest Money / Bid Security: Rs. 38,10,900/- to be submitted through online payment modes available on IREPS Portal only. For further details and updates please visit <https://www.ireps.gov.in>. Amendments/ Corrigendum, if any would be hosted on the above website only.

SABARMATI RIVER FRONT DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LTD (SRFDCL)
2nd Floor, "Riverfront House", Behind H.K. Arts College, Between Gandhi & Nehru Bridge, Pujya Pramukh Swami Marg (Riverfront-West), Ahmedabad-380009 Tel / Fax : +91-79-26580430
Email: srfdp.amc@gmail.com website : www.sabarmatiriverfront.com

NOTICE INVITING e-RE-TENDER
SRFDCL Re-invites e-tender for the work "Construction of Tropical Garden in Usmanpura Park including Civil, Glass Dome, Plumbing, Electrical, ELV, HVAC, Fire Fighting & Horticultural work on West Bank of River Sabarmati"
Bid document is available on websites: <https://www.tender.nprocure.com> The information available on websites www.sabarmatiriverfront.com.
The last date for Submission is **30th April, 2026 up to 16.00 Hrs.** Pre-bid meeting for the same will be held on **15th April, 2026** at the office of SRFDCL at 3:00 p.m.

The Indian EXPRESS
~ FOUNDED BY ~
RAMNATH GOENKA
◆ IN 1932 ◆
BECAUSE THE TRUTH
INVOLVES US ALL

Killing Iran's leaders is fraught and escalatory

As the war launched by the US and Israel on Iran enters its third week, the killing of Ali Larjani, secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, by Israel and the strikes on South Pars, part of the world's largest gas-field, mark an escalation both rapid and perilous. Larjani's killing is another damaging blow to the regime after the killing of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei on the war's first day. Together with the killing of Basij commander Gholamreza Soleimani, this decapitation strategy is one Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu believes could create the conditions for a popular uprising in Iran. On the evidence so far, the targeting of high-ranking leaders, one by one, has done little to rally the Iran street — instead, it could have shrunk the space for any diplomatic spadework that will, inevitably, have to follow the conflict once the pieces need to be picked up.

History is replete with attempts at regime change that led to instability and chaos, leaving power vacuums for armed groups to exploit. In the case of Iran, however, that may not necessarily be a downside for Israel. Unlike the US, which has extensive economic and defence ties with Gulf states, Israel's leadership may well view a prolonged war and an unstable Iran as favourable outcomes, not least in an election year for Netanyahu. The resignation letter of Joe Kent, director of the National Counterterrorism Centre, says the US "started this war due to pressure from Israel and its powerful American lobby". This has come amid continuing lack of clarity in President Donald Trump's war aims and claims. Despite Trump's efforts to draw NATO into the conflict by pressing allies to deploy warships to open up the Strait of Hormuz, countries across Europe, as well as Japan, Australia, and Canada, have held firm in their refusal, leaving the US largely isolated, alongside Israel. US allies are justified in being cautious against joining a war they never supported.

India's energy security depends heavily on the Gulf and the uninterrupted flow of traffic through the Strait of Hormuz. Nearly 1 crore Indian citizens live and work in the region, making both their welfare and the flow of remittances vital national interests. India has done well to keep all lines of communication open. Delhi's understated diplomacy is beginning to show results: Last weekend, two Indian-flagged LPG carriers crossed the Strait. Undoubtedly, India and Israel share a growing, close strategic partnership that has strengthened in recent years. But Delhi must remain alert to the rapid escalation as it risks moving towards a point where Indian and Israeli interests begin to diverge.

A Bill that narrows, not expands, rights

IF DEMOCRACY is based on the individuality and dignity of man... we have to recognise the right of a human being to choose his/her gender identity, which is integral to his/her personality and is one of the most basic aspects of self-determination, dignity, and freedom." With these words, the Supreme Court in *NALSA vs Union of India* (2014) recognised the third gender as a category and trans persons' right to determine their own gender identity as integral to the right to life and dignity. The protections and rights assured by NALSA and the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019, could now be undermined by the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026.

The Bill limits the definition of who the state would recognise as a transgender person to biological and cultural markers: "A person having such socio-cultural identities as kinn(a)r, hijra, aravani and jogta...", intersex people and persons who have been "forced" to present as transgender. This means the state would cease to recognise the right to choose one's own gender identity, excluding lakhs of people for whom the legislation was framed — trans men, trans women outside the communities listed, genderqueer, and non-binary people. To identify and protect a "genuine" class of "oppressed" transgender persons, the Bill proposes the examination of trans persons by a district medical board. It fails to recognise that sex may be physically determined, gender identity is not. It is also impossible to diagnose "oppression" through medical examination. Many in the process of transitioning and/or acquiring fresh documents will be left in limbo, and those outside recognised categories may see their documents invalidated. By making it mandatory for medical institutions to share details of persons undergoing gender-affirming surgeries with the DM, the Bill violates the right to privacy enshrined in *Puttaswamy* (2018).

While the larger objective of the Bill — wider implementation of protections and welfare measures — is worthy, the solution cannot be a narrowing of categories. Instead, institutional capacity, political will and understanding must be expanded. At a time when the world is seeing a rollback in the scant protections for trans people, India has the opportunity to offer its citizens safety, autonomy, and dignity. It should not, instead, walk back on rights.

Spy writer who taught young men to cook

IN 1962, a few weeks after the first James Bond film, *Dr No*, opened to full houses, another spy thriller caught the attention of book lovers. In several ways, it was the antithesis to the Ian Fleming-scripted blockbuster — its title, *Ipcress Files*, an acronym for "Induction of Psychoneuroses by Conditioned Reflex under Stress", and its unnamed protagonist, a gritty civil servant, at home with office memos and bureaucratic rivalries. The book went on to sell more than 2 million copies in three years, establishing its writer, Len Deighton, who died on Monday, as a major voice in Cold War spy fiction. While *Dr No* found it difficult to fathom that the Sun had set on the British Empire, Deighton's protagonist is unabashedly worldly — he solves crosswords, loves to rile his boss, cooks, and enjoys the smell of roasted chicken stuffed with pine-nuts and spices. He wears ill-fitting jackets and in his tinsel avatar — where he gets a name, Harry Palmer — Deighton's spy wears glasses.

By the early '70s, Deighton had cemented his place among writers such as Eric Ambler and John le Carré, who challenged spy fiction's hero mythology, and whose characters were often aware of the compromises demanded by their profession. Deighton's work was also distinguished by its understated wit. His 1970 work, *Bomber*, was praised as one of the finest post-war British novels. But it was also criticised for empathising with ordinary Germans at the receiving end of the British counter to the Blitz.

Deighton also brought his storytelling skills to works on popular history. His "Cookstrips", illustrated step-by-step recipes in *The Observer*, were meant to nudge "young men living away from home to take up cooking". Like several of his other works, that, too, was an evocative idea.



THAROORTHINK
BY SHASHI THAROOR

IN THE last couple of weeks, many Indian liberals have turned their ire inward, accusing those of us who have not condemned the government's silence on the US-Israeli war against Iran of moral cowardice. In the American phrase, it has become a "circular firing squad" — shooting on ourselves. They want us all to demand that India should have taken the moral high ground, denouncing the war as a flagrant violation of international law.

Let me state clearly: I concur that the war cannot be justified under international law. It violates the very principles India has historically stood for — respect for sovereignty, non-aggression, and peaceful resolution of disputes. Nor, as I have explained earlier, is there a case for pre-emptive self-defence either. And yes, we should have promptly issued condolences on the death of the Supreme Leader of Iran, as we had done when its president was killed in a helicopter crash. I am free to say so, and so are my liberal friends in the Opposition or the commentariat. But I will not condemn the government for choosing silence over confrontation.

India's diplomacy has always been about balancing principle with pragmatism. Jawaharlal Nehru's policy of non-alignment was not a refusal to take moral positions, but a recognition that India's sovereignty and survival depended on avoid-

ing entanglement in Cold War hostilities. Today, in an increasingly multipolar world, India practises "multi-alignment" — engaging with diverse powers, sometimes in tension with one another, while keeping our national interest paramount.

The objective has remained constant: Protect India's sovereignty while speaking for global justice. No one holds a monopoly over patriotism, nor over the interpretation of the values taught by Gandhi or Nehru. The true tribute to their legacy lies in applying their values wisely to the realities of our time, not in self-gratifying denunciations that could jeopardise our interests.

Critics forget that India has often chosen silence when principles collided with national interest. We were reluctant to condemn the Soviet Union's flagrant violations of international law in Hungary (1956), Czechoslovakia (1968), and Afghanistan (1979). Why? Because we rightly judged that we had too much at stake in our relationship with Moscow to antagonise it with a moralistic stand. The Soviet Union was our principal arms supplier, a crucial diplomatic partner, and a counterweight to Western hostility.

That silence did not mean we endorsed Soviet aggression. It meant we understood the costs of confrontation and chose prudence over posturing. Today, the same logic applies to our stand on the Russian invasion of Ukraine and the Israeli-American assault on Iran.

India has far too much at stake, not only in the US, but in the Gulf Arab states currently facing Iranian missile and drone attacks. Nearly \$200 billion in annual trade flows through this region. Our energy security depends on Gulf oil and gas. And the well-being of some 9 million Indian workers and residents in the Gulf is directly tied to regional stability.

We were reluctant to condemn the Soviet Union's flagrant violations of international law in Hungary (1956), Czechoslovakia (1968), and Afghanistan (1979). Why? Because we rightly judged that we had too much at stake

A German scholar, pioneer of India's regional history writing



RANABIR CHAKRAVARTI

A BUDDING GERMAN scholar, barely 23, came to a Buddhist monastery in Sri Lanka as a tutorial assistant for two months in 1959. He then undertook an exceptional train journey from the south of India, through the Deccan and the northern plains up to Amritsar and Lahore, and then hitch-hiked across the Khyber Pass. His journeys across South Asia would have pleased Xuanzang (the 7th-century CE Chinese Buddhist pilgrim). He visited several historic and sacred sites (including Thanjavur, Badami, Ajanta, Sanchi, Varanasi and Agra) and remembered the travels as his *tirtha-yatra*. It would be the beginning of his six-decade-long association with India. The scholar was Professor Hermann Kulke, one of the most respected German experts on South Asian History, who passed away on March 10.

Kulke began by studying German History, Sociology and Political Science, but soon felt drawn to South Asian History by reading Heinrich Zimmer and Wilhelm Rau. He turned to Indology at the University of Freiburg as a doctoral scholar. Although he received rigorous training in German Indology, Kulke was never enamoured of the Aryan question, which, as he pointed out, was "a major ideological prop of German Fascism". A close reading of Max Weber aroused in Kulke a deep interest in Indic systems. The result was his groundbreaking doctoral dissertation on the sacred centre of Chidambaram. It involved a critical analysis of the *Chidambaram-mahatmyam*, which enabled new perspectives on the Cholas.

The growing appeal of the Bhakti cults from 600 CE onwards, emerging first in South India and then proliferating on a pan-India scale, coincided with the rise of numerous political powers at local and supra-local levels. These emergent polities often sought legitimisation through sacred ideologies and rituals. Kulke delved deep into the formation of regional states with his research on the history of the Jagannath cult and the polity of Odisha under the Eastern Gangas and the Gajapatis (twice leading the Orissa Research Project of the German Academic Council). These forays brought the premodern polities

of Odisha to global attention. Besides publications on the Jagannath cult, his *Kings and Cults* (1993) revealed the interactions between *kshatra* (power) and *kshetra* (sacred centres) in Odisha and South India. It also set the stage for his seminal contributions to premodern political processes — *The State in India 1000-1700* and the books he co-edited with B P Sahu, *Interrogating Political Systems: Integrative Processes and States in Pre-modern India*, *The Routledge Handbook of the State in Premodern India* and *History of Precolonial India: Issues and Debates*. These works highlighted the process of state-making "from within" at local and regional levels.

Along with Sahu and another close friend, BD Chattopadhyaya, Kulke critiqued nationalist historians' thrust on centralised and unitary polity, the Marxist perception of the decentralised polity under feudalism, and the segmented polity model. They presented, with empirical richness and conceptual strength, the alternative process of "integrative polity" that gave centrality to the regional profiles of powers.

Kulke was equally at home with South Asian and Southeast Asian pasts. His contributions to the study of the Angkor state in Cambodia, the Javanese polity and the Chola overseas campaigns in Southeast Asia and Sri Lanka have brought about lasting historiographical shifts. He did not subscribe to R C Majumdar's claim of the Hindu colonies in the Far East or George Coedes' perception of the indianised states of South East Asia. Instead, he demonstrated the cultural convergence on both sides of the Bay of Bengal that resulted in socio-economic, political and cultural interactions between South and Southeast Asia. Sahu and Chattopadhyaya passed away in 2022. The passing away of the remaining member of the trio will leave a deep void in Indian historiography.

Generous and helpful to the fault, especially to young scholars, Kulke was an admirer of India and Indians. His many students, both in Germany and in India, will not only fondly remember him, but will surely further enrich the fields Kulke opened up.

The writer is a historian



GEORGE JOHN

TRUTH AND falsehood are not just opposing statements; they are rival ways of living together. Lies — especially when amplified by power or prestige — can circle the world before patient fact has laced its boots. We live in a "post-truth" age, where feelings often seem to weigh more than evidence and where every claim can be dismissed as "just your narrative". Yet, ordinary life still depends on some shared sense that words ought to answer to reality. When that weakens, everything else begins to wobble.

What, then, do we mean by "truth"? Philosophers speak of correspondence (our words matching the world), coherence (our beliefs hanging together), and pragmatism (truth as what "works" in experience). In practice, we borrow from all three. A doctor, a judge, or a journalist needs statements that fit the facts, make sense within a wider picture, and continue to survive serious questioning. Truth-seeking is less a static possession than a disciplined habit: Gather evidence, listen to objections, revise when necessary, and still be willing to say, "On present evidence, this is what we should believe." Plural perspectives do not mean anything goes. Different angles on reality can be partial without being arbitrary. Humility here is a virtue: The willingness to admit limits and learn from those who see what we have missed.

If truth matters so much, why do falsehoods flourish? Part of the answer is motivational: Lies can be comforting, convenient, or profitable. Part of it is structural: Rumours and half-truths are easy to share, while verification is slow and unglamorous. And part of it is what the philosopher Harry Frankfurt called "bull****": Unlike the ordinary liar who still pays tribute to truth by trying to conceal it, the bull****er saws off the very branch on which public trust sits. Power deepens the damage. From totalitarian propaganda to today's flood of contradictory messages, those who control megaphones can blur the line between fact and fiction. When citizens no longer know whom to trust, many retreat into cynicism or cling to their tribe's preferred story. Most victims of misinformation are not wicked; they are human. We all prefer information that fits what we already believe. We are overwhelmed by headlines, clips, and forwards. In this environment, "cognitive ease" — what feels familiar — often masquerades as truth.

So, what can we do? We can practise a few modest disciplines. First, triangulation: Don't rely on a single source; look for independent confirmation. Second, provenance: Ask who is saying this, how they know it, and what they stand to gain. Third, conversational ethics: Argue to understand, not just to win; try to restate an opponent's view fairly before criticising it. Fourth, character: Cultivate the habit of admitting, "I was wrong." We cannot purge public life of lies, but we can dilute their power. A truthful society is not one in which everyone agrees, but one in which disagreement is conducted with shared respect for reality. That requires courage, patience, and humility.

The writer is a retired psychiatrist

40 YEARS AGO

March 19, 1986



Sobhraj aide surrenders

DINESH, ONE of the six persons who escaped with the dreaded international criminal Charles Sobhraj, surprised police officers when he returned to the jail. He was subsequently arrested by the police, who had taken into custody the deputy jail superintendent, V D Pushkama, and warden Prem Bahadur, for allegedly having a hand in the conspiracy regarding Sobhraj's escape from jail.

Sobhraj met Tihar officials

CHARLES SOBHRAJ, the dreaded international criminal, had an extraordinary meeting with two senior officials of Tihar

Central Jail about an hour before he escaped. It was not an official meeting. The two deputy superintendents who met him, B S Jarial and H C Verma, were not in charge of the part of jail where Sobhraj was kept. The meeting was arranged in no: 1 section of the jail. Sobhraj was called there from no: 3 section at about 11 am. The meeting lasted an hour.

Amritsar SP attacked

An attempt was made on the life of the Amritsar District Superintendent of Police (CID), Harjeet Singh, while another person was stabbed to death in Ludhiana in the last 24 hours. Harjeet Singh had a narrow escape when some unidentified persons, sus-

pected to be terrorists, fired Sten sub-machine gun shots at his car near his house on Taylor Road in Chandigarh.

Clashes in Jalandhar

The Sri Lankan government is preparing an autonomy plan as part of a political solution to the island's ethnic crisis, reliable sources said in Colombo. The initial step would be to set up a provincial council in the disputed eastern province, which would have a chief minister at its head, the sources said. The new plan falls short of a merger of the northern and eastern provinces as demanded by the Tamil United Liberation Front (TULF), the main Tamil political party.



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How to define an ancient hill range? By protecting a delicate balance



ANOOP SINGH

AS A new committee of experts is set to take up what appears to be an increasingly vexatious task of defining an ancient hill range, I feel compelled to put on record why, as then director general (DG), Forest Survey of India (FSI), I opposed the definition based on 100 m elevation for the Aravalli.

It is also as good a time as any to remember why it may not be necessary to reinvent the wheel, because the Aravalli hills were meticulously mapped back in 2011 by the FSI under a very able director general, the late R D Jakati.

Pursuant to the Supreme Court (SC) order dated February 19, 2010, the central empowered committee of the SC assigned the task of mapping mining areas in the Aravalli hills of Rajasthan to the FSI.

Subsequently, after failing to obtain any map of Aravalli Hills and Ranges from other mapping agencies, the FSI embarked upon the arduous task of mapping by itself and submitted the delineated map of the Aravalli hills for 15 districts of Rajasthan on April 13, 2011.

The issue was revisited when a committee of secretaries and representatives of technical institutions was constituted, as per directions of the SC on May 9, 2024, to find an uniform definition of Aravalli Hills and Ranges.

The committee submitted its report in its affidavit on October 3, 2025. As DG, FSI, I was a member of the committee and had opposed the definition based on 100 m elevation above a reference level due to its serious environmental impacts. After the SC judgment on November 20, 2025, multiple reports by this newspaper led to protests by environmentalists. On December 29, the SC stayed the November judgment with directions to form a new

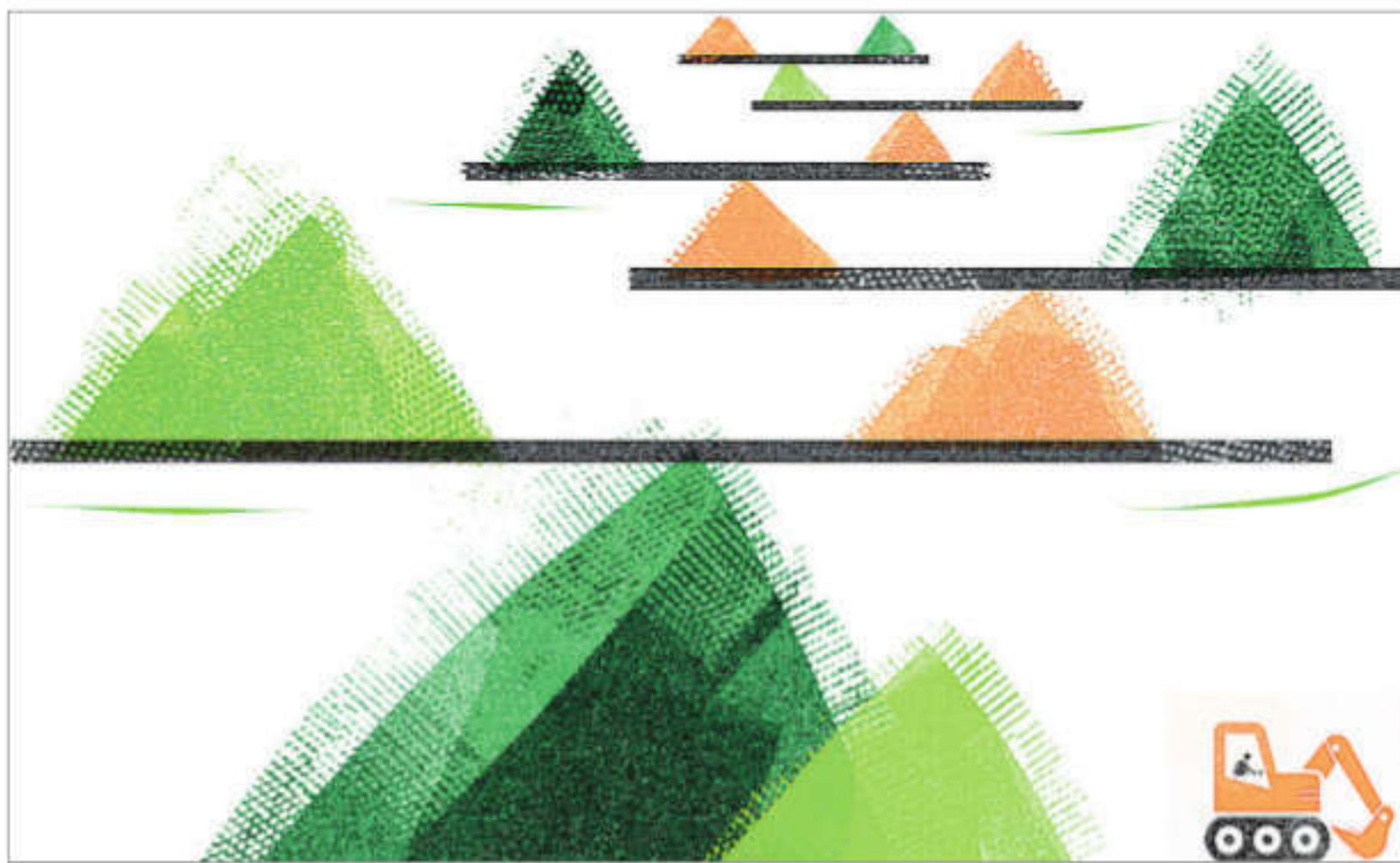


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

Aravalli region in Rajasthan

Total number of hills: **1,18,575**

HILL HEIGHT (M)	NO. OF HILLS
≥ 20	12,081
≥ 40	5,009
≥ 60	2,656
≥ 80	1,594
≥ 100	1,048

Number of Aravalli Districts

STATE	AS PER FOREST SURVEY OF INDIA*	AS PER ENVIRONMENT SECY-LED PANEL**
Rajasthan	36 of 41 new districts	20 of 41 new districts
Haryana	9	7
Gujarat	9	5
Delhi	8	5
Total	62	37

* REPORT DATED 22 SEP 2025 ** AFFIDAVIT TO SC DATED 3 OCT 2025

committee to examine the issue.

While this committee is in the process of being set up, I think it is important to highlight a few points:

The recent analysis on the Aravalli hills and their definition, extent, distribution, demarcation and altitudinal zonation was done during my tenure as DG, FSI. I studied the application of remote sensing and GIS from ITC, The Netherlands, and spent six months at ESRI, USA. I may claim a modest understanding of the technology.

It is also as good a time as any to remember why it may not be necessary to reinvent the wheel because the Aravalli hills were meticulously mapped back in 2011 by the FSI

While serving as DG, I had analysed the data for 15 districts of Rajasthan to ascertain the impact of excluding hills below 100 m from the Aravalli. Only 15 (erstwhile of 2011) districts were used because the Rajasthan government had earlier stated that the Aravalli is spread over only these 15 districts.

Digitised contours of these 15 districts were available with the FSI. The contour dataset was digitised painstakingly from 1:50,000 Survey of India topographic sheets in 2011. Based on this dataset, the

FSI had proposed to the SC the boundary of Aravalli hills using 3-degree slope criteria in 2011. The results of the analyses carried out by the FSI in 2025 were reported by this newspaper last November (see table 1).

In order to answer the SC's query on the accuracy of this study, it needs to be repeated by the proposed committee, without changing the Survey of India sheets-based dataset created during the tenure of former DG FSI Jakati.

According to the FSI's report dated September 22, 2025, as many as 62 districts qualify to be included in the Aravalli. In comparison, the environment secretary's committee listed only 37 districts in their affidavit on October 3, 2025. Even prominent districts such as Sawai Madhopur and Chittaurgarh, famous for their forts, were excluded from the list of Aravalli districts by the secretary's committee, even though they were included in the Aravalli Green Wall Project and also in the Ministry of Culture's UNESCO World Heritage sites as "Hill Forts of Rajasthan".

The districts to be included along with reasons for inclusion have been mentioned in detail in the FSI's report. As the table shows, the omission is stark (see table 2) and, if not rectified, the hills are destined to be obliterated in many districts without even being heard.

The new committee should also refer to FSI's September 2025 report to take note of the reasons why various government agencies — such as the environment ministry, the Ministry of Culture, Central Ground Water Board, Geological Survey of India etc — have been including these districts under the Aravalli.

The new committee may also like to re-examine the robustness of the 3-degree slope criteria adopted by the FSI earlier as it is time-tested and identifies the hills in the Aravalli region quite accurately.

Rajasthan has only 8 per cent geographical area under forest and tree cover (ISFR, 2023) and the majority of this lies in the Aravalli region. The utmost care needs to be taken not to disturb this delicate balance.

Singh is former director general, Forest Survey of India

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Dowry cases

IN A country where countless undertrial prisoners accused of petty theft languish for years in overcrowded jails, the spectacle of alleged dowry-related murderers being set free through what appear to be run-of-the-mill bail orders is deeply troubling ('A case of gender injustice', *IE*, March 18). The tragedy of our times lies not merely in crime but in the perception of prejudice within the justice system itself. Bail jurisprudence must rest on clear principles to avoid legal loopholes, especially in grave offences like dowry death that reflect entrenched social violence.

Harsh Pawaria, Rohtak

War aims

THE CALLS for a regime change in Iran may appear strategically decisive, but history suggests otherwise ('In war on Iran, Israel knows what it wants — US does not', *IE*, March 17). In Iraq and Afghanistan, rapid military success was followed by prolonged instability due to the absence of credible post-conflict political frameworks. Removing a regime is far easier than rebuilding a functioning state. Iran presents an even more complex challenge, with deeply embedded institutions and ideological cohesion. External pressure is more likely to strengthen internal unity than trigger collapse.

Sudip Kumar Dey, Barasat

Energy insecurity

What we are witnessing is not calculated diplomacy but a forced retreat born out of domestic insecurities and economic missteps ('Return of Russian oil signals US pragmatism', *IE*, March 16). The US is cornered by the mounting pressure of gas prices at home, and the waiver is less a strategic lever than a necessary evil to stave off backlash. Energy inflation has already been a key driver of broader price instability, with the US Bureau of Labour Statistics reporting that fuel costs contributed disproportionately to the Consumer Price Index increases over the past year. Washington cannot afford another shock.

Abhinav Shah, Lucknow



RAJAN KUMAR

WEST ASIA continues to be trapped in a deadly conflict with no end in sight. Most recently, Iran's security chief, Ali Larijani, and the paramilitary force Basij's commander, Gholamreza Soleimani, have been killed. The conflict has claimed over 1,300 lives, energy prices have hit the roof, and global security is at stake. But the global response remains tepid and perfunctory, marked by strategic ambivalence and risk aversion. The world is drifting towards disorder in the absence of collective action, owing to leadership paralysis. European leaders have abdicated their obligations, while the leaders of the Global South are reluctant to coordinate a joint response. Every state is apprehensive of disrupting its ties with Washington and souring relations with the unpredictable US President Donald Trump.

The central dilemma facing every state is: Who will bell the cat? Every state recognises the threat to global security, but each remains averse to initiating action, fearing punitive measures by Washington and uncertain outcomes. The middle powers expect the powerful countries to assume leadership, while the powerful states fear entrapment and uncertain support from the middle powers. Two sets of actors have economic and diplomatic capabilities to change the course of the war and restore the global order: The European coun-

Trump is not worried about the EU, given its dependence on the US. However, the combined strength of Brazil, Russia, India, and China will certainly serve as a deterrent

tries and the leaders of the Global South. But unfortunately, while Europe does not want to disrupt its alliance with Washington, BRICS countries appear equally apprehensive of antagonising Trump and thus prefer strategic restraint.

The European states do not view this as a necessary war, and most of them ignored Trump's exhortation to join it. Kaja Kallas, EU foreign policy chief, stated that Europe feels slighted because it was not consulted and because the US has no clear objectives. Trump expressed his displeasure with most NATO members because they refused to deploy their militaries to ensure free navigation in the Strait of Hormuz. However, their action is unlikely to move beyond non-cooperation. No European state blamed Trump squarely for initiating a war. In contrast, European states and experts were quick to blame the Iranian regime. Compared to the European stance on Russia, its posture on Iran is revealing. It invoked international law and sovereignty in condemning Russia's invasion of Ukraine, but is restrained even in using words against the US.

More striking, however, is the absence of strong statements and condemnations from the BRICS countries. The war has entered its third week, and there is a serious risk of escalation, but BRICS has not issued a joint statement condemning the US-Israel action. For an organisation whose politics

centres around countering Western hegemony and which draws legitimacy from the Global South, its inaction is woefully inadequate. In a modest statement, it called for a ceasefire and urged dialogue and consultation. The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation issued a joint statement without naming or blaming anyone.

Ideally, BRICS should have taken concrete measures immediately. BRICS members — including the UAE, a US ally — have diverse interests. However, powerful actors such as China, Russia, India, and Brazil have higher stakes in global stability. BRICS states reiterate the cause of sovereignty and non-interference at every multilateral forum, but when it comes to concrete measures, their approach is lacklustre. In such a scenario, its credibility becomes suspect. It must not allow the world to hurtle towards a disorder where the powerful do what they can while the weak suffer what they must.

As the chair of BRICS, it is incumbent upon India to mobilise members. The Trump administration is not worried about the EU, given its dependence on the US. However, the combined strength of Brazil, Russia, India, and China will certainly serve as a deterrent. The question is: Will the leaders of these countries put aside their differences and coordinate action to send a powerful message? One cannot be sure.

The writer is professor, School of International Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University, Delhi

BRICS should step in, restrain US-Israel



a public cause and demand public accountability from the authorities. It started with the SC taking cognisance of a newspaper report describing the appalling condition of prisoners languishing in Bihar jails without trial, notwithstanding the fact that they had already undergone the maximum sentence for the crimes they had allegedly committed. Treating the report as a writ petition, it directed the release of nearly 40,000 prisoners and gave a go-by to the *locus standi* rule, where only the aggrieved person could approach a High Court or the SC for justice. It is the judiciary that, through various pronouncements, has given an expansive definition to Article 21, which guarantees to every person the right to life and personal liberty, so as to include in its sweep the right to live with dignity rather than mere existence.

This should not be taken to mean that the judiciary is a paragon of virtue. It has its failings, too. Its judgment in *ADM Jabalpur* — holding that when an Emergency is in operation, the right to life and personal liberty under Article 21 would stand suspended — is still etched in the minds of the people. There is a growing feeling that while the rich and powerful have easy access to justice, the poor and marginalised rot in jail endlessly, waiting to be heard. While Ashish Mishra — accused in the deaths of eight people in Lakhimpur Kheri — gets bail, Umar Khalid is condemned to the prison's four walls, even though he has spent more than five years in custody without trial. Corruption in the judiciary is not hidden from anyone: Not long ago, wads of burnt currency notes were found at the house of an HC judge. Certainly, the judiciary needs to make a course correction in a big way. One hopes the SC, while acting to protect the judiciary's honour, keeps in mind that at times, it too has failed the Constitution, and that where and when it so fails, the citizen has a right to say so, sometimes in whispers and at times loudly.

The writer is a former judge of the Delhi High Court

Let's talk about menstrual leave, who bears the cost



MITALI NIKORE

LAST WEEK, when the Supreme Court refused to hear a PIL on a national policy for menstrual leaves, it stated, "The moment it is introduced as a compulsory condition, you do not know the amount of damage you are going to do to their (women employees') career. Nobody will give them big responsibility."

Are menstrual leaves indeed a structural barrier to enhancing women's labour force participation? Or will they, in fact, facilitate women's retention as they legally allow the rest required during painful, debilitating period pain?

The evidence, unfortunately, seems to point in the direction of employer discrimination. A parallel can be drawn with what happened after the Maternity Benefit Act,

2017 introduced a six-month, employer-funded maternity leave. Purna Banerjee, Shreya Biswas, and Debojyoti Mazumder ('Maternity Leave and Labour Market Outcomes', 2025) show that the policy significantly reduced the employment probability for women in the high-fertility age group (ages 20-29), especially in high-skilled occupations with high wages in the formal sector.

The formulation of the law is critical. Spain, the only Western economy to have a national law on menstrual leave, requires a doctor's certificate and bears the cost through publicly funded social security. The cost of the leave is not on the employer, thereby reducing the chances of discrimination.

So where do we go from here? Here are a few things to consider. One, we need more quantitative evidence on whether paid period leaves result in employer discrimination and what it does to women's labour productivity and retention. We need studies that

provide comparative analysis; a cross-state comparison, possibly across Karnataka and Odisha — early adopters of a menstrual leave policy — with other states that do not have paid period leave. Or a comparative firm-level analysis of companies that offer paid period leaves versus those that don't. This will allow policymakers to make data-driven, evidence-based decisions.

Two, we need a national menstrual hygiene policy that covers all menstruating persons. Menstrual health management

Companies are beginning to recognise that offering period leaves or work-from-home options improves employee morale, increases loyalty, and boosts labour productivity

(MHM) initiatives cannot be limited to rural schoolgirls. MHM policy is needed for all menstruating persons — working and non-working. And such a policy needs to go beyond subsidised sanitary pads. It can introduce financial incentives for sanitary napkin manufacturing, issue guidelines for provision of sanitary napkins and MHM infrastructure at workplaces and additional medical leaves for persons with severe period pain (similar to Spain, maybe). It can even look into protocols for period pain management.

Three, building on the foundations laid by the Swachh Bharat Mission, we now need a Swachh Bharat, Sashakt Nari Mission to build or upgrade toilets for women and girls in public spaces and workplaces. Under this mission, CSR funding can support municipal corporations, public transport authorities, industrial areas, market associations, and other public spaces, expand sanitation infrastructure, improve

maintenance and cleanliness of women's toilets across public spaces.

We need more empathy and flexibility. Even without legal mandates, some companies are beginning to recognise that offering period leaves or work-from-home options for menstruators who require rest/medical attention improves employee morale, increases loyalty, and boosts labour productivity. Private companies can offer flexible work arrangements or even leaves, as a benefit to their employees who menstruate, per their choice.

It's unlikely that this debate will die down any time soon. And that's a good thing. Because even as we keep debating the merits and demerits of a law on period leave, governments, private companies, and community-based organisations can keep working to make the world a slightly easier place for menstruating persons.

The writer is founder, Nikore Associates



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• POLITICS

Language row in Karnataka that led to cancellation of Railways exam

Kiran Parashar
Bengaluru, March 18

THE SOUTH Western Railway (SWR) was forced to postpone a recruitment examination on Tuesday after a pro-Kannada outfit protested near exam centres across Karnataka, objecting to the test being conducted only in English and Hindi. SWR's action was all the more notable in a state that has had a history of protests over language, with pro-Kannada activists frequently resorting to vandalism and violence. Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah posted on X: "Despite peaceful protests, the department failed to respond in time, cancelling the examinations at the last moment and leading to the present confusion."

What was the examination in question?

The Mysuru Division of the SWR issued a notification on February 25, 2025 for a promotion exam. Such exams are held for Group 'C' and 'D' employees, giving them an opportunity for promotion. It was to be held for 194 Goods Train Manager



Pro-Kannada protesters in Bengaluru on Tuesday. PTI

posts, with a 60% quota for existing employees. On November 5, 2025 another notification was issued for 101 posts under the Limited Departmental Competitive Examination with a 15% promotional quota. Both exams were scheduled for March 17.

According to the candidates, the examination notification mentioned a three-language policy when it was first released, meaning it would be conducted in English, Hindi and Kannada. However, a later notification only mentioned Hindi and English. In a letter dated February 12, the All India OBC Railway Employees Association wrote to the General Manager of the SWR and demanded that the examinations be conducted as per the official language policy of the Government of India, and that, in its absence, Kannada-speaking employees faced disadvantages.

According to Railway Board guidelines issued in a July 8, 1992 circular, all departmental examinations must be conducted in three languages — Hindi, English, and the respective regional language. South Indian states have long stressed the need for a three-language policy in recruitment concerning Public Sector Banks, the Indian Railways and other central agencies to encourage local recruitment. In his post on X, Siddaramaiah alleged that the "continued imposition of Hindi in recruitment processes across central departments" has led to the unfair treatment of local candidates.

What has the Railways said?

SWR, which is yet to announce the new dates, has said that regular exams abide by the three-language policy, but the promotion examination is being conducted in Hindi and English. An SWR official claimed the exam for promotions is computer-based, which is why Kannada was not added as an option. Questioned about the notification, which clearly mentioned that exams would be held in three languages, the official said that they would revert. An official statement indicated that the issue of Kannada's exclusion was being taken up for discussion.



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• CULTURE

With 2 Oscars, how KPop Demon Hunters charted a path to mainstream success

Rishika Singh
New Delhi, March 18

NETFLIX'S *KPop Demon Hunters* (2025) won two Oscars Sunday for Best Animated Feature Film and Best Original Song, a banner night for a film that came to the streaming platform with little expectation. It is now Netflix's most-watched film, ever. Its songs have topped US music charts and a sequel is in the works. So how did the film break multiple commercial records and accrue critical acclaim all the way?

Infusing Korean mythology

KPop Demon Hunters follows three members of a popular Korean girl group called Huntrix. They live double lives as hunters of demons, whose existence is unknown to humans, and fight them through the power of their music. In the process, the main characters learn the values of self-acceptance and teamwork.

The setting provides ample space for a colourful and bright visual palette, which

is rendered in the film's unique animation style. It has received praise for faithfully incorporating aspects of Korean culture, including the city landscape of Seoul, as well as Korean food and mythology.

For instance, it reimagines a feature seen in many Disney films involving princesses, that of a cute animal companion. In the film, this takes the form of a tiger and a magpie.

A report in *The Korea Times* stated: "This odd-couple pairing may seem random at first, but it traces back to Korean folk art and genre paintings called 'minhwa'. Flourishing in the later centuries of the Joseon Dynasty (1392-1910), minhwa broke away from the refined conventions of court painting. Rather than following rigid formalism, the genre embraced raw charm and unrestrained spontaneity. Brimming with whimsical, often mischievous details, these works reflected the imaginative desires and everyday humor of ordinary people."

"Traditionally, the tiger was seen as a guardian against evil spirits and the magpie as a harbinger of good news. But in



'KPop Demon Hunters' is now Netflix's most-watched film. NETFLIX

minhwa, these auspicious figures took on a satirical twist, delivering a playful jab at those in power," it added.

Mijeong Mimi Kim, a Professor in the Department of East Asian Languages and Cultures at Washington University in St. Louis, was among the advisers consulted for the

cultural depictions. She told the university magazine that her suggestions included details like the type of sword used by the characters, and ensuring historical accuracy.

K-pop and its fan culture

Focusing on K-pop artists lets the film

add multiple catchy and energetic songs common to the genre in its two-hour runtime. Some of the soundtrack features the popular K-pop girl group, *TWICE*.

The film attempts to capture aspects of the genre in a way that both nods to the fan culture and pokes occasional fun at its intensity without looking down on it. Most of the soundtrack is in English, which helps widen its appeal to non-Korean audiences.

In centring K-pop, the film capitalises on the rapid rise of the genre in the West over the last decade. Groups such as *BTS*, *TWICE* and *Blackpink* served as inspiration for the characters' appearances and fashion.

But it's not just K-pop — Korean movies and culture have had a spot in the limelight for a while now. This could have eased the film's path to mainstream success. At the Oscars, too, the 2019 film *Parasite* won the Best Picture award in 2020, becoming the first non-English film to do so. The next year, *Minari* received several nominations and the Best Supporting Actress award for Youn Yuh-jung. *Squid Game*, the most-

watched series on Netflix, was also a Korean creation.

Prof Kim said: "Works such as 'Parasite' and 'Squid Game' reveal universal aspects of human nature — both its strengths and its flaws. Their power lies in their unflinching honesty, resisting any impulse to soften or idealize reality."

Kids as a key demographic

From a focus on friendships to love interests, the film includes several aspects common to feel-good animation movies. The genre is often targeted at children, and this film has the advantage of catchy songs that they request to be played on repeat. Netflix now offers a version with just the film's music videos.

The overwhelming popularity doesn't mean the film hasn't faced criticisms, ranging from a lack of depth in characterisations to some plot inconsistencies. But put together, the visuals, music, and the overarching sense of fun and action have been enough to propel it to success.

• WAR IN WEST ASIA

Ali Larijani: Philosopher, negotiator and hardliner



SHUBHAJIT ROY

IRAN'S POWERFUL national security advisor Ali Ardeshir Larijani was killed by Israel on Monday night. His death was confirmed by Iran's Supreme National Security Council, which Larijani led as secretary. Larijani's son, Morteza, was also killed in the attack, the council said.

Larijani, 67, was widely believed to be running the country following the killing of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

Long ties with India

In New Delhi, Larijani was viewed as a "friend" and the Indian establishment had engaged with him for over 20 years.

The most recent engagement was in January this year, when Deputy National Security Advisor Pavan Kapoor visited Iran. This was a follow-up visit after National Security Advisor Ajit Doval called up Larijani in September last year and congratulated him on assuming the responsibility of Supreme National Security Council chief.

According to an Iranian readout, Larijani had "expressed his gratitude for the kind words and discussed strategies for expanding economic cooperation between the two countries, as well as strengthening security and defence relations and advancing the Chabahar project". It had been agreed that further negotiations would continue during an upcoming visit to India.

Larijani had visited India in February-March 2013 as Chairman (Speaker) of the Parliament of Iran. At that time, he had met Lok Sabha Speaker Meira Kumar and discussed greater interaction between the two Parliaments.

At that time, he had offered a nuanced understanding of bilateral ties, saying: "Iran and India play a complementary role to each other. This goes back to the roots that bind the two countries together. There were many Iranian scientists who came to India. I can say that for almost two centuries, Persian was the official court language of India. You have some great people who are considered great people for us too. Like Gandhi, like Jawaharlal Nehru. The people of Iran know about them. Their works are being studied even today in Iran. You have some Indian poets and they have



Ali Larijani being welcomed to Beirut by Hezbollah supporters in 2025. AP/FILE

actually written their poetry in Persian language and they are very famous in Iran too. So I can say that the people of the two countries are very close to each other. And when countries have very good people-to-people contacts, it is very easy for them to have political cooperation."

About differences of views, he said: "That's natural. In today's world, there are always small arguments and differences... We have to see whether they are tactical or strategic. But when it comes to the strategic level, we have no difference of opinion." This was remarkable, considering he was speaking soon after India had voted against Iran at the International Atomic Energy Agency.

Calibrated hardline

Larijani was a quintessential Iranian politician: bureaucrat, technocrat and diplomat all rolled into one.

He ran for President in 2005 but came sixth. Subsequently, he was handpicked by Khamenei into the Supreme National Security Council (NSA equivalent) between 2005 and 2007 — a crucial phase for the Iranian nuclear programme. He was their lead negotiator during those years and is credited with fashioning a calibrated hard-

Last letter

In his last letter on March 16, Larijani had called for the unity of the Muslim world

'You know that America has no loyalty to you and that Israel is your enemy. Stop for a moment and reflect on yourselves and the future of the region,' he wrote

line position that he managed well enough to purchase time during the negotiations with EU3 (France, Germany and the UK).

However, he is also said to have scuttled the possibility of an agreement with the West in 2009, when then President Mahmoud Ahmadinejad had agreed in principle to the Tehran Research Reactor deal. This involved shipping out enough of Iran's low-enriched uranium stockpile to Russia to prevent it from making a bomb, and Russia in return providing fresh fuel to keep the reactor running for civilian purposes. This was aimed at providing a year or two of negotiating time without the pressure of a clock ticking on the side. The collapse of this deal accelerated the push for tougher sanctions against Iran.

Kennedy and Kant

Larijani belonged to a wealthy and powerful family from Amol. In 2009, *Time* magazine described them as the "Kennedys of Iran". His father, Mirza Hashem Amoli, was a prominent religious scholar and his brothers too have held powerful positions in the government. He was married to Farideh Motahari, whose father had been an aide of Khamenei's predecessor,

Larijani was the quintessential Iran politician: Bureaucrat, technocrat, diplomat. His killing will pave way for hawks less amenable to talks

Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini.

Larijani studied mathematics and computers for his graduation, and received his Masters and PhD in Western Philosophy from Tehran University. He taught philosophy at the same university, authoring three books on the German philosopher Immanuel Kant.

Having played an active role in the 1979 Iran Revolution, he joined the Islamic Revolutionary Gaurd Corps (IRGC) in the early 1980s. Then he transitioned to the government, serving as culture minister under President Akbar Hashemi Rafsanjani between 1994 and 1997, and then as the head of the state broadcaster (IRIB) from 1994 until 2004. During his time at the IRIB, he faced criticism for being part of the repressive regime, but the broadcaster expanded its reach, including some international TV channels for Iranian expatriates.

He attempted to run for President for a second time in 2021. But this time, he was disqualified by the Guardian Council, which vets candidates. He was disqualified again when he attempted to run in the 2024 presidential election.

The Guardian Council gave no reason for the disqualifications, but analysts viewed the 2021 move as a way to clear the field for hardliner Ebrahim Raisi, who won the election. Larijani criticised the 2024 disqualification as "non-transparent".

But he did return to an influential position in August 2025, when he was reappointed as secretary of the Supreme National Security Council by President Masoud Pezeshkian.

Like other top Iranian leaders, Larijani was under heavy US sanctions and implicated in the violent repression of mass protests in January. He had been appointed to advise Khamenei on strategy in nuclear talks with the Trump administration.

In his last letter to the Islamic world on March 16, he had called for unity among them.

What his death means for war

Larijani was one of the insiders of the Iranian regime with the ability to work across the aisle — from moderates and reformists to hardliners and IRGC — while also having the bandwidth to engage with the most sophisticated American and Western diplomats.

After his assassination, the Iranian establishment is expected to be filled with officials appointed by the IRGC, who are expected to be much more hardline and much less amenable to negotiations with the West.

Why NATO doesn't have to answer Trump's call to join Iran war

Anagha Jayakumar
New Delhi, March 18

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump revived a familiar refrain this week, calling on NATO to join the war commenced by the US and Israel against Iran, now in its third week.

"I think NATO is making a very foolish mistake. And I've long said that I wonder whether or not NATO would ever be there for us," he told reporters on Tuesday. "So this was a great test, because we don't need them, but they should have been there."

The latest remarks on the alliance have prompted a recall of Trump's rhetoric at the start of the year, when he took to the stage at Davos to say that the US "never got anything out of NATO."

What NATO's charter says

The parameters of the current war show a rejection of NATO's rules of engagement under its charter. Under Article 1 of the Charter, members must commit to resolve any international dispute they are involved in through peaceful means, without endangering international peace, security and justice. Allies are also expected to refrain from using threats or force inconsis-

tent with the purposes of the United Nations. The present conflict presents a clear rejection of this practice, with the fallout spreading globally.

Even the use of Article 5, obligating a response by all members to an attack on one member, may be invoked strictly as a defence measure. Post 9/11, other allies were not obligated to join the US offensive in Afghanistan, but opted to join a Coalition of the Willing formed by the US.

Geography is another limiting factor. Under Article 6, the alliance's collective defence obligations apply only to specific regions — the territories of member states in Europe and North America, Turkey, and the North Atlantic area north of the Tropic of Cancer, including their forces and vessels in the Mediterranean. The current conflict, playing out in and around Iran, falls squarely outside these boundaries.

Given these caveats, NATO exercises a high bar for military response. An attack on any member country's military bases or missiles, therefore, does not automatically result in the invocation of Article 5.

Allies responding individually

Thus far, the alliance has limited its role

Rules of engagement

- Article 5, obligating a response by all members to an attack on one member, may be invoked strictly as a defence measure.
- An attack on any member country's military bases or missiles does not automatically result in its invocation.

to "enabling support", such as logistics and missile defence, without invoking Article 5. Early into the war, NATO Secretary General Rutte emphasised that there are "absolutely no plans" for NATO to be involved, "other than individual allies doing what they can to enable what the Americans are doing together with Israel".

Several European countries have rejected Trump's call for naval reinforcements, while others have chosen to engage at their own discretion. The UK has allowed the US to use some of its military bases in Cyprus following suspected Iranian drone attacks. While Cyprus is not a NATO member, the UK is. Greece has sent frigates and F-16s, while France deployed the frigate *Languedoc* to Cyprus. NATO forces have also intercepted Iranian drones and missiles near Turkey's Incirlik Air Base. To date, the eastern flank of the alliance has absorbed the spillover of conflict, even as NATO itself refrains from formally entering the war.

Trump's grievances

Since his first presidential term, Donald Trump has claimed that other NATO allies haven't contributed as much to the shared alliance defence budget as the US. Since

A dividend at risk

Mismatch between education, jobs, and aspirations could narrow India's demographic window

EMPLOYABILITY AND JOB shortages have long cast doubt on India's ability to realise its much-vaunted demographic dividend. A new report by Azim Premji University adds to these concerns, flagging a growing mismatch between aspirations and economic realities. India is projected to have a working-age population of over one billion by 2030. However, according to the State of Working India 2026 report, the share of this cohort is likely to begin declining from 2030, signalling that the window to harness this advantage may be narrower than previously assumed. This shift is expected to coincide with a rise in unemployed graduates, particularly among the young. Although the demographic dividend is expected to last until 2055, it will be of limited value if younger cohorts are forced into low-skill work.

The report suggests this trend is already underway, with low levels of permanent, salaried and white-collar employment among graduates. Consider this: fewer than 7% of male graduates were able to secure a permanent salaried job within a year of graduating as of 2023. These findings are especially concerning given a labour market facing headwinds from artificial intelligence and automation, whose impact on entry-level roles is increasingly visible and likely to intensify in the coming years. The shortage of salaried employment has been building over the past decade. Economists note that since the early 2010s, the number of young people entering the labour force has risen steadily, even as job creation has slowed. The study acknowledges progress in bridging educational gaps of earlier decades. Gross enrolment ratios in higher education are broadly in line with India's stage of development, and socioeconomic barriers—across gender and caste—have narrowed to some extent. Yet, despite rising overall enrolment, the share of young men in education has fallen from 38% in 2017 to 34% in the last quarter of 2024. A key reason is financial pressure, with many forced to support household incomes, often at the cost of completing their education. The government has sought to boost employability through initiatives such as the Prime Minister Internship Scheme, but it has struggled to attract applicants, with concerns ranging from low stipends to logistical constraints.

Policy priorities must centre on expanding salaried employment opportunities. This includes improving the absorption of women graduates. A TeamLease report earlier this year noted that only about one-third are considered employable, despite a sharp rise in women's participation in higher education. More broadly, unless structural divides are addressed, India risks not only missing an economic opportunity but also facing social strains that could deepen inequality. It is important to reverse trends such as the rising share of students from poorer households in tertiary education, alongside the continued dominance of those from more affluent backgrounds in professional courses such as engineering and medicine.

The rapid expansion of vocational training institutes since the 2010s—driven largely by private industrial training institutes—has not translated into better employment outcomes, largely due to concerns over quality and weak industry linkages. This has contributed to a persistent skills gap that undermines India's manufacturing ambitions. Historically, China moved ahead with a broad-based approach to vocational training and basic education, while India focused more on elite higher education. Bridging this imbalance is essential if the goals of the 2020 National Education Policy, particularly improving employability, are to move beyond intent and deliver measurable outcomes.

Firms pivoting from China shedding to maxxing

SOME OF CHINA'S most successful global companies have spent years masking their origins to sidestep Western scrutiny. But that approach, called "China shedding", has run its course—at least for the bigger players.

The surprise homecoming of online retailer Shein Group's founder should be the final nail in the coffin for the strategy. Last month, Xu Yangtian, who has been rarely photographed, took to the stage in the southern Chinese province of Guangdong to thank the local government and suppliers for helping the company to become a retail juggernaut. Shein is now the biggest player in the global market for bargain-priced apparel, according to GlobalData, ahead of the likes of Primark and Target Corp. Private market research firm Sacra estimates its 2025 sales at \$60 billion, which would be more than Hennes & Mauritz and Inditex's Zara combined.

Blurring ties to Beijing to minimise regulatory or reputational risk overseas was a defensive manoeuvre five years ago. At the time, telecoms equipment maker Huawei Technologies was still making headlines after being banned by Washington over spying concerns. Following that episode, Chinese firms aiming for international prominence wanted to avoid a similar fate.

Three of the most successful—social media platform TikTok and budget online retailers Temu and Shein—have all tried to distance themselves from their roots. None have succeeded. Increasing opposition from Beijing, combined with a recent vibe shift that has elevated perceptions of Chinese products suggest it would be smart for home-grown companies to be more upfront about where they're from.

What was unusual about Xu's first-ever public appearance is that Shein had been presenting itself as a Singapore-based fast-fashion giant, with only perfunctory mentions on its website of the region that powers its ability to churn out designs in as little as three weeks. It's a positioning that reportedly upset the Chinese regulators who must approve its long-delayed IPO.

Another reason companies should be more honest is that China shedding was always a hard sell. Just look at TikTok, owned by Beijing-based ByteDance. No matter

what it tried, the short-form video platform was unable to convince the public it wasn't Chinese, even though it doesn't exist in China.

Fearing a Huawei-like ban following a 2019 national security probe, TikTok hired Kevin Mayer, a former Walt Disney executive, as CEO in an effort to improve its standing in the US. The platform even left Hong Kong in 2020 to signal independence from China. To no avail. President Joe Biden's efforts to investigate it culminated in a congressional grilling of the next chief executive, Shou Chew, in March 2023.

Pressed on whether TikTok was Chinese, Chew sidestepped the question, saying only that the app was unavailable in China and based in Los Angeles and Singapore. Though Chew comported himself well, his argument was unconvincing. The lesson? Simply downplaying Chinese ties was not enough to avoid political scrutiny. Eventually, the Trump White House brokered a deal to create a US-controlled TikTok to which ByteDance licenses its algorithm.

Last year, during the height of the US-China tensions, President Donald Trump ended a long-standing tariff exemption on goods under \$800 that had propelled the fortunes of Temu, owned by PDD Holdings, and Shein. But while the active users of both online shopping sites fell, they eventually recovered, with Shein bouncing back especially quickly, according to market intelligence firm Sensor Tower.

In fact, trade volatility hasn't hurt the seller of \$1 eyebrow shapers and \$4 wax strips at all. Shein raised its US prices before tariffs on small packages were imposed, which is expected to have helped its net income hit \$2 billion in 2025, nearly double the year before, *Bloomberg News* reported.

Smaller companies may still be able to fly under the radar with China shedding. Not so for the global heavyweights for which honesty would be the best policy.

INDIA SHOULD SUPPORT ITS CONTINUATION, WHILE PRESSING FOR CLARITY, FAIRNESS, AND SAFEGUARDS

Naysayer to decision-maker

ARPITA MUKHERJEE

Professor, ICRIER

Stakes for a digital economy

As one of the fastest-growing digital economies, India has a high stake in global trade rules. Electronic transmissions cover software downloads, cloud services, design files, research data, and cross-border digital services. In 1998, e-commerce was largely confined to digitally ordered goods and some services. Today, digitally delivered goods and services are ubiquitous, yet WPEC has not reached consensus on scope or definition.

Trade agreements, however, have attempted definitions of e-commerce in digital trade chapters. India has digital trade chapters with the United Arab Emirates, the UK, and the European Union. WPEC discussions remain crucial to keep e-commerce on the multi-lateral agenda, especially since JSI's status as plurilateral is unclear. The US has not joined JSI but remains part of WPEC. The moratorium has enabled businesses, especially smaller firms, to access platforms and markets without layered border taxes. If countries begin levying duties on digital transmissions, micro, small, and medium enterprise (MSME) exporters could suffer in an increasingly protectionist world.

The India AI Impact Summit 2026 in New Delhi showcased India's ambition to become a hub for responsible, human-centric AI innovation. It highlighted how technology can drive inclusive growth across the Global South and demonstrated India's readiness to take leader-

ship roles in global digital trade policy-making. India is already agreeing to zero tariffs under multiple trade agreements, so tariffs can no longer be treated as an import shield.

Revenue concerns

The principal argument against the moratorium is fiscal/custom revenue loss. Some studies (such as United Nations Trade and Development [UNCTAD] studies by Banga, 2019 and 2021) estimated that developing countries forgo potential tariff revenues from digital imports.

Countering this, ICRIER Working Paper (WP) 426 found that the UNCTAD studies included goods where India has a positive trade balance and/or is a net importer where tariffs are already zero or low under existing free trade agreements. Thus, the argument is technically weak for India. With more trade agreements, more digital products will likely be duty-free.

With government focus on electronics exports, global capability centres, and revival of special economic zones, India should prioritise removing export barriers. Imposing customs duties on intangible digital transmissions would also pose serious administrative challenges. Indonesia attempted to create a separate HS code, without success. ICRIER WP 426 argued that domestic tax/goods and services tax is a more effective revenue collection method than customs duty.

India should use upcoming negotiations to push for clarity on what constitutes an 'electronic transmission'

Liberalisation sandboxes can break deadlock



VARDAAN AHLUWALIA

General Counsel, Premji Invest

Used well, they could become living demonstrations of the govt's reform vision—global models of sustainable, rules-based urban and economic governance

INDIA HAS BECOME boldly ambitious in what it wants to build but remains less so in how to achieve it. Reforms over the past decade have been a pattern of incrementalism at best—not because they lack democratic legitimacy or policy nuance, but because they were limited by politically safe measures that ultimately failed to deliver commensurate results. For every step forward, a chorus of special interests and federal complexities often pulls another step back. The costs are substantial—the stalling of land acquisition reform alone has left land-related disputes holding up investment projects greater than \$200 billion. Initiatives such as special economic zones (SEZs) and the production-linked incentive scheme also follow an incrementalist approach by relying on financial incentives to offset structural bottlenecks rather than addressing them.

Effective reform is a public good, one that requires deliberate effort in diverse democracies. As James Madison and BR Ambedkar cautioned, democratic systems are distorted when formally empowered governments are unable to act because of narrow special interests.

This raises the question of whether alternative reform pathways exist that can demonstrate outcomes to help build consensus. One possibility lies in using existing constitutional space more creatively—by reimagining Union Territories (UTs) not as administrative afterthoughts or strategic outposts but as liberalisation sandboxes—controlled reform environments. Drawing on experience from Guangdong's reform enclave, Estonia's e-govern-

ance architecture, and Singapore's financial regulatory design, such frameworks could be tested locally in UTs before being scaled nationally.

The creation of the Island Development Agency and the \$9.4-billion Great Nicobar Island Development Project reflects a renewed push by the government to unlock growth in UTs. Yet these initiatives remain sporadic and embedded in the same legal and administrative frameworks that have constrained execution. The real opportunity lies not in incremental adjustments to existing models but in rethinking the governance fabric.

India's UTs occupy a distinct constitutional position, separate from the Centre-state legislative demarcation that defines Indian federalism. Under Articles 240 and 246, UTs without a legislature fall under the direct legislative and executive authority of the central government—a distinction reaffirmed by the Supreme Court in 2023. This structure helps neutralise the democratic distortions that impede reform—it places lawmaking squarely within the Union's constitutional remit while reducing exposure to entrenched special-interest vetoes.

India's administrative structures function as a hidden tax on growth. Consider dispute resolution—with nearly 50 million pending cases and commercial contract enforcement typically taking around four years, and delays are especially crippling in land markets—where two-thirds of civil cases involve property disputes. These weaknesses directly affect India's ambitions. Take large-scale AI clusters that will require international talent, digital infrastructure, reliable baseload power, and assured access to land and water. These investments depend on clear titles and liability laws, enforceable contracts, and predictable regulatory approvals. In their absence, even well-capitalised projects struggle to move beyond planning.

The structure governing Union Territories helps neutralise the democratic distortions that impede reform

When layered onto India's federal polity, where reform efforts often trigger democratic distortions, these constraints become decisive. A liberalisation sandbox offers the ability to jettison such distortions by offering best-in-class governance and administrative frameworks. For instance, the government could pioneer blockchain-secured land registries, single-window regulatory clearances, fast-track dispute resolution, and state-backed nuclear liability frameworks to launch such projects in UTs. Over time, these territories could build concrete economic capabilities—AI clusters, international financial services, arbitration hubs, tokenisation, and digitally enabled trade—even attracting global talent. Beyond economic gains, their success would create a channel for evidence-based policymaking, encouraging wider adoption and strengthening New Delhi's hand in trade negotiations by enabling more cred-

ible market-access commitments in ring-fenced territories for clearer evaluation. While constitutionally sound, liberalisation sandboxes would be an exceptional step and must be designed to streamline—not bypass—checks and balances through empowered and accountable governance. Concerns that this could undermine fragile ecologies, vulnerable communities, or simply rebrand SEZs are legitimate. The government could anchor this through a council presided over by the PMO—drawing on international and Indian constitutional experts, economists, environmentalists, regulators, and entrepreneurs—to design best-in-class governance frameworks to compete with international business havens. A well-conceived sandbox approach will embed suitable environmental and social safeguards within the development framework. If achieved, we'd strengthen institutional democracy by evolution rather than weakening it.

With India's macroeconomic conditions broadly favourable, the opportunity is both immediate and substantial. The Andaman and Nicobar Islands are 10 times the size of Singapore and larger than Hong Kong, while Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu are comparable in scale to Singapore, offering scope for concentrated, high-quality development. Used well, these sandboxes could become living demonstrations of the government vision—global models of sustainable, rules-based urban and economic governance. The challenge is self-imposed and warrants a deliberate constitutional solution in the service of democratic evolution.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Turbulence for Air India

Apropos of "Faltering flight path" (FE, March 18), four years after the Tata Group's takeover of Air India, the airline is trailing expectations. Regular travellers and public rejoiced with confidence when AI was taken over by Tata, hoping the latter would overhaul the ailing airline's systems and its management, and bring it at par with private players. While the Tata group

was channelising efforts, placing orders for a massive number of aircraft, overhauling the brand, and setting the house in order, the unfortunate Ahmedabad crash last year cast aspersions. People have confidence in the group's dedication, but it needs to initiate multi-pronged initiatives right from refining internal control, upgrading the fleet, and upskilling flight crew, to reorienting administrative mechanisms. —RV Baskaran, Pune

China's growth strategy

Apropos of "Enabling Chinese ambitions" (FE, March 18), China is resilient to the disruption in its huge Iranian oil import of 1.38 million barrel a day due to the US-Iran war. The oil import disruption increases costs and impact its economic growth, and China's Iranian investments, including the Belt and Road Initiative, will be affected. Despite these headwinds, China chalked out its 15th Five-Year

plan with reduced growth rate but with a goal of high-quality investments, transforming its economy for technological self-reliance and innovation-driven growth including artificial intelligence and robotic and digital application in industries. The instability in West Asia doesn't appear to be affecting China's agenda for high-quality growth yet. —NR Nagarajan, Sivakasi

●Write to us at feletters@expressindia.com



A thought for today
The direct use of force is such a poor solution to any problem, it is generally employed only by small children and large nations
DAVID FRIEDMAN

Scary Middle Game

Iran war enters a troubling stage, where most likely outcomes look more destabilising than US planned for

If war is a game of chess, Iran conflict has moved beyond its opening gambits into a tense, intricate middle game – where every move carries layered consequences, and no outcome is guaranteed. The early phase was dramatic and decisive: US and Israel eliminated Ayatollah Khamenei, in a stunning strike. That momentum continued. On Tuesday, Ali Larijani, a key figure in Iran's national security establishment, was killed. Soon after, intelligence minister Esmail Khatib met a similar fate. Israel has hinted more such moves are coming, keeping adversaries guessing. Meanwhile, a US naval vessel – believed to be carrying marines – edges closer to West Asia, fuelling speculation of a possible ground operation inside Iran.

Nearly three weeks into the conflict, certain realities are becoming clearer. First, air power alone – even when precise and relentless – rarely delivers regime change. History offers no convincing example of regimes collapsing solely under aerial assault. While Iran's leadership has been significantly degraded, and institutions like Basij are under pressure, the system has shown resilience. New figures are stepping in, almost as quickly as others are removed, suggesting depth within the regime's structure.

If outright regime change through military strikes seems unlikely, the alternative being floated is more volatile: internal collapse via civil unrest. Both

Trump and Netanyahu have called for Iranians to rise against their leadership. Netanyahu's appeal to public celebrations like Nowruz may not be cultural – it may be strategic, hoping that gatherings could ignite dissent. Yet, recent history tempers such expectations. Protests earlier this year were met with brutal force, reportedly leaving tens of thousands dead. Though weakened, the regime still commands powerful instruments of repression. An uprising, if it occurs, could spiral not into reform – but into chaos.

And that chaos would not remain contained. Iran has already signalled its capacity for escalation – targeting Gulf states, and disrupting Strait of Hormuz, sending shockwaves through global energy markets. A full-scale civil war could ignite sectarian tensions, across the region, turning instability into a wildfire. For Gulf nations, this is an uncomfortable bind: uninvolved in the war's initiation, yet deeply affected by its consequences. Their calls for restraint – to both Washington and Tehran – have so far gone unheard.

Yes, the board is set, major pieces are in motion. But in this dangerous middle game, the final outcome remains uncertain – and potentially far more destabilising than opening moves suggested.

Working With Hands

Skilled physical work isn't a social stigma. India has to fix its thinking, if more young people are to find jobs

Azim Premji University's State of Working India 2026, highlights a key point, which explains why India struggles to fix its 40-year-old problem of joblessness. Apart from structural challenges and gaps, the report talks of the need for "an attitude shift in society" on what counts as "knowledge", and what's "dignified work". Caste, class and colonial legacies inform, to this day, what work is "respectable". Only 6.7% young graduates, aged 20-29, had permanent salaried jobs in 2023. About 40% are unemployed. Less than half had some form of work: self-employed or ready to be underemployed, as a way of getting a foot in the door marked 'better prospects'. Of course, high levels of unemployment among graduates are not uniquely an Indian phenomenon. But, the sheer volume of India's working-age population, makes unemployability a crisis.

Look at the numbers – India's 367mn-strong working-age population (aged 15-29), is about 20mn more than US's population. Keeping out those in school and college, there are 263mn in the workforce. By 2036, the report estimates, graduates will be 38% of employable men, up from 26% in 2023, in age group 20-24. Among men aged 25-29, share of graduates is projected to rise from about 30% to 42% by 2036. It simply cannot be business as usual.

The idea that "head work" is superior to "hand work", putting higher value on mental labour than on physical labour, is defined both by caste and class. Graduates from middle classes and aspiring middle classes aspire to "head work". Status is a prime consideration, for jobs that will pass family and society's approval. There is near contempt for hand work. The report says skill training, vocational and technical, must be made aspirational. Formalising jobs, that such training attracts, is key. The world of work has to be made class- and caste-agnostic.

Fine print, finer trap

On the great maya of travel insurance

Saurabh.Sinha@timesofindia.com

Main Hoon Na. Never take this assurance at face value, unless it's given by SRK. I learnt about this relatively unknown fifth law of Newton the hard way, after buying travel insurance for an overseas trip, last month.

The policy worked very well as long as the trip went smoothly. At dinner on the last night of my stay, I got a message from the airline that my next morning flight back home was cancelled, due to a strike at the airport. And the airline said they wouldn't provide a hotel, as the cancellation wasn't their doing.

No problem, *wo hai na*, I told myself, thinking of the insurance that covered, among other things, flight delays and cancellations. After making arrangements for the prolonged stay, I called the insurance company, which told me I was eligible for \$40 compensation, for every four hours of delay.

Since that covered my unplanned expenses, I happily stayed on, and was a little heartbroken when the airline sent a mail next evening, saying I was booked on the next morning flight – a total delay of 24 hours. "Just keep the boarding cards as proof. We are there for you," the insurance portal told me, just like SRK in the movie had assured his stepbrother.

After filing the claim on returning to India, it was my turn to get the stepbrotherly treatment. "In the present case, as per the email from the airline, we note that you were informed more than six hours prior to the scheduled departure of the flight. Hence the claim is not admissible under the policy," the claim rejection letter said.

"Is that fair?" I asked the insurance portal person, who seemed to agree with me, but blamed the fine print. Now, for future trips, I have created a foolproof checklist to escape dodgy fine print clauses. Block the airline from contacting me till I enter the six-hour departure window. Carry extra khakhra, mathri, and a mini tent on future trips, to resist expenses if my flight is cancelled. Use the policy document carefully, to put the khakhra and aachaar on.

In *Love and Death*, Woody Allen says: "There are worse things in life than death. Have you ever spent an evening with an insurance salesman?" While I love the man and his movies, I won't blame the salesman. After all, don't shoot the messenger.

War Or Peace: Brains Of Nations

Behavioural science has an interesting take on why countries like US, Russia are now totally ignoring a rules-based system: old habits change when new rewards seem, even if wrongly, more lucrative than older ones

Arindam Goswami



Charles Duhigg, in *The Power of Habit*, says that most human behaviour follows a simple loop: a cue triggers an action, a routine follows, and a reward tells the brain if it should remember it. Habits, once formed, do not go away. They can be changed. By swapping in a new routine, while keeping the same cue and reward. This idea also explains why the international order after World War II worked well for a time, and why it is now facing problems. The habit of cooperation has quietly been replaced, by the habit of conflict.

After 1945, leaders like Truman, Marshall, Monnet, and Adenauer knew they couldn't erase centuries of distrust between countries. Instead, they changed how countries handled problems. Earlier, political disputes or trade issues often led to military action, and appeals to national pride. The new approach replaced that with legal processes, treaty obligations, or turning to Brussels.

The reward was access to European markets, reconstruction funds, and political legitimacy. This system kept peace in Western Europe for 70 years. It was the habit of cooperation, not just good intentions, that made the difference.

This same habit framework helps explain why the international order is falling apart today. Russia's invasion of Ukraine, violence in Gaza, and American actions – whether in Venezuela, Iran, or pulling back from global institutions – all show a pattern: powerful countries have decided that breaking the rules now brings more benefits, than following them.

Duhigg points out that habits break down when the rewards change. The post-war system relied on rewards like trade, development money, security, and diplomatic status, which worked when US and its allies dominated the global economy. That dominance is now being challenged. For instance, now, China offers its own rewards, Gulf money moves without democratic rules, and IMF has less influence as new lenders appear. Following the rules no longer always pays off, and international institutions have not kept up.

Some might ask if any of this matters, since powerful

countries like US, China, and Russia set the rules anyway. That's a fair question, but it confuses short-term gains with long-term interests. US's real strengths today are not just military – they include dollar's global role, deep capital markets, demand for American tech, and alliances that make its military power effective. All these depend on a stable, rules-based world. When that system breaks down and contracts, or norms are ignored, US and its economy also suffer.

Now, to bring about change, a good starting point is to look at what behavioural economists call defaults and friction. Right now, if a country faces a border dispute,

be better access to markets, lower borrowing costs, faster tech deals, or priority for development funds. Rewards should come quickly and be updated often, so countries can see the results, and plan ahead. This fits with Duhigg's point that the brain craves rewards. If following the rules clearly brings benefits, and breaking them clearly brings losses, the habit loop will work again.

But Duhigg's biggest insight is about identity, not just rewards or punishments. Alcoholics Anonymous works, because people start to see themselves as non-drinkers, supported by others who share that identity. After World War II, European leaders began to see themselves as

Europeans, not just as leaders of their own countries. Today, the international order is struggling not only because its incentives are outdated, but also because the sense of global community has faded. Being called an international outcast does not hurt as much now, since some leaders feel backed by other countries with similar views.

So where should we start? Duhigg suggests looking for a keystone habit – a single change that triggers many others. In global affairs, that keystone is reforming how UN Security Council veto works. For example, a new rule could say that no permanent member can veto a resolution, about a conflict where it is directly involved. Then, Russia could not block action on its own wars, US could not protect its allies' campaigns, and China

could not avoid scrutiny of its actions. Other changes could follow: a system to score countries on compliance, like a credit rating, but for security and humanitarian behaviour; a group of mid-sized democracies able to trigger economic consequences, without needing big-power approval; and special trade and investment deals, for countries with strong compliance records.

This is where India has a unique opportunity, as the world's largest democracy, and a growing economic power, with no ambitions to expand its borders. But to lead, India must make a choice: move from staying on the sidelines, to taking action. India should propose Security Council veto reforms, and bring together a new group of mid-sized, rule-following nations, which together are ready to break free from old habit loops.

The writer is with the High-Tech Geopolitics Programme, Takshashila Institution

'I Visited Tehran In Nov, And It Disproved So Many Stereotypes'

● Many women didn't wear hijab ● Religiosity seemed less overt in most of the city than in some parts of India ● Nightlife was not dead, it was great ● Israel and US were not discussed as hated countries

Sujit.John@timesofindia.com



Beneath the shadow of global headlines, day-to-day reality in Iran has long been at variance with Western narratives. In Nov, when we spent three days in Tehran, one of the first messages I received when I reached – from a friend in US – said the women must all be in hijabs. How wrong that was!

Barring some older women, no one was wearing – forget hijabs – even a scarf over their heads in public places. We were told that in restaurants, if a woman has a scarf covering her head, a young woman might come by, flip it off, and say 'Don't betray the movement'.

This is a reference to the 'Woman, Life, Freedom' movement, triggered by the Sept 2022 death of Mahsa Amini, a young Kurdish-Iranian woman, after her arrest by the police for allegedly wearing the hijab improperly.

Yes, Western sanctions over decades have had a severe impact on the economy. The person assigned to pick me from the airport had some fascination for cars. So, during the one-hour drive to our hotel, he frequently pointed to various car models we passed – mostly European brands. He noted that those models were no longer being produced in Iran, but owners were managing to keep them going, with parts imported from China, or reverse-engineered locally. The cars looked odd. Even the one we were sitting in was long past its prime. The few new cars are expensive, imported ones. The city looks old too; modern buildings are few.

But socially, Iran is far from what most of us imagine. Indian Embassy officials told us Iran is probably less religious today, than India is. One of them said a third of mosques in Tehran have shut down, because nobody goes to them. That's true for mosques across Iran. People who go are mostly those getting financial assistance from govt, distributed through religious bodies. It's one of the conditions of the grant.

Everyone we met spoke of the phenomenal nightlife, all through the week – private parties, dating, music and

gatherings. One evening, we were at an open-air food-court. Filled with youngsters – in groups, in pairs, boys and girls. On one table, a young woman sat wearing what looked like a wolf-shaped headgear. We could just as well have been in San Francisco or Bengaluru.

What stood out was also the warmth of ordinary Iranians. Shopkeepers routinely offer items free. We heard stories of cab drivers refusing payment, after learning the passenger was from India.



The conference we went for, while being a demonstration of Iran's strengths in science and tech, was primarily to bring Brics countries, including its researchers, together – to find ways to reduce the world's dependence on the dollar. Iran is looking at crypto and blockchain as an alternative.

Many Iranian govt officials and academics spoke. What was striking was, even though the event was happening less than five months after last year's Israel and US strikes, there were no offensive references to either country, let alone rants. Speeches

and discussions were matter-of-fact.

Like when Ali Asghar Ghaemi, member of Tehran City Council, told us: "It's been more than 50 years that our country has had controversies with America. And we have seen the results on the screen, the war, and destruction. So, we are eagerly cooperating with any country that would like to de-dollarise the economy. India has this shared purpose... you have a conflict also with America, and your country could handle it so well."

These and other conversations also come to mind, when today the world talks of the Iranian regime. The West often presents the regime as a monolithic bloc of Islamic fundamentalists. That may be far from the case. Multiple people told us the regime is a mix of hardliners and reformists, and reformists are probably gaining ground. Even hardliners probably aren't as hardline, as they once were.

One senior Indian Embassy personnel had previously been posted in Tel Aviv. We asked the official, who – Iran or Israel – was more delusional about the other side's "evil" intentions. "Both are equally so," was the instant response.

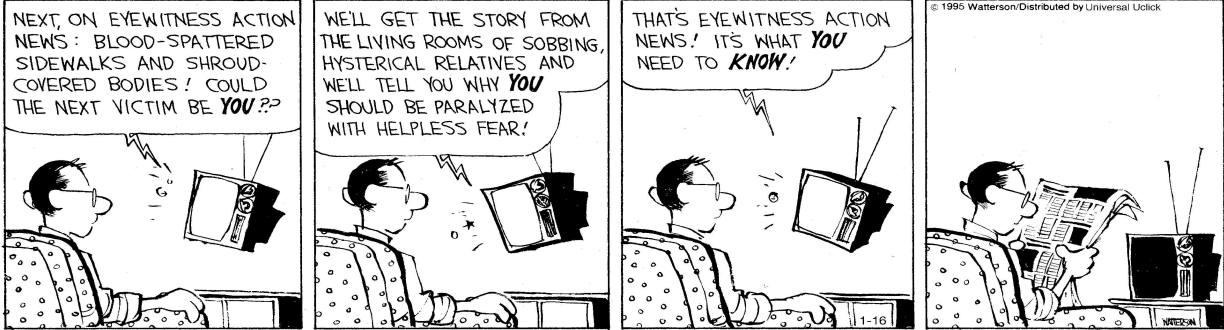
On our return flight was Narjes Mottaghi, a data scientist, and head of ICT dept at Isfahan University of Medical Sciences. She was coming to Bengaluru to meet her Indian-Australian fiancé and his family. Her dream was to be a NASA scientist – put paid to by US sanctions.

She wears a hijab. "It makes men see me as a human being, not as a woman, not as a pretty face," she explained, but added that she fully supported the 2022 women's protest against the hijab. She told us there are more women than men, in many science and tech universities in Iran. Men are going into business, not doing higher education, leading often to incompatibility in marriages. Divorce rates are near 50%.

On weekends, Narjes drives across Iran alone for adventure sports, sometimes stopping by the side of a highway to sleep. "It's completely safe for women," she said.

The writer was in Iran in Nov, for a blockchain & cryptocurrency conference, organised with support from Iranian govt

Calvin & Hobbes



Can You Control Your Thoughts?

Rajiv Vij

Pause for a moment. Close your eyes and gently observe your thoughts.

Do you notice them arising one after another – some linked to the previous one, some disjointed? Are you choosing these thoughts, or are they appearing on their own beyond your control?

Consider your everyday thoughts about the past or future. Thoughts that generate excitement or fear. Thoughts coloured by love, envy, or self-judgement. Don't they seem to arise by themselves? This is clearly noticeable on a sleepless night when an unending stream of thoughts shows up uninvited.

Now consider a situation where you 'consciously' decide to think about something, perhaps planning your weekend. How did even the thought, 'Let me plan my weekend' arise? Did you manufacture it? Or did it simply appear?

Thoughts arise from memory, habit, fear, desire – from everything we have ever

experienced. They emerge automatically from the mind's past conditioning, not from a controller consciously choosing and releasing them. Yet from birth, our language and social structures reinforce the sense of an independent thinker who owns and controls these thoughts.

But what power do you actually have over your thoughts? Can you choose your next thought? Did you choose the last one? Or do thoughts simply arise, only to fade away and give way to the next? The continuity and coherence of thoughts create the impression of a thinker. But is it possible that thoughts arise due to conditioning and then another thought subtly appears, claiming 'I am the one thinking'?

It all begins with an experience. Pain is felt, hunger arises, a thought appears. But instead of noticing 'pain', 'hunger', or 'thinking', we learn to say, 'I am in pain', 'I am hungry', 'I am thinking'. Language creates

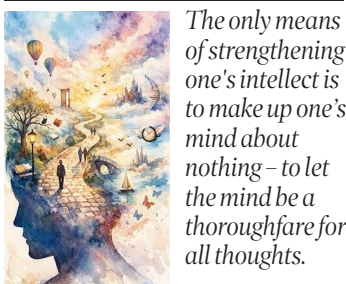
a central reference point for experience – an 'I' to whom everything happens, a thinker behind the thinking.

Over time, memory links experiences together and strengthens the sense of a continuous controller. In the process, an identity forms. Life no longer simply unfolds; it happens to 'me', or is caused by 'me'. An awkward moment becomes 'I am embarrassed', followed by, 'Why am I like this?'

But let's look closely. Is it possible that thinking happens on its own and the sense of a thinker is itself another thought? The narrative of 'I' is surely essential for navigating daily life and operating in a social construct. But when we over-identify with the thinker and take every thought personally, it often becomes a source of emotional struggle and unhappiness.

If thoughts arise on their own, perhaps they don't need to be tightly managed. Perhaps they don't need to define us. We

Sacred space



John Keats

The only means of strengthening one's intellect is to make up one's mind about nothing – to let the mind be a thoroughfare for all thoughts.

The writer is a Singapore-based life coach



Editor's
TAKE

Afghan-Pakistan rift turns deadly

The latest airstrikes on Kabul and rising casualties mark a sharp escalation between former allies turned adversaries, underscoring a dangerous shift

It is understated yet deadly and could have far-reaching implications for the South Asian region. The conflict between Afghanistan and Pakistan is escalating and, with world attention focused on West Asia, it is playing out loudly but no one seems to care. What is more disturbing is the fact that its human cost is rising with every assault, and soon it could be a major flashpoint that would be hard to contain. The reported Pakistani air strike on a Kabul hospital, which the Afghan Taliban claims killed nearly 400 people and injured 250, is not a border skirmish; it is a full-blown conflict. Though Islamabad insists it targeted militant infrastructure, not civilians, it was a massacre nonetheless. Ironically, Pakistan is getting a taste of its own medicine. For years, Pakistan nurtured, trained and used Taliban militants, who are now turning against it. Pakistan wanted a friendly regime in Kabul which would not only make its eastern border secure but also stand alongside it, in providing manpower when needed against India. However, Pakistan's calculus failed when the Taliban returned to power in 2021. The Taliban, now in power and running Afghanistan, is no longer the insurgent force it once was. In five years of its tenure, Afghanistan has wilfully demonstrated autonomy and refused to take diktats from Pakistan's generals.

At the heart of the breakdown is the resurgence of the Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP). Pakistan accuses the Afghan Taliban of providing a safe haven to TTP fighters, who have intensified attacks within Pakistani territory. Kabul denies these allegations, countering with claims that anti-Taliban groups find refuge in Pakistan. This blame game has steadily escalated into military confrontation. The latest strikes fit into this paradigm. Border skirmishes, air raids and retaliatory attacks have become rather routine. Moreover, diplomatic interventions by regional players have failed to produce lasting stability. What we are witnessing is not an isolated crisis but the steady normalisation of conflict between two deeply intertwined states.

There is an acute asymmetry in military capabilities. Pakistan, with its advanced air power and large standing army, holds sway over the Taliban's limited conventional capabilities. Yet, its military might does not guarantee decisive victory. If Pakistan has the machinery, the Taliban have the will and mettle to fight, especially in rugged border regions where insurgency tactics thrive. What is worrisome is the fact that, at the moment, West Asia is unstable and in a state of flux. The chances of this war getting mixed up with West Asia are high, as eventually China,Russia and the US would get involved and contest any attempt by the rivals to dominate these strategically important countries. This creates a conducive environment for escalation, reducing the likelihood of timely international mediation. As the two nations slog, power has altered priorities and ideology has collided with sovereignty. The path forward demands restraint and the need for dialogue that can eventually stop this conflict. Ironically, neither Pakistan nor Afghanistan can afford to go to full-fledged war, and if they do, it would be catastrophic for their people and the region at large.

PPP: Reimagining national resource management

By placing communities at the centre of Nature-based Solutions, PPP not only addresses environmental challenges but also empowers those most affected, paving the way for sustainable livelihoods, equitable growth and a participatory framework



SUSHIL
KUMAR
SINGLA

The common prevalent notion is that the Government has no business being in business. Is it time to move beyond and take a leap from PPP 1.0 to PPP 2.0, with Public being replaced with People as far as the management of national resources is concerned?

Nature-based Solutions (NBS) can be, and must be, taken forward with People at the forefront, as they are the most vulnerable and victims of climate change and resultant warming; and they must be placed at the front as leading partners. This will help in bringing all the stakeholders-Public, People or Private Entity-on the same footing and on the same page, as all of them will carry equal weightage, which will help in creating an inclusive and equitable societal order without any frills.

A case in point is the Forest Conservation Amendment Act, 2023, allowing industries to take up plantations on forest land, particularly degraded forest lands, aimed at enhancing green cover in the country. This is in line with the National Forest Policy 1988 goal of bringing one-third of the land area under forest or tree cover from the current level of approximately one-fourth.

In the mountainous Himalayan state of Himachal Pradesh, two Ayurvedic manufacturers, using bio-resource material for the production of plant-based formulations, have come forward to collaborate and work closely with people residing in rural areas to cultivate medicinal and herbal species. One of these, a leading company, shall provide free-of-cost plants to people for raising on their private lands or to farmers for growing on farmland as per feasibility assessments. Dabur India Limited has signed an MoA to supply 1.2 million plants every year without any charge to local people, and this free distribution shall continue for the next 10 years. The company has agreed to create awareness, impart technical know-how to the people, in addition to having a buy-back arrangement with the growers of these medicinal and herbal produce.

The Department of Forest and Ayurveda under the State Government shall have a limited mandate of facilitating and providing a common platform to People and Private entities to coordinate, collaborate and cooperate to take forward the objectives of mutually



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The writer is Secretary
Environment, Science
Technology and Climate
Change Government of
Himachal Pradesh. Views
expressed are personal

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development programmes will also be organised in partnership with the university on safe collection practices, biochar applications in agriculture, and climate change mitigation. Over its 10-year operational period, the project is expected to generate about 28,800 carbon credits, giving a boost to Himachal Pradesh's green initiatives.

The Afforestation, Reforestation and Re-vegetation (ARR) project is being promoted on land owned by people by roping in private investments. Under ARR, the private company will supply seedlings free of cost to farmers for raising on private lands and, after five years, will be eligible to partake in the carbon credits accumulated on account of these plantations undertaken on farmland. Here, Government departments, particularly the Forest Department, shall play a peripheral role.

As nature-based solutions have a longer gestation period, they require long-term and continuous efforts to make them successful and sustainable.

Now, public servants have to think from the perspective that People, Private Entities and Public Servants are sitting on the same side of the table, and the table is not square or rectangular but round. National resource management has to graduate from joint management to community-led management, which shall ultimately lead to sustainable management.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

This will pave the way for the scientific propagation of herbal plants with the twin objectives of enhancing local rural livelihoods and ensuring quality herbal produce for the manufacture and preservation of traditionally harvested forest and conservation areas.

A similar approach has been taken by the State Government in the field of climate change projects in the state, such as India's first state-supported biochar production programme. Under the Biochar Project, forest-based bio-resources will be used to convert them into biochar, which shall help in protecting forests from forest fires and also create avenues for local people's livelihood enhancement. A tripartite Memorandum of Agreement (MoA) in this regard was signed between Y S Parmar University of Horticulture and Forestry, Nauni, the Himachal Pradesh Forest Department, and ProClima Services Private Limited, Chennai. The initiative will not only create employment opportunities but also help the State to secure carbon credits. ProClima, through the Forest Department, will engage local communities in sustainable biomass collection, and the participants will be paid per kg of biomass collected, with performance-based incentives for maintaining quality and quantity.

The programme is expected to generate nearly 50,000 person-days of income annually through biomass collection, along with direct employment in plant operations. Skill

Contentment, not possession, holds the key to peace



RAHYOGI BRAHMA
KUMAR NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

It has often been observed that whenever people meet a spiritual personality or a learned, enlightened soul, they invariably express the feeling that their faces reflect inner contentment, peace and purity. However, hardly do these people make a sustained effort to go deeper into the factors that lead to a life of contentment and inner harmony and a state of calm and composure, and much less do they make a serious attempt to attain these, even though they value them highly. A quiet reflection and serene introspection would, however, lead to the conclusion that contentment does not come from high and numerous material attainments. Contentment dawns when the dark night of ignorance ends. It is born of a sense of realisation that all that this material world offers is only ephemeral and short-lived. Only he, from whose

mind desires for mundane achievements have been eliminated, has contentment. Contentment is thus a sign of spiritual wisdom and maturity.

So, what is so special about contentment that has made many great people talk or write about it? Well, to understand it, we would first need to understand the opposite of it, i.e. discontentment. A discontented person has a typical habit of building castles in the air while he is as poor as he can be. Such people totally fail to understand that it is only by dint of hard work that a man can make both ends meet, and only a man of right understanding can work on the right lines. Otherwise, it is a blunder to let your reason be clouded by passion and thus lose your own happiness. Hence, we should remember that just as food sustains the body, so does the mind find sustenance in happiness. So, the saying goes: there is no food as good as happiness. And, to be happy, you have to be content. Just as, for bodily well-being, man seeks food, so should he maintain the state of contentment to ensure happiness of mind.

As Alfred Nobel has rightly said, 'Contentment is the only real wealth', we should therefore not run after securing another kind of wealth to lose the wealth of contentment. Likewise, peace comes when one's inner conflicts have been resolved and harmony of the mind and the intellect has been achieved. Peace is born of purity.

Contentment, purity and peace are the trio which make one's life worth living. They appear on the life scene after one has been pursuing one's spiritual studies and has also been practising deep meditation. Without the practice of yoga, one cannot attain and sustain inner peace and tranquillity.

One of the biggest illusions is that external circumstances must become perfect before we feel inner peace. In truth, it is the opposite-only when we cultivate peace, purity and contentment within does the external world begin to reflect it. Just as a lamp cannot spread light unless lit from within, society cannot become peaceful unless individuals awaken to their inner light.

Spiritual studies are often seen as uninteresting and ritualistic, but this is not so. They are as engaging as any other subject, and meditation is simply about reflection, remembrance and feeling. With a little guidance, even a small investment of time can yield rich dividends in the form of contentment and peace.

Today, very few people devote their time, money and energy to harmony in society. It is time we resolve to do so, for a peaceful and harmonious world must begin with each one of us.

The writer is a spiritual educator and popular columnist

PIC TALK



A barbet attempts to catch a honeybee while perched on a tree branch.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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TIME TO REVIVE PARLIAMENT'S CREDIBILITY AND PURPOSE

Parliament, once revered as the supreme forum of democracy, is increasingly losing its vitality and dignity. The sight of empty seats, computers left switched on without use, and lights blazing in deserted halls reflects wasteful expenditure and disregard for public resources. Poor attendance and lack of seriousness among lawmakers have become routine, undermining the very essence of parliamentary functioning. Opposition parties often reduce their role to mere disruption, while treasury benches remain largely passive, showing limited engagement beyond praising the Prime Minister. The absence of top leaders, who skip more sessions than they attend, further erodes credibility and weakens accountability. Citizens expect Parliament to be a space for

debate, constructive policymaking and responsible governance.

Instead, it has become symbolic of neglect and inefficiency, where discussions are overshadowed by walkouts and noise rather than substance. Important Bills are passed without meaningful debate amidst uproar.

Restoring discipline, responsibility and genuine debate is essential if Parliament is to regain respect. Only through active participation, meaningful dialogue and respect for procedure can it reclaim its role as the guardian of democratic values. It is the responsibility of all Members of Parliament to ensure it does not degenerate into redundancy.

O PRASADA RAO | HYDERABAD

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LPG supply concerns rise

In the March 15 update, the Ministry of Petroleum stated that there were "no reported dry-outs at LPG distributorships". However, the Strait of Hormuz, the main route for India's LPG imports, remains forcibly closed by Iran. After talks between the Indian Prime Minister and the Iranian President, Iran granted a special concession, allowing LPG carriers bound for India to pass through the Strait. However, the Iranian Ambassador to India, Mohammad Fathali, declined to specify the number of ships given permission.

Abdul Majid Hakeem Ilahi, representative of Iran's Supreme Leader in India, addressed Indians as "dear brothers and sisters" and stated that the concession reflected the solidarity shown by people towards Iran. It can be inferred that this balanced approach helped secure the concession.

India's LPG storage capacity, estimated between 1.2 and 1.9 MMT, remains unchanged since 2015, while consumption has risen from 17 MMT to 31 MMT. Import dependence has increased to 60 per cent. Countries such as Canada and China maintain significantly higher storage capacities. A comprehensive strategy to address supply disruptions and price volatility is urgently required.

HARIDASAN RAJAN | KERALA

Cheetah project shows progress

Wildlife enthusiasts are understandably euphoric over the birth of five cubs to Jwala, a cheetah at Madhya Pradesh's Kuno Palpur National Park. Asiatic cheetahs had vanished from India by 1950, and the species was declared extinct in 1952.

Low genetic variability and prolonged inbreeding were once cited as causes for their decline, although several wildlife experts argue that this loss occurred thousands of years ago. The more immediate causes were poaching, hunting and habitat destruction.

After initial setbacks, India's cheetah relocation project now appears to be on track. With recent additions, there are currently 53 cheetahs across Kuno National Park and Gandhi Sagar Wildlife Sanctuary. Early planning recognised the importance of restoring suitable grassland and scrub forest habitats.

Attempts to source cheetahs from Iran did not succeed. Subsequently, Kuno National Park, spanning 750 sq km and offering a strong prey base, was identified for reintroduction following approval from the Supreme Court. The recent births signal cautious optimism. Continued scientific monitoring and habitat management will be essential to ensure the long-term success of this ambitious conservation initiative.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Self-identification under threat

The Transgender Persons Amendment Bill, 2026 requires careful scrutiny, as it raises significant concerns regarding constitutional protections and fundamental rights. By replacing self-identification with medical verification, the Bill appears to contradict the Supreme Court's 2014 ruling. Under the proposed amendment, gender recognition would depend on medical verification rather than self-identification. This creates additional procedural barriers for transgender persons seeking identity documents. In a society where transgender individuals often face discrimination, such requirements may further restrict access to education, employment and healthcare.

Supporters argue that clearer definitions are necessary for effective implementation of welfare measures. However, constitutional guarantees must remain paramount. The Supreme Court had affirmed that gender identity is rooted in self-perception and lived experience, and not solely in biological criteria.

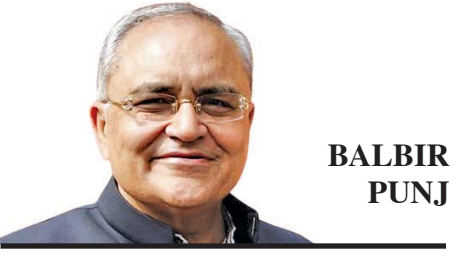
The Bill's emphasis on biological determinism risks undermining this principle. It may inadvertently reverse progress made in recognising the dignity and autonomy of transgender persons.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

An open letter to Rahul Gandhi

India deserves an opposition that challenges the government with seriousness-not slogans; with evidence-not conjecture; with statesmanship-not theatrics. As Leader of the Opposition, you have a rare opportunity to elevate national discourse. That responsibility demands intellectual discipline & historical awareness

FIRST
Column



BALBIR
PUNJ

Dear Rahul ji,

I write with candour, yet with due regard for the office you occupy as Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha. In any parliamentary democracy, this office is not meant merely to oppose, but to scrutinise rigorously, question the government of the day fearlessly, and do so while safeguarding national interest. A mature democracy requires both — a strong government and a credible opposition. When either falters, democratic balance weakens. Unfortunately, I must say that the dignity of the office has declined since your takeover, due to your conduct and statements that appear impulsive, theatrical, and lacking a solid grounding in facts or historical knowledge. My concern is not limited to a single incident. The pattern predates 2014 and indicates a deeper intellectual attitude-one that is sometimes disconnected from historical realities and national sensitivities.

In 2010, diplomatic cables released by WikiLeaks recorded that you told the US Ambassador that radicalised “Hindu groups” posed a “bigger threat” to India than the Pakistani terror outfit Lashkar-e-Taiba-responsible for the horrific 2008 Mumbai 26/11. This disclosure came when India was still scarred by the Godhra train burning, where fifty-nine pilgrims were burnt alive by jihadists.

Yet, instead of confronting Islamist extremism with clarity, a fake counter-narrative of “safron terror” was constructed, even casting suspicion on organisations such as the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh. The 2007 affidavit questioning the historicity of Lord Ram further reflected a disturbing intellectual drift. In a continuity of this disposition, you and your family chose to absent yourselves from the historic 2024 Ram Temple Pran-Pratishtha ceremony at Ram Mandir, Ayodhya.

In 2013, the country witnessed an extraordinary spectacle. During Prime Minister Manmohan Singh’s tenure, you publicly dismissed your party-led Cabinet-approved ordinance as “complete nonsense” that should be “torn up and thrown away.” The ordinance had already been cleared by the Cabinet and the Congress leadership. Democracy welcomes dissent; it also demands institutional respect.

The writer is an eminent columnist, former Chairman of the Indian Institute of Mass Communication (IIMC), and the author of 'Tryst with Ayodhya: Decolonisation of India' and 'Narrative ka Mayajaal'

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 The Pioneer



Where do you get such arrogance? From a sense of entitlement owing to your dynastic roots? More recently, on 13 March last in Lucknow, while commemorating Kanshi Ram’s birth anniversary, you suggested that had Jawaharlal Nehru been alive, Kanshi Ram might have become Chief Minister through the Congress.

The claim surprised many observers-not just because it was speculative, but because it overlooked Kanshi Ram’s political journey and the historic disdain of Congress for dissenting Dalit voices outside its organisational structure. In 1994, I had the opportunity to meet Kanshi Ram several times. Each interaction lasted hours. These meetings were facilitated by a Dalit leader from South India who then served as a minister in the government of P. V. Narasimha Rao and remains associated with your party even today. Kanshi Ram impressed me as a man uniquely dedicated to Dalit empowerment. Unlike many politicians who see power as an end in itself, he viewed political office solely as a tool for social change. Personal ambition did not motivate him. He politely declined an offer to move to Rashtrapati Bhavan, made by Atal Bihari Vajpayee. Ultimately, he trusted his movement to Mayawati, whom he believed could continue the struggle. The analogy you used in your speech-holding a pen vertically to symbolise hierarchy and horizontally to represent equality-was actually Kanshi Ram’s favourite metaphor. I remember him

demonstrating it vividly during our conversations.

Invoking Nehru in this context, however, appeared historically misplaced. Kanshi Ram built his politics precisely because he believed the Congress system had failed Dalits. The historical relationship between Congress leadership and Dr BR Ambedkar also deserves reflection. Kanshi Ram regarded Ambedkar as his greatest inspiration. Yet Ambedkar’s political experience with Congress leaders-particularly Nehru-was marked by sharp tensions.

Nehru had no hesitation in awarding himself the Bharat Ratna in 1955. Ambedkar, the chief architect of India’s Constitution, received the same honour only in 1990-thirty-five years later-under the government of V. P. Singh, which was supported from outside by the Bharatiya Janata Party and the Left. Ambedkar’s entry into the first Cabinet of independent India occurred largely because Mahatma Gandhi insisted that the new government must include distinguished non-Congress figures. Thus, Ambedkar served alongside leaders such as Syama Prasad Mukherjee and Sardar Baldev Singh.

The 1952 general election further highlights the relationship. After resigning from the Cabinet, Ambedkar contested from North Bombay. The Congress fielded Narayan Sadoba Kajrolkar against him. Ambedkar lost by around fourteen thousand votes, while over 75,000 ballots were declared invalid. It was probably the first case of vote chori (theft), scandalising independent India in its very first election to the Lok Sabha. Compounding the hostility, Congress and Communist leaders called Ambedkar a “traitor”. Yet such accusations were

not entirely novel. Writing to Rajkumari Amrit Kaur on 26 January 1946, Nehru himself remarked that Ambedkar had “allied himself with the British Government against the Congress”.

Savita Ambedkar records in her autobiography that Nehru was “keeping a sharp eye on the constituency” during the 1952 election. According to her account, Nehru, S. K. Patil and Dange were determined to ensure Ambedkar’s defeat. Nehru himself appeared jubilant with the outcome. In a letter to Lady Edwina Mountbatten dated 16 January 1952, he wrote: “In Bombay city and to a larger extent in Bombay province, our success has been far greater than expected. Ambedkar has been dropped out.” Rahulji, please ask yourself: Why was Nehru celebrating Ambedkar’s electoral defeat? I am not implying anything, but I wonder why he was happily sharing the news of Ambedkar’s loss with a woman who was the consort of a colonial ruler responsible for planning and executing India’s partition, and had then left Indian shores for her country. Hopefully, you know the answer.

Ambedkar’s anguish is recorded by his biographer Dhananjay Keer in ‘Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar: Life and Mission’. Ambedkar lamented that Congress leaders routinely branded him a “traitor”. In contrast, Mahatma Gandhi once told him: “I know you are a patriot of sterling worth.”

In this context, your recent demand for the Bharat Ratna for Kanshi Ram raises questions about consistency. When Mayawati made the same request in 2008, the Congress-led UPA government rejected it, arguing that such honours should not be subject to lobbying. Why were you silent then? Today, the same demand, raised by you on the eve of Uttar Pradesh elections, seemingly appears insincere and driven by political opportunism. Kanshi Ram himself had little faith in the Congress. In his 1982 book ‘Chamcha Yug’, he accused the party of cultivating “stooge” Dalit leaders who served its interests rather than empowering the community. Your rhetorical framework often echoes familiar ideological clichés about India’s civilisation. This has repeatedly led to judicial corrections. Your remarks linking the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh to Gandhi’s assassination required clarification in court. The “Chowkidar Chor Hai” episode led to an apology to the Supreme Court. Your statements on Vinayak Damodar Savarkar invited judicial caution.

Criticism is legitimate, and indeed a vibrant democracy’s lifeline. However, undermining the nation while trying to criticise the government, echoing external prejudices, and making baseless accusations against political rivals and ideological opponents fall into a different category. It is irresponsible behaviour unworthy of a credible

leader. Your endorsement of foreign criticism describing India as a “dead economy” raised concerns about national disparagement. Your remarks abroad suggesting that “Sikhs may not freely practise their faith in India” were swiftly appropriated by hostile elements. Most alarming was your assertion that your party is fighting not merely the BJP or RSS, but the “Indian State”—a formulation historically invoked by insurgent movements. In 2018, you made an unsubstantiated claim in the Rafale matter, invoking the French President—swiftly contradicted by the French government. In 2017, during the Doklam standoff, you met the Chinese Ambassador, with your party first denying and then admitting the meeting.

During foreign visits, Rahulji, you have expressed concern that Western powers no longer comment on India’s internal affairs and have repeatedly described India as merely a “union of states”—not as a nation. This is less a constitutional observation and more an intellectual stance that diminishes India’s civilisational continuity—a doctrine Gandhiji often emphasised and strived for.

Even recent episodes—such as the conduct of Youth Congress activists at an international forum, followed by your approving remark—suggest a troubling preference for spectacle over seriousness. You have warned that India would “burn” if the BJP returns to power and questioned constitutional stability. After electoral defeats, you and your party have cast doubts on institutions such as the Election Commission. Opposition is legitimate; delegitimising institutions is not.

Your parliamentary conduct has occasionally reinforced perceptions of theatricality—the 2018 embrace of the Prime Minister followed by a wink, or recent public gestures that prioritised superficial optics over substantive politics. Your renewed emphasis on redistribution slogans such as “jitni abaadi, utna haq” raises further concern. History offers a cautionary lesson. Under Indira Gandhi, excessive nationalisation weakened production, fuelled shortages, and culminated in the Indian Emergency. Redistribution without wealth creation destroys the very foundation it seeks to distribute. The test of leadership lies not in applause, but in arguments that withstand scrutiny—historical, judicial, and intellectual.

India deserves an opposition that challenges the government with seriousness-not slogans; with evidence-not conjecture; with statesmanship-not theatrics. As Leader of the Opposition, you have a rare opportunity to elevate national discourse. That responsibility demands intellectual discipline, historical awareness, and an unwavering commitment to the dignity of the Republic. I hope you will reflect — not as a matter of partisan disagreement, but as an appeal to restore seriousness to India’s political conversation.



Unearthing Kerala’s carved legacy: A tribute to sacred woodcraft

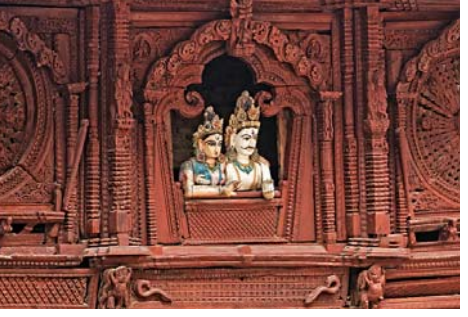


RAGHVENDRA
SINGH

I must, at the outset, concede that I am no art historian. Yes, I am a student of history but not particularly well placed to write a critical review on wooden sculptures in Kerala temples. My workplace experience fortunately exposed me to the marvels of Indian sculpture. A stint as Director General of the National Museum, New Delhi, gave me a wonderful opportunity to learn about Indian architectural masterpieces. It also gave me a chance to witness these artefacts in different museums across India and the world and compare them across time and space. I could not stop myself from embarking on the delightful task of going through the two recent publications on Kerala sculptures by Professor Preeta Nayar and attempting a review. Painstakingly composed, they caught my attention immediately. These two books have been curated imaginatively and explained interestingly, even for a casual reader of this genre. The research done is meticulous. The temple architecture of Kerala is quite distinct from the ‘Dravidian’ and the ‘Nagara’ style. The Kerala temple architectural features manifest the integration of cultural elements from both within and without. It also has its own indigenous features, quite pronounced, for example, a modest structure with a subdued gopuram, lively in style, that merges elegantly with climate-friendly patterns of domestic dwellings, elevating it to a divine status. Timber is the main construction material, with striking wooden artistry as a dominant feature. Sculptural art of Kerala has a tradition of more than a millennium. The two main elements of the sculptural wealth come from the Vaishnava and Shaiva traditions. The lyrical quality of twists and turns in forms, the musical harmony in proportions, the natural artistry in moulding shapes, and the precision in carving anecdotes in finite spaces greatly manifest in the craftsmanship of the godly hands of the woodcarvers of Kerala. They effortlessly impart a gigantic feel to miniature forms and transform expressions of fierce ferocity into subtle aesthetic delight.

The art of Kerala is one of the richest and most exuberant. It is with some hesitation that I venture some reasons for it. Temples in Kerala adhere to a series of strict and closed-door ritualistic traditions with many layers of limitations. These traditions, under normal circumstances, do not permit access to sculptural niches for the purpose of iconographic investigation.

It is against this background that the relevance of the two important publications, “Vaishnava



Sculptures of Kerala: An Iconographic Study” and “Carved Wonders in Wood: Rare Sculptures of Kerala,” authored by Professor Preeta Nayar of the Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, should be viewed. The book on Vaishnava sculptures of Kerala is methodically organised into eight chapters. It begins with the origin and development of Vaishnavism, and traces the historical roots and evolution of this tradition in the state. The next theme covers the cultural perspective and provides a contextual backdrop by examining the social dynamics that influenced the region’s art and architecture. The author thereafter delves into the architectural features of the Hindu temples in Kerala. The various forms of ‘Vishnu’ are examined in detail, represented as they are in the sculptural art of the state. The ‘Dashavatara of Vishnu’ illustrates the ten principal avatars, highlighting their iconographic significance.

This is followed by a lucid analysis of minor avatars of Vishnu, focusing on lesser-known incarnations and their representations. Then there are the composite and associate deities of Vishnu, discussed extensively as per delightful visual representations. The book on Vaishnava sculptures of Kerala provides a comprehensive evaluation of the sculptural forms and their iconographic relevance. It is an in-depth scientific study of Vaishnava sculptures in stone and wood. Informative iconographic descriptions of different forms of Vaishnava sculptures starting with sthanaka (standing), asana (sitting) and shayana (reclining) forms of Vishnu, his major and minor avatars, are all presented aesthetically. It deals with sculptural depictions of many anecdotes (for example, Krishnalila) affiliated with these forms. The work examines the explanations given for these forms in ancient iconographic texts like Vishnudharmottara and evaluates the salient features while indicating the degree of fidelity observed between the texts (shastras) and the images (prayogas).

Morphological features of the icons, like the number of different deities, the attributed symbols they hold and their schematic arrangement, are incisively analysed and classified. The findings in the book sub-regionalise important forms in different geographical areas of the state.



It categorises over 97 basic forms of Vaishnava sculptures, with 120 sub-forms and over 200 other varieties. The study compares these forms with those from northern and other parts of South India, attempting a broader classification and understanding of regional variations.

The visuals and descriptions enhance the understanding of the intricate details and variations within the Vaishnava sculptures of Kerala.

This publication is a pivotal contribution to the understanding of Kerala’s rich sculptural heritage. By intertwining the historical, cultural and iconographic perspective, the book offers a 360-degree framework to appreciate the intricate relationships between the art and architecture of Kerala temples through iconography.

Now I come to the second work of Professor Preeta Nayar, the ‘Carved Wonders in Wood: Rare Sculptures of Kerala’. This too is a beautifully brought-out volume in colour. It takes the readers on a journey through the magnificence of Kerala’s wood carving heritage. It commences with a brief description of the unique architecture of Kerala temples and illustrations of its various architectural components. The rest of the text is a rare treat on the splendour of the ‘least seen and least known’ atypical sculptural forms, depicting 66 themes of Hindu mythology, carefully selected from a multitude of wooden sculptures that richly adorn the sculptural niches of 76 ancient Hindu temples across the state.

The sculptures are described with emphasis on their iconography after narrating the story associated with their respective forms. This is followed by images of specific niches where those sculptures are positioned in the temples, the names of those temples and their location in the state. The contents are supported with 186 original colour photographs, most of them in larger format. The work contains rare forms of cosmic Vishwadeva, Kinnara Shiva, Rakshoghnamurti. Sculptures depicting themes like Vishnu in Yoganidra and the origin of Madhu and Kaitabha, Bhima carrying his family on his shoulder to the Hidimba forest, Kalki in a termitarium, Aghasuravadha, Ashtavakra, rare sculptures with philosophical dimensions like Vighna, and some denoting localised themes like six-breasted Pidari and many other rare images.

Both these publications, significant in their own way, come with references to literature and a glossary of technical terms which make them user-friendly. These two books add immensely to our understanding of the local Kerala tradition in the Indian context. Undoubtedly, it will prove to be an important source of reference for archaeologists, Indologists and art historians.

The writer is a former Secretary, Ministry of Culture, Government of India and an Advisor at Bharat Ki Soch Foundation

 dailypioneer

 @59raghvendra

 The Pioneer

West Asia crisis and the Modi doctrine



ISHAAN
SAXENA

As the conflict in the Middle East continues to escalate unabated, and the US and Israel continue their ferocious campaign against Iran, the world is on tenterhooks. The broad repercussions of this raging war can be felt worldwide, from rising energy costs to the profound implications for the tourism sector. But in the midst of this latest conflagration, which has captivated global attention and headlines, India, under the leadership of Prime Minister Modi, appears to have skillfully navigated a tumultuous environment with great ease. This is a testament to our diplomatic sagacity and the art of dealing with close allies on a plethora of issues, even though our interests diverge on the current problem that is brewing.

Even though Israel and the US are acting in concert to obliterate targets in Iran and its proxies, India has skillfully demonstrated its ability to manoeuvre through this complex web and yet keep its ties intact with the Arab world. Three issues come to mind. First, the balancing act that occurred during the Gaza and Middle East conflict is a masterstroke.

Mr Modi’s visit to Israel was timed at a very crucial juncture. Both Israel and the US could not have launched a coordinated attack on Iran with his presence in the Middle East. When the Prime Minister addressed the Israeli Parliament, he reiterated the strategic partnership between the two nations and the urgent need to further bolster defence and technology ties. The devastating war commenced less than two days after his departure. Terror was condemned in the harshest terms, but India successfully articulated a clear message to Israel: it has deep-rooted economic interests in Iran (the Chabahar Port), and India will not forsake them in light of the current situation. Concurrently, gone are the days when India had to tread a fine line to establish deeper ties with Israel. The message is loud and strident: our national interest comes first.

Second, despite a belligerent Iran that is hell-bent on striking any vulnerable targets in the Middle East, India opened direct talks with Iran to allow the passage of its oil tankers. This again is a manifestation of how intelligent diplomacy works. We have proven to the world that we embrace, empathise and cooperate with Israel, but that does not diminish the nature of our ties with the Middle East.

The cooperation between the two nations has evolved tremendously pursuant to the attacks,

especially in terms of intelligence sharing. Despite the fact that India has condoned the assassination of Ali Khamenei, our national interest in securing our energy needs has prevailed effortlessly in a very precarious security scenario.

Third, America seems to be urging India to purchase Russian oil, which it was vehemently opposing prior to the war. This is to contain surging oil prices. Yes, deep-rooted concerns remain in ongoing trade negotiations that reference environmental and labour standards, but history is a witness that these standards have always been employed to gain an upper hand in trade negotiations. Ever since the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT) in 1948 until the establishment of the World Trade Organisation (WTO) in 1995, Article XX has been invoked under the guise of genuine concern, but the core reason has been protectionism. Throughout modern history, this has been the bone of contention between the developed and developing world, and India will eventually manage to surmount this challenge and sign a successful deal in the coming months. America is too engaged in the Middle East right now to pay close attention to a deal that will be mutually beneficial to both nations. After all, in Trump’s own words, Mr Modi is a very tough negotiator.

So, if anything, the recent unfolding of events has only proved that the Indian economy is slated to outpace the rest of the world. Meanwhile, China’s economic interests have been threatened by the recent bombing campaign on Iran’s Kharg Island. Its air defence systems have proven to be weak. Operation Sindhoor, the abduction of the Venezuelan President, and the attack on Iran point illuminatingly to this indisputable fact. Furthermore, Pakistan’s reluctance to join Saudi Arabia in the war proves that the so-called Islamic NATO is just baloney—a Catch-22 situation. If it joins the war, it will be implicitly endorsing Israel, and if it does not, the Islamic NATO becomes a laughing stock.

India has demonstrated that when interests align, it will constructively engage with all stakeholders, and when they do not, it will follow its national interest. The linear unfolding of events has conveyed a very powerful diplomatic message to the world: we watch quietly and act with purpose when necessary, in the interest of our country. Furthermore, the precision with which we react and activate our diplomatic channels will astonish India’s mightiest adversaries.



The writer is a national security analyst

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